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Happening today

● A PARLIAMENTARY panel has summoned officials of the Education Ministry, National Testing Agency and the CBI.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



REJECTED OFFER OF RS SEAT, NOT INTERESTED IN NATIONAL POLITICS, SAYS SIDDARAMAIAH

Cong's Karnataka slugfest ends: Siddaramaiah out, DK to be CM

New govt may have 2 or 3 Dy CMs, including a Lingayat and a Dalit

Manoj C G & Akram M
New Delhi, Bengaluru, May 28

TWO DAYS after the Congress high command told him to step down, Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Thursday resigned, paving the way for D K Shivakumar to succeed him. The new government may have two to three Deputy CMs. Siddaramaiah's resignation brings curtains down on a protracted tussle for leadership between him and Shivakumar, the state Congress president

and Deputy CM. Siddaramaiah met his Cabinet colleagues for breakfast and told them that he was stepping down as directed by the high command. Shivakumar, who was also present, later accompanied Siddaramaiah to Lok Bhavan.

Since Governor Thawar Chand Gehlot was not in Bengaluru, Siddaramaiah handed over his resignation letter to the Governor's Special Secretary Prabhu Shankar. Addressing a press conference with Shivakumar

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Outgoing Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah with Deputy Chief Minister D K Shivakumar in Bengaluru on Thursday. ANI

E. EXPLAINED

Behind the timing

The tussle between Siddaramaiah and D K Shivakumar finally came to an end due to three factors. First, Siddaramaiah's age — he will be 80 during the 2028 Assembly polls. Second, the BJP's expanding footprint in the North, East and West, which makes it crucial for the Congress to keep it out of the South. Third, the unwritten 2023 pact on power-sharing. [REPORT, PAGE 6](#)



China's Assistant Foreign Minister Hong Lei with Sujit Ghosh, MEA Joint Secretary (East Asia), in Beijing. X@CHINA_AMB_INDIA

Making progress towards normal ties after border peace: India, China

E. EXPLAINED

Series of steps

Ever since the disengagement of troops from friction points in eastern Ladakh, China and India have taken a series of steps to repair ties: reduction in visa curbs, resumption of direct flights, revival of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, easing restrictions on Chinese businesses.

triggered a military standoff six years ago.

Disengagement of troops from friction points was completed in November 2024, a month after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping met in Kazan, Russia. But an estimated 50,000 troops remain deployed in the depth areas on each side of the LAC in the region as the two

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

CLASS 12 BOARD EVALUATION ROW

Firm roped in by CBSE was under scanner for Telangana exam mess; may be fined

Contract was cancelled after glitches in board exam in 2019, also in evaluation

Vidheesha Kuntamalla & Sreenivas Janyala
New Delhi, Hyderabad, May 28

THE CENTRAL Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) is considering imposing a financial penalty on Hyderabad-based vendor Coempt Edutech Pvt Ltd handling its new On-Screen Marking (OSM) system, after thousands of blurred answer-book scans and multiple cases of mismatched answer sheets were found during this year's Class 12 board evaluation process, *The Indian*

INSIDE PAGE 7

PRADHAN: SOME DISCREPANCIES... FOR THIS, I TAKE RESPONSIBILITY

Express has learnt.

Sources said the CBSE has identified 5,000 blurred answer-book scans so far and 23 cases where students received scanned copies belonging to another candidate's answer sheet.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Dhanendra Kumar, first chief of competition panel, dies in AC blast fire at South Delhi home

Pragynesh
New Delhi, May 28

DHANENDRA KUMAR, a retired IAS officer who served as Executive Director at the World Bank and became the first Chairman of the Competition Commission of India, died after a fire, suspected to have been triggered by an explosion in an air conditioner, broke out at his Hauz Khas home in South Delhi Wednesday night, police said Thursday.

Eighty-year-old Kumar was declared dead at the AIIMS Trauma Centre where he was taken after the incident. His son, also hospitalised, was said



Dhanendra Kumar, 80.

to be out of danger.

Senior police officers said the incident took place late Wednesday night on the ground floor of the house where Kumar, his wife and son

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Anand Mohan J
Sidhi (MP), May 28

THEIR AVERAGE age was 26; the youngest was 19. Between April 2025 and March 2026, 53 women died before, during or after childbirth in a single district in Madhya Pradesh. The rising toll had not gone unnoticed — the state's Directorate of Public Health and Medical Education had highlighted it through letters, calls, WhatsApp messages and review meetings. And yet, little changed, with the officials noting that "no improvement was ever made."

Officials had a reason to be worried. India's maternal mortality rate — or deaths per one lakh live births — fell to 87 in the latest Sample Registration System estimates for 2022–24, continuing a long-term national decline. Madhya Pradesh ranked second among the country's worst-performing states in maternal health outcomes, with an MMR of 159,



Among the dead: (top, from left) Taravati Pandey, Divya Singh Baghel, Roshni Kewat and Lalita Rajak; Above: At the maternity ward of the community health centre in Rampur Naikin town of Sidhi district. The district has a maternal mortality rate of 211, significantly higher than the national MMR of 87. ANAND MOHAN J

THE WORLD PAGE 14

IRAN, U.S. TRADE FIRE, AWAIT TRUMP'S NOD ON CEASEFIRE

staff claimed they had to push premium services to meet "sales targets," even sometimes leading applicants to believe that this would "improve their chances" at the visa centre. They echo concerns that European monitors have zeroed in on, a refrain in inspection records of Schengen visa centres in 20 countries obtained by Lighthouse Reports, a non-profit investigative newsroom based in Utrecht, The Netherlands. These were collaboratively investigated by media organisations in 11 countries, including *The Indian Express* in India.

These records flagged a

Twisha death: CBI arrests her retired judge mother-in-law

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, May 28

A DAY after the Madhya Pradesh High Court quashed her anticipatory bail, retired district judge Giribala Singh was arrested by the CBI on Thursday in connection with the death of her daughter-in-law, Twisha Sharma.

The CBI took Giribala Singh into custody after questioning



Twisha Sharma, Giribala Singh

her for several hours at her Bhopal home. The Supreme Court,

which took suo motu cognizance of the case on May 23, had on Monday referred to the Madhya Pradesh government's recommendation for a CBI probe, and said the agency should "immediately" take over the investigation into the 33-year-old model and actor's death.

Twisha was found dead at her matrimonial home in the Bagmugalia locality of Bhopal

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

IPL's anti-graft unit warns against use of smart glasses in restricted zones

Varinder Bhatia
Chandigarh, May 28

THE IPL'S Anti-Corruption and Security Unit (ACSU) has issued a fresh advisory to players and support staff in the on-going edition of the T20 league, warning against the use of smart glasses, sunglasses and goggles equipped with communication and recording technology inside restricted areas on match days, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources said the ACSU, which is responsible for monitoring integrity, preventing spot-fixing and enforcing security protocols in the league, has informed the BCCI that several companies are actively marketing and selling smart eyewear products to players and team personnel participat-

ing in the IPL.

According to sources, the ACSU flagged that these smart devices are capable of live-streaming, sending and receiving text messages, and making audio and video calls through mobile data or Wi-Fi networks, raising concerns over unauthorised communication and potential misuse during matches.

Under the IPL's Player and Match Officials Area (PMOA) Minimum Standards, such devices have been classified as "Audio/Video Recording Devices" and "Communication Devices".

The ACSU has reiterated that possession or use of smart glasses and similar wearable technology is strictly prohibited inside the PMOA. Players and support staff have

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● APPLICANTS SAY ASKED TO PAY FOR SERVICES THEY DIDN'T KNOW WAS OPTIONAL

At VFS centres in Delhi, Mumbai: Bill Rs 15,000, value added services Rs 5,000

Nirbhay Thakur, Sarasvati Thuppadolla, Naresh S & Sandeep Singh
New Delhi, Mumbai, May 28

OUTSIDE VFS Global House on Delhi's KG Marg, the sun bounces off glass facades and onto the crowd under the shade of a bunch of trees. A few hundred metres away at the Shivaji Stadium metro station, another restless line of people clutch plastic folders.

Welcome to the two VFS Global centres in the national capital, where the anxiety is palpable — not just about the

visa but also the "extra" money that, many applicants said, they were asked to pay for services they didn't know was optional.

At these two centres, nearly half of the 85 applicants this newspaper spoke to complained of being "pushed towards" value added services: premium lounge, SMS alerts and courier fees. Two-thirds of over 60 applicants

outside VFS Global's Bandra-Kurla Complex centre in Mumbai spoke about the same pressure.

It's not just applicants. Several current and former VFS

staff claimed they had to push premium services to meet "sales targets," even sometimes leading applicants to believe that this would "improve their chances" at the visa centre.

They echo concerns that European monitors have zeroed in on, a refrain in inspection records of Schengen visa centres in 20 countries obtained by Lighthouse Reports, a non-profit investigative newsroom based in Utrecht, The Netherlands. These were collaboratively investigated by media organisations in 11 countries, including *The Indian Express* in India.

These records flagged a



People waiting outside the VFS Global centre in Bandra-Kurla Complex in Mumbai. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

range of concerns — from how applicants' data is stored on un-

encrypted discs to "lapses" in informing applicants that

value-added services (VAS) are optional and have no link to visa approval.

Responding to the investigation, VFS Global said its services are transparent, tightly audited and "subject to rigorous and continuous government oversight".

In India, Records of Registrar of Companies (RoC) show VAS grew from 6.3% (Rs 25.7 crore) of the company's Rs 408 crore revenue in FY 2015-16 to 17% (Rs 114.7 crore) of Rs 673 crore in FY 2019-20. Between 2016 and 2024, profits rose 20-fold — from Rs 77 crore to Rs 155 crore — as revenue climbed from Rs 411 crore to Rs 1,125 crore.

The company's consolidated accounts in Luxembourg consistently attribute the firm's growth to sales of VAS. Its operating profits have increased four-fold since 2017, reaching 172 million euros in 2024. Over the same period, records show, the company processed just 15% more visas.

The company stopped reporting VAS revenue separately from FY 2020-21, and started sharing break-up of revenue under segments. Yet, a sample of around 2,000 receipts for Swedish visa applications across 16 countries from a two-week period last year — obtained by Lighthouse Reports

through a Freedom of Information (FOI) request — shows VAS accounting for over 30% of revenue.

In the India sample, this was largely driven by premium lounge services, with a 17% take-up rate contributing 21% of VFS revenue. Courier fees were used by 55% of applicants, contributing 12%, while SMS services had a 46% take-up rate, contributing 6%.

Responding to queries on VAS and employees pushing these services, VFS Global said applicants are "clearly informed" online and at visa application centres that they are

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Firefighters try to douse the blaze, in Ajmer on Thursday. ANI

Burning SUV, 4 charred bodies, ‘staged accident’: When a domestic feud turned deadly in Ajmer

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, May 28

JUST AFTER dawn on Thursday, flames rising from a burning Scorpio on a road in Rajasthan’s Ajmer district drew villagers and police personnel to the spot. Inside the vehicle were three charred bodies. A fourth victim was reportedly pulled out of the burning vehicle by a truck driver and later taken to hospital, but was declared dead.

Within hours, investigators would uncover what they describe as a carefully staged crime scene — one that police now say was meant to disguise the murder of an entire family as an accident.

Police have since arrested 45-year-old Sunita, the first wife of former sarpanch Ramsingh Chaudhary, and detained the couple’s 19-year-old daughter and 17-year-old son in connection with the killings of Ramsingh, his mother and former sarpanch Pusi Devi, his second wife Surgyan Devi, and his niece.

The incident took place in Shrirampur village under Borad police station limits around 5.30 am on Thursday.

According to Ajmer SP Harshvardhan Agarwala, investigators believe the four victims were killed inside their house during the night before, and their bodies were transported in the vehicle, which was set ablaze around 500 metres away.

“As per the information received, Ramsingh frequently

consumed alcohol and there was domestic violence involving the first wife and children. He had married his second wife in 2017 and had two children with her. We found information that there was a fight in the family on Wednesday, after which the accused allegedly planned the killings,” Agarwala said.

Police said the victims were allegedly attacked with sharp-edged farming tools available at the house and nearby fields.

Investigators believe that after the murders, the bodies were loaded into the rear compartment of the Scorpio. The accused then allegedly siphoned diesel from a tractor parked at the residence before the vehicle was driven away and set on fire.

At around 6 am, police received information about a vehicle engulfed in flames on Shrirampur road.

What initially appeared to be a tragic accident began unraveling as forensic teams examined the scene. Blood stains found at multiple locations inside the house and other circumstantial evidence pointed investigators toward members of family itself.

According to police, after allegedly setting the vehicle on fire, the daughter and mother returned home while the minor son later joined them there.

Police said sustained questioning and forensic evidence eventually led investigators to reconstruct the sequence of events. The case remains under investigation.

‘She fought for her life’: Gujarat woman killed during ‘attempted robbery’ in Canada

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, May 28

VIDHI MEDHA’S family last spoke to her over a video call on May 14. For nearly two weeks, they tried reaching out to Vidhi, who had moved to Canada for education four years ago, from their home in Borsad in Gujarat’s Anand district.

Neither did their phone calls get through, nor were their texts ‘delivered’. On Wednesday afternoon, her anxious parents learned that Vidhi was stabbed to death during an attempted robbery in Canada’s Niagara region on May 15.

Vidhi, 22, died on the spot after she was allegedly attacked with a knife in the city of St. Catharines on May 15, according to Niagara police. However, she fought her attacker and injured him, her father Kalpesh Medha said, citing district officials and police. “We were told that she (Vidhi) was stabbed to death on the spot... But she tried her best to fight back and save herself. She succumbed to severe injuries, but she also injured her attacker...”

According to her family, Vidhi was pursuing business management in Hamilton, a port city in Canada’s Ontario province, while also working part-time to support herself. She had also enrolled in a “personal support worker” (PSW) honours course. They said she had moved to St. Catharines just 15 days before the incident.

Vidhi’s father said the family thought that their daughter might have gone away on an ‘excursion’ and, therefore, was unreachable. “When we kept trying to contact her and the text messages went undelivered, we thought she may have gone on some excursion somewhere without connectivity, but we were anxious... We had no idea about what happened to our daughter,” Kalpesh said. Vidhi had spoken to her father just a day before the attack.



Vidhi Medha

Excited and hopeful, she told him that she was preparing to apply for a work permit and permanent residency in Canada after completing her education.

“She had shifted from Hamilton to St. Catharines about fifteen days before the incident... So, maybe, people there were not that familiar with her. She was determined to become independent and create a secure future for herself and her loved ones...” Kalpesh added.

The family has appealed to the Indian government to help bring Vidhi’s remains back to India for the final rites. Kalpesh also demanded a stronger protection mechanism for Indian students living abroad.

As per a May 18 release of Niagara Regional Police Service (NRPS), the officers of the “1 District (St. Catharines/Thorold) (on May 15) had responded to a residence in the area of Lakeshore Road and Lake Street in the city of St. Catharines for reports of two people without vital signs. Upon arrival, one adult female was located deceased within the residence. An adult male was transported to a local hospital for treatment.”

The Canadian police then released another statement stating that the attacker, Joshua St Omer, a 40-year-old from St. Catharines, had been arrested for second-degree murder.

Gujarat cabinet minister and Borsad MLA Raman Solanki visited the grieving family and offered his condolences.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Siddaramaiah

later, Siddaramaiah said he had resigned as the high command had asked him to do so. He said he had maintained in the past that he would resign as CM whenever the Congress leadership asked him. “I voluntarily resigned when they asked me to,” he said, adding that he would continue in active politics.

Asked about the high command’s offer to him to shift to national politics by taking up a Rajya Sabha seat, he said, “I humbly rejected the offer saying that I am not interested in national politics. People (of my constituency) have elected me for five years. There are still two years left in my tenure. I neither chased money nor craved building properties. My political life is an open book,” he said.

He left for Delhi to meet Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, and Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi. However, inclement weather in the national Capital forced Siddaramaiah’s plane to land in Jaipur. Shivakumar, too, was on his way to Delhi. The two leaders are set to meet the high command on Friday. A meeting of the Congress Legisla-

ture Party will be convened upon their return to Bengaluru, either on Friday or Saturday.

Signalling that he was not walking into the sunset anytime soon, Siddaramaiah said, “Till my last breath, I will fight against communal forces. Because the Constitution opposes it (communalism). If there were no Constitution, I wouldn’t be literate, an MLA, Deputy CM, or CM. I would have been a shepherd or farmer.” In a social media post, he wrote, “Till my last breath, I will continue to fight for social justice and stand against divisive communal forces that go against the spirit of our Constitution. Thank you for your love, trust and companionship through every step of this journey.”

The breakfast meeting Siddaramaiah had with his Cabinet colleagues at his official residence, saw some of them turning emotional. Excise Minister R B Thimmapur said many ministers were emotional after the CM made his announcement. Labour Minister Santosh Lad, known for his outspoken demeanor, was seen shedding tears as he left the meeting.

Siddaramaiah stuck to tradition at the press conference and

did not reveal who would succeed him, saying the party leadership and CLP would announce the decision. By evening, AICC general secretary (Organisation) K C Venugopal released photographs of Shivakumar hugging Siddaramaiah and seeking his blessings by touching his feet. “Party above self, people above power, because for Congress, the party is our family and the people are the purpose,” he posted.

Shivakumar is set to take over with two to three Deputy CMs. Satish Jharkiholi, sources said, could be the new Karnataka Congress president, replacing Shivakumar, who has been holding the post since 2020. Hailing from an ST community from Belagavi in North Karnataka, he will be a counterweight to Shivakumar.

Sources said the high command had started finalising the Cabinet even before the official announcement of Shivakumar’s name so that he doesn’t have a completely free hand in the selection of ministers that could antagonise the Siddaramaiah faction. So there will be two to three Deputy CMs, keeping in mind the caste and regional equations. Sources said there would be one Deputy CM each from the Lingayat and Dalit communities. Shivakumar hails

from the Vokkaliga community. And if Siddaramaiah insists on making his son Yathindra a Deputy CM, the number will rise.

M B Patil, one of the prominent Lingayat faces of the Congress and now the Minister for Large and Medium Scale Industries, is learnt to be the front-runner to be a Deputy CM. A Siddaramaiah loyalist, he could also be in the running for state Congress president if he refuses to join the Shivakumar Cabinet. Home Minister G Parameshwara, a former state Congress president, could be another Deputy CM. He is Dalit.

Sources said the high command was not averse to making Yathindra a Deputy CM or a minister as it would only ensure stability of the Shivakumar government. Sources said Gandhi was keen to ensure that the new Cabinet has more representation for the Ahinda, an acronym in Kannada for a coalition of the Alpasankhyataru (Minorities), Hindulidavaru (Backward Classes), and Dalitaru (Dalits).

Siddaramaiah, a Kuruba, was the only CM from a backward class community that the Congress had. He assiduously worked on building the Ahinda support base. The high command is learnt to be keen that the entire Cabinet take the oath of office with Shivakumar.

India, China

countries move to restore ties.

In an official statement Thursday on the 35th meeting of the WMCC in Beijing, the Ministry of External Affairs said, “The discussions were constructive and forward looking. The two sides reviewed the situation in the India-China border areas. They expressed satisfaction with the progress made in maintaining peace and tranquility in the border areas, which has enabled progress towards gradual normalization of bilateral relations.”

The Indian delegation was led by Sujit Ghosh, Joint Secretary (East Asia), while Hou Yanqi, Director General of the Boundary & Oceanic Affairs Department of the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs, led the Chinese delegation. Ghosh had earlier served as Director (China) and was India’s Deputy High Commissioner in the UK. Hou Yanqi was China’s Ambassador to Nepal (2018 to 2022). So, both officials have a background in dealing with the border issues between India and China.

Xu Feihong, China’s Ambassador to India, in a post on X, said, “Both sides conducted constructive dialogue in a practical and friendly atmosphere and ac-

knowledge that the border area maintained lasting peace and tranquility.”

“The two sides held discussion on boundary delimitation, border management, mechanism development and cross-border communication and cooperation, and agreed to keep communication through diplomatic and military channels, maintain peace... in the border area and actively prepare for the 25th Round of Talks between the Special Representatives of China and India on the Boundary Question,” Xu said.

While these remarks echoed Delhi’s statement on the border issues, the Chinese statement did not mention the issue of trans-border river cooperation which was flagged by the MEA.

“The two sides discussed issues pertaining to delimitation, border management, mechanism building and cross-border cooperation,” the MEA said, adding that the “Indian side stressed on early meeting of the next Expert Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers” — a reference to the Brahmaputra.

It said “both sides agreed to maintain regular exchanges and contacts at the diplomatic and

military levels through mechanisms including those that were agreed as part of outcomes of 24th SR Talks”. This was a reference to the outcomes of talks between the Special Representatives, NSA Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, held on August 19, 2025 in New Delhi, days before Prime Minister Modi’s visit to Tianjin, China, for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit.

During the Doval-Wang talks, the two sides had agreed to utilise the border management and control mechanisms through diplomatic and military channels. The outcomes included an expert group under the WMCC to explore early harvest in boundary delimitation, a working group to advance effective border management for peace in the border areas, general level mechanisms in Eastern Sector (Arunachal Pradesh) and Middle Sector (Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand), in addition to the existing general level mechanism in the Western Sector (Ladakh).

The MEA statement also said, “The two sides agreed to work together to make substantive preparation for the next meeting of the Special Representatives (SR), to be held in China.” This means that NSA Doval will travel to China later this year.

IPL

been instructed to deposit such devices with Security Liaison Officers, along with their mobile phones and smart watches, before entering restricted zones on match days. Sources said failure to comply would amount to a breach of PMOA protocols and could invite penalties under operational regulations.

“With wearable technology becoming more sophisticated and concerns growing over covert communication methods, the ACSU’s latest crackdown underlines the league’s attempt to stay ahead of evolving integrity risks during one of world cricket’s most commercially significant tournaments,” sources said.

The latest directive comes amid a series of heightened vigilance measures introduced by ACSU during the current season.

On May 8, *The Indian Express* reported that the unit had flagged the presence of unauthorised persons in team dug-outs following which the BCCI sent an advisory to all IPL teams and called a meeting of CEOs of all franchises to remind them of the protocol. The ACSU had also flagged concerns over vaping and smoking-related transgressions.

Dhanendra Kumar

and two domestic workers were present. DCP (South) Anant Mittal said, “At 11.18 pm Wednesday, a PCR call regarding a fire at House No. R-15, Hauz Khas was received at the Hauz Khas police station. Police and the Fire Service responded immediately. Two fire tenders extinguished the blaze.”

Delhi Fire Service officers said the fire broke out in an indoor unit of an AC on the ground floor of the three-storey house. It soon spread to wooden articles kept on the ground floor, and reached the window panes on the first floor. Two fire tenders were rushed to the spot.

DCP Mittal said, “Two persons were shifted to hospital, including Dhanender Kumar, 80, a retired IAS officer. He succumbed to smoke inhalation during treatment at the AIIMS Trauma Centre. His son is under treatment and is stated to be out of danger.”

Officers said electrical inspectors were looking into the possible reasons for the AC blast, including short-circuit and overheating.

“Running an AC for long hours at minimum temperatures like 18 degrees celsius consumes a lot of energy, and can lead to the unit overheating. What could have been the issue in this case will be clear once the electrical inspectors send a report,” a police officer said.

Kumar, a 1968-batch IAS officer from the Haryana cadre, held several key positions in the state and Central governments. He served as Principal Secretary to Haryana Chief Minister, Secretary in the Ministry of Defence, Ministry of Road Transport and Highways and Ministry of Culture. He became the first Chairman of the Competition Commission of India in 2009.

employees had monthly targets to pitch VAS for which they would earn at least Rs 100 on every combination of SMS and Courier sold.

A current VFS Delhi employee, who has been working with the company for four years in the Schengen unit, said there is an incentives system linked to the sale of value added services. While employees are not informed of the exact percentage distribution of the amount earned from these sales, he said that on average he earns around Rs 7,000 to Rs 8,000 every month as incentives.

In Mumbai, the same playbook

At the VFS Global centre in Mumbai, the same pattern plays out. A 27-year-old applying for an Italy visa watched his bill climb from Rs 9,000 to Rs 15,000. “They kept adding things like SMS, courier, and then the

CBSE evaluation

It was the first time the fully digital evaluation system was used by the CBSE for Class 12 results, involving over 98 lakh answer books belonging to over 18 lakh students.

Official sources told *The Indian Express* Thursday that a CBSE committee will assess the extent of the scanning errors and determine the penalty amount based on the number of affected answer books.

A day after senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi questioned the choice of Coemtp and claimed it had a chequered past, an official said the firm handles large-scale digital evaluation work in several states, including Telangana, Karnataka and West Bengal, and was financially competitive.

However, Coemtp’s performance has been called into question before. In 2019, then known as Globarena Technologies Private Limited, the firm was linked to a data processing failure in Telangana after over 3 lakh students out of nearly 9.74 lakh who gave the state board Intermediate or Class 12 exams failed to clear it. After 18 students were reported to have died by suicide in the week following the Telangana Board of Intermediate Education (TSBIE) results, the BRS government cancelled the contract with Globarena.

President of Telangana Parents’ Association N Narayana asked how academically bright students got 5 or 10 marks in some subjects, hundreds were “marked absent” despite appearing for the exams, and that one girl student’s marks went up from 0 to 99 in Telugu on re-evaluation. Former TSBIE commissioner Syed Omer Jaleel told *The Indian Express* that Globarena, hired by the board to perform exam functions similar to the CBSE Class 12 test now, had used “untested and uncertified software”.

Soon after, Globarena Technologies Pvt Ltd had shifted its operations to its sister concern, Coemtp Edutech Pvt Ltd.

A probe team set up by the Telangana government later said in its report that “pressure” to declare results may have led to the errors. Many evaluators were also assigned duty for the Telangana Assembly polls and did the job hastily, the three-member committee said.

As per the panel, this rush led to mistakes such as 08 marks for a student instead of 88, or 00 instead of 99. The report held Globarena accountable for “minor technical mistakes”, and did not blame anyone for the glitches.

Incidentally, of the 3.82 lakh who failed the TSBIE exam, only 1,183 passed on re-evaluation.

G Jagdish Reddy, who was the Telangana Education Minister at the time, told *The Indian Express* that the TSBIE had entrusted exam enrolment and result processing to Globarena for streamlining the process. “At that time it appeared they had the required software and technology. But mistakes were made, which cost the students dearly. So we decided not to utilise their services again.”

On why the firm had not been blacklisted — which has been cited by the authorities now as defence of Coemtp — Reddy said: “There was a court case going on so we could not blacklist the firm at that time.”

Then Globarena and now Coemtp CEO VNS Raju told *The Indian Express* that what happened was the result of a few minor glitches, which were rectified. “We did not commit any large-scale blunder as is being alleged.”

But, before that, in 2010, Jawaharlal Nehru Technological University-Kakinada (JNTU-K)

in Andhra Pradesh filed a cheating and criminal breach of trust case against Globarena over a Rs 20 crore contract to automate the university’s examination systems and to provide e-content. In its FIR, JNTU-K accused Globarena of substandard services, below average content, and not paying service tax.

The investigation by the Vigilance wing of the university also questioned how JNTU-K had awarded the contract to Globarena although the company had no evidence of previous experience of this. JNTU-K consequently withheld all payments to Globarena, though the firm got a “no arrest” order by the court. The case is still going on.

In November 2023, JNTU Hyderabad shortlisted Coemtp Education Pvt Ltd along with Magnetic Infotech for digitising of answer scripts and for an on-screen digital evaluation system. Magnetic Infotech was linked to Coemtp as a consortium partner.

CBSE contract

The CBSE approved Coemtp’s OSM system at a meeting of its Governing Body in June last year. Members were told that digital evaluation would reduce errors and impurity in region-wise evaluation, and make the examination protocol stronger.

Going by the minutes of the meeting, “members (of the Governing Body) suggested that the on-screen marking may be implemented only after completion of pilot projects in some subjects across the various Regional Offices of the Board”. However, this was not done, and a dry run of the OSM evaluation was conducted in January in only five schools. Based on recommendations from the three-day process, the system was updated.

The exam process

For the Class 12 exam, Coemtp scanned, uploaded and evaluated digitally nearly 1 crore answer books of over 18 lakh students. CBSE sources said answer books were checked multiple times during scanning and uploading, and evaluators had the option to reject illegible or blurred scans during marking.

The controversy emerged after students who sought access to the scanned copies of their answer books flagged blurred answer sheets, missing pages, and, in some cases, that another student’s answer book was showing up as theirs. After this, the CBSE’s payment system for reevaluation also collapsed, deducting additional payments in some cases and smaller-than-required amounts in others.

Officials told *The Indian Express* on May 23 that 2.94 lakh applications had been received for 8.56 lakh answer books this time — more than twice the number last year. At least partly, the demand was driven by a lower proportion of 90% and above overall scores this time.

In its defence, the board cited this “unprecedented traffic” as well as claimed “attempts of unauthorised interference”.

On the choice of Coemtp, officials said the tendering process had been conducted by the CBSE and the company had emerged as the lowest bidder. A source said the CBSE paid Rs 25 per copy for scanning and software work for a 40-page answer booklet, compared to the second bidder’s offer of Rs 60.

The mismatches, according to an official, likely occurred during the masking stage of the evaluation process, when roll numbers are concealed before answer sheets are sent to evaluators. Sources said that rather than the OSM technology, the problem lay in isolated human lapses during implementation.

processing time. I was still called based on the same queue as everyone else. They gave you the impression that premium means faster movement, but in reality, it’s just a different seating area,” he said.

A 35-year-old, heading to Germany on a tourist visa, re-plays the pressure that many describe. “It was technically called optional, but it was said in a way that made it feel like if I opted for these services, my process would be faster and there would be less chance of rejection or delays. I didn’t actually want to spend on any of this, but I also didn’t want to risk complications after going through the entire application process. So I ended up paying, even though it clearly felt unnecessary and more like pressure than value,” he said.

(SARASVATI THUPPADOLLA IS AN INVESTIGATIVE REPORTER WITH LIGHTHOUSE REPORTS)



The single-storey house in Central Delhi's Rajinder Nagar. EXPRESS

Two elderly women found dead at home, no signs of struggle or forced entry: Cops

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 28

TWO DAYS after she left preparing tea for two octogenarian sisters-in-law, a domestic help returned to the single-storey house in Central Delhi's New Rajinder Nagar on Thursday morning to clean the porch as she did every day. But she noticed something unusual: A strong foul smell was emanating from the shut doors of the house. Alarmed, she alerted the neighbours, who informed the police.

When a police team entered the house, they found the two women dead in a room. "One body was found lying on a bed, while the other was on the floor," DCP (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh said. The untouched tea cups still remained where they had been left.

"The help had prepared tea for them and served it the day before yesterday," Joint Commissioner of Police (Central) Madhur Verma said. "The tea cups were still lying there as they were, and no signs of struggle or forced entry were found."

The deceased were identified as Chandra Kanta and Saroj Bala, both aged around 80. While Saroj Bala was unmarried, Chandra Kanta was her sister-in-law. Both women had reportedly been living together at the house for several years.

The crime team, Forensic Science Laboratory team and CAT ambulance were called to the spot. Both women were declared dead after examination by the CAT ambulance staff.

During inspection, police said they found no signs of forced entry, ransacking or dis-

turbance inside the house, which has four entry points. Neighbours also did not indicate any suspicion of foul play, they added.

Proceedings under Section 194 (police to enquire and report on suicide) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita have been initiated and both bodies sent to RML Hospital for post-mortem examination, said police.

"The remaining details will become clear only after the post-mortem examination reports," the Joint CP said.

Inside the New Rajinder Nagar locality, not many knew the two women. "I have seen them a couple of times. Mostly just one of them, standing on the porch. They kept to themselves. The other lady couldn't move. But I didn't know their names," said a resident.

A cleaner, Sanjay, who has been working in the colony for years, said the last time he saw one of the women was about 10 days ago. "She boarded an e-rickshaw near her house to go somewhere. They didn't talk much," he said.

Police said the women had two domestic helps – one who cleaned the porch and another who cleaned the house. While the one cleaning the house was on leave, the help who cleaned the porch came daily. She was the one who noticed the smell.

"Saroj was a retired employee of DESU, while Chandrakanta used to be a teacher at a school in Punjab. None had any children," said an officer.

"They have some extended family living in Rajouri Garden and we have informed them about the postmortem proceedings," the officer added.

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, May 28

SPEED UP trial in cases where accused are caught red-handed, draw up heatmaps to flag hot-spots where neighbourhood disputes are frequently reported, and ensure legal follow-up in road rage cases: Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha has issued a slew of directions to the Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCPs) across 15 districts of the Capital to fast-track criminal investigation, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Under the new order, investigating officers must file chargesheets within seven to 15 days of arrest in the cases where the accused has been caught red-handed, such as snatching incidents. After this, fast-track trial proceedings should be ac-

tively pursued, the police chief said. The target, laid down in directions issued by Golchha, is part of a broader push to accelerate investigations and secure convictions, said officers.

The directives were issued in the Crime Review Meeting held last week, according to officers.

With court trials dragging forever in a majority of cases, there has been a mounting pressure to improve conviction rates and fast-track criminal investigations, said officers. In the last two weeks, at least 10 to 15 'quick-chargesheet' cases have been finalised, filed and pushed toward trial, officers added.

Senior officers have been instructed to monitor compliance closely. Joint Commissioners of Police have been tasked with reviewing districtwise progress every fortnight and report di-

•Speedy trial after being caught 'red-handed'

● **Conviction in 12 days** after accused Mohammad Adil (22) caught on May 12 in Gandhi Nagar Market, New Delhi, for snatching taxi driver's phone

● **Conviction in 10 days** after accused Fahim held on May 16 for robbing Rs. 80,000, jewellery from a house in West Delhi's Palam

rectly to the CP's office. "The message is simple: disposals cannot slow down," said an officer familiar with the implementation of the directives, ad-

ding, "Every fortnight, numbers have to go up."

The focus is not limited to filing chargesheets. In another set of directions, investigating officers have been asked to coordinate closely with public prosecutors to maximise conviction outcomes in contested trials. Acquittals have to be personally reviewed by district DCPs to identify "systemic investigation lapses", Golchha directed.

He also directed that the high volume of PCR calls linked to quarrels and neighbourhood disputes across Delhi must be constantly reviewed. District units have been asked to prepare detailed monthly analyses of quarrel-related calls, mapping call volumes, geographical concentration, time-of-day patterns and repeat callers, and heatmap to identify "hotspots".

Repeated complainants and habitual offenders are to be tracked through data analysis, the direction mentioned.

The instructions also called for 'red-flagging' individuals involved in repeated complaints over time.

"Officers are expected to initiate preventive legal action from the second recurring complaint onward. Road rage incidents received special mention in the directives, with orders that such calls should not be closed as routine quarrels without legal follow-up," the directive stated.

The push extended to surveillance too. CCTV footage from identified hotspots has to be proactively collected, preserved and reviewed in all significant cases. PCR calls have also to be sub-classified by loca-

tion, recurrence and timing to identify 'underlying socio-spatial factors'.

One data point has appeared to shape deployment strategy more than others: the bulk of quarrel-related PCR calls, the documents noted, are received between 8 pm and midnight. All districts are instructed to increase police presence during those hours, with time-specific deployment plans.

On paper, the directives reflect a policing model built on speed, data analysis and preventive enforcement. But several officers said the cumulative effect was a culture where numerical compliance became central to day-to-day functioning. Said another officer, "Eventually, targets stop looking administrative, and begin shaping decisions on the ground."



Eid Mubarak

Devotees offer prayers at Jama Masjid on the occasion of Bakrid in New Delhi on Thursday. ABHINAV SAHA

Minister promises 'greener future', trials of hydrogen fuel cell buses set to begin

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 28

DELHI MAY soon see hydrogen-powered public buses. As part of a next-generation green mobility initiative, the Delhi government is going to operationalise two hydrogen fuel cell buses on trial basis in coordination with Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC), NTPC Limited and other stakeholders, Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said on Thursday.

"Delhi is steadily moving towards clean mobility solutions.

Hydrogen fuel technology represents an important step in our journey towards environmentally responsible transport systems. Through collaboration with organisations such as NTPC, we are exploring innovative pathways to introduce advanced zero-emission technologies that can strengthen the public transport network while contributing to a greener future," the Minister said.

The initiative, he said, aims to introduce advanced hydrogen fuel cell technology into Delhi's public transport

ecosystem, complementing the city's clean mobility transition.

Hydrogen fuel cell buses are globally recognised for zero tail-pipe emissions, and potential to significantly reduce the environmental footprint of large metropolitan transit systems, said officials.

As part of the proposed operational framework, an initial deployment of hydrogen fuel cell buses is being undertaken in coordination with NTPC. The buses are proposed to operate under the Gross Cost Contract (GCC) model, with DTC facilitat-

ing operational deployment.

The DTC is working on a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with state-owned NTPC Limited, which will provide the buses under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative. Officials said that operational expenditure at approved GCC rates would be borne by DTC, while support for costs beyond the GCC framework is being explored through NTPC's CSR support mechanism and other appropriate arrangements in consultation with the concerned agencies.

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New Delhi

TAKES OVER FROM SACHDEVA

Union Minister, Punjabi face: Harsh Malhotra is Delhi BJP's new president



Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra with outgoing party president Virendra Sachdeva and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, at the BJP office on Thursday. AMIT MEHRA

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, May 28

HARSH MALHOTRA, Minister of State for Road Transport & Highways and Corporate Affairs, who has been appointed the new Delhi BJP chief, took over from outgoing state president Virendra Sachdeva on Thursday in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

"The responsibilities in the BJP are like a 400-m relay race, and Virendra Sachdeva ji handed over the baton of responsibility to me today... I pledge that with the support of thousands of BJP workers and the guidance of the leadership, I would make every possible effort to strengthen the party and accelerate the work of the Delhi Government," Malhotra told mediapersons at the BJP office.

"All former state presidents, under whose guidance I had worked, are present today to bless me... After 27 years, the BJP formed a government in Delhi and Rekha Gupta became the CM. This achievement was the result of the hard work of thousands of BJP workers and the inspirational leadership of outgoing president Virendra Sachdeva..." he said, while also thanking Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah and BJP national president Nitin Nabin.

Besides the CM, the event was attended by Delhi Ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Manjinder Singh Sirsa and Ashish Sood, MPs Manoj Tiwari and Bansuri Swaraj, as well as senior leaders and party workers.

Sachdeva, meanwhile, said, "Delhi today has a successful BJP government working with strong principles, and it is now the responsibility of new president Harsh Malhotra to take those works and principles to even greater heights... He possesses extensive administrative experience as mayor, MP, and minister, along with long organisational experience."

"I have full confidence that Malhotra would guide and support all Delhi BJP workers and colleagues in the same spirit as Sachdeva ji and continue to keep everyone united as one family," the CM added.

With Punjab elections and MCD elections ahead, BJP has fielded its Punjabi faces in key roles and leadership roles. The party has two Punjabis in Delhi cabinet — Manjinder Singh

Sirsa, a Sikh leader and Ashish Sood, a Mona Punjabi. Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu is also a Sikh face from BJP, besides Sirsa.

"As the new Delhi BJP chief, his immediate challenge will be leading the party in the MCD elections next year. Another key task would be ensuring coordination between the party organisation and the Delhi Government," a senior leader said.

Senior leaders also believe that Malhotra's role as Union MoS for Road Transport and Highways and Corporate Affairs could help expedite infrastructure projects in Delhi. "He is known for being non-rebel, calm and taking everyone along," said one leader.

Malhotra has been a long-time worker of the BJP and was active in municipal politics before the party fielded him from its East Delhi stronghold in the last Lok Sabha election. He was the general secretary of the Delhi BJP when he was picked to contest the seat represented by Gautam Gambhir, the former India cricketer and head coach of the national side, in 2024.

He won 52.33% of the total vote, defeating Kuldeep Kumar, the AAP leader who is currently the MLA from Kondli. He polled 6,64 lakh votes against Kumar's 5.71 lakh votes, a victory margin of 93,663 votes.

While Malhotra's margin of victory was the smallest in terms of vote share among the seven BJP MPs who were elected to Lok Sabha from Delhi, he became the only MP from Delhi to become a part of the Union Council of Ministers in PM Modi's third term. In 2025, he was given responsibilities in West Bengal ahead of Assembly polls.

Malhotra, who studied law at Delhi University, is known as a loyal "organisation man". An active volunteer of RSS and ABVP, Malhotra began his political journey in late 1980s from as a member of BJP Yuva morcha and entered active politics in 1991.

Over the years, he has held several organisational positions, including Yuva Morcha Mandal president, district Yuva Morcha secretary and district general secretary (organisation). He became BJP district president in 2007 and later served as Delhi BJP general secretary. He became the Mayor of East Delhi Municipal Corporation in 2015.

After days of punishing heat, temperature plunges 10-15°C as rain lashes Delhi-NCR

Rewari in Haryana sees hailstorm, gusts up to 60 kmph in Delhi's Palam; relief likely to continue

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, May 28

DELHI-NCR recorded a sharp fall in temperatures — from around 10-12 degrees Celsius in parts of the Capital and Gurgaon to up to 15 degrees Celsius in Haryana's Charkhi Dadri and 20 degrees Celsius in state's Mahendragarh — after thunderstorms, rain and strong winds brought a respite from days of punishing heat on Thursday evening. The much-needed weather shift came after India Meteorological Department (IMD) sounded multiple alerts through the evening, warning of intense thunderstorm activity.

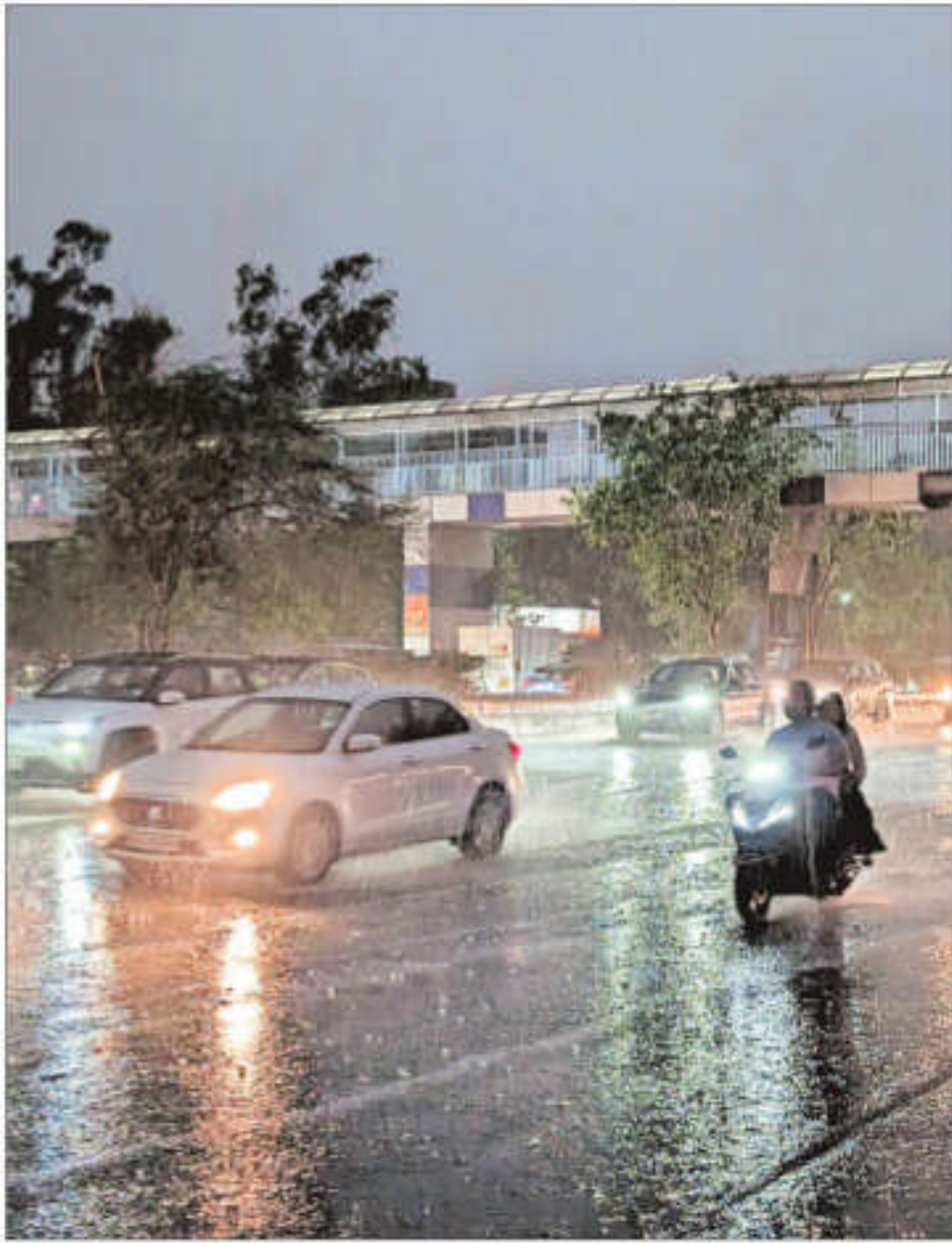
While Rewari in Haryana saw hailstorm activity, Hindon in Ghaziabad and Gurgaon recorded nearly 20 mm rainfall each till around 7.15 pm. On the other hand, Delhi's base station, Safdarjung, recorded 3.3 mm of rainfall while Palam logged 3 mm.

Across the Capital, a majority of weather stations witnessed a temperature drop of around five degrees Celsius. Ayanagar witnessed an 11-degree Celsius fall, Mehrauli around 10 degrees Celsius and Narayana around 6 degrees Celsius. Gurgaon recorded a fall of nearly 12 degrees Celsius.

Strong gusty winds accompanied the thunderstorm activity. Palam recorded wind speeds of up to 61 kmph. Pusa logged gusts of 52 kmph while Safdarjung and Pitampura recorded wind speeds touching 37 kmph.

According to IMD scientists, the thunderstorm activity was triggered by a combination of meteorological factors, including intense surface heating over Northwestern India over the past several days, interaction of a western disturbance with moisture-laden easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal, and mid-level westerly winds.

Maximum temperature ranged between 42-45 degrees Celsius over the past several days in the Capital. The IMD



A road in Delhi during showers; vehicles stuck in traffic near Gaur Chowk in Greater Noida West on Thursday. SHREYA SINGHAI & PTI

said heatwave to severe heatwave conditions prevailing over large parts of Northwest India are likely to abate significantly from Thursday onward.

However, isolated pockets over Rajasthan, Vidarbha and east Madhya Pradesh may continue to experience heatwave conditions briefly before easing further from Friday.

Officials said an unusually high concentration of moisture-bearing easterlies from the Bay of Bengal was observed over the Capital and adjoining areas, creating favourable conditions for intense thunderstorm development, squally winds and isolated hailstorms.

IMD senior scientist Krishna Mishra said humidity levels rose sharply due to a shift in wind direction from dry westerlies to moist easterlies.

"The dew point increased significantly, from around 6 degrees Celsius on Wednesday to nearly 21 degrees Celsius on

• Skywatch



Forecast: May 29, 2026

Generally cloudy sky, a spell of light rain likely

MAX: 35-37

3.4°C below normal

MIN: 22-24

4.6°C above normal

• **Sunrise:** 5:25 AM (May 30)

• **Sunset:** 7:13 PM (May 29)

• **Moonrise:** 5:39 PM (May 29)

• **Moonset:** 4:13 AM (May 30)

• AQI Tracker



Anand Vihar

Poor

AQI: 267



ITO

Moderate

AQI: 169



IGI Airport

Moderate

AQI: 169



Bawana

Poor

AQI: 246

● Good (0-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

NCR over the next three days. According to the IMD forecast bulletin, Delhi is likely to witness generally cloudy skies along with spells of light rain, thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds till at least May 31.

On Friday, wind speeds during intense spells may continue to reach 60-70 kmph, gusting up to 80 kmph, especially during morning and afternoon hours.

Similar thunderstorm activity accompanied by light rain and gusty winds of 40-50 kmph has been forecast for May 30 and 31 as well.

The IMD has also forecast a sharp fall in temperatures over Delhi during the next two days. Maximum temperatures are expected to fall by 8-10 degrees Celsius till May 30, while minimum temperatures may drop by 4-5 degrees Celsius during the same period before gradually rising again early next week.

fluenced by a western disturbance over the Himalayan region and an induced cyclonic circulation over Rajasthan and adjoining areas.

The weather department has forecast continued thunderstorm activity over Delhi

Thursday," Mishra said. Dew point is an indicator of actual moisture present in the atmosphere, and a sharp increase reflects significantly higher humidity levels.

Experts added that the weather activity was also in-

• Govt planning 7 infra projects with Centre to decongest Capital

In a major push to decongest Delhi and improve connectivity with neighbouring cities and states, the Centre and the Delhi government will jointly undertake seven large-scale infrastructure projects, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Thursday.

Six-lane tunnel from Nelson Mandela Marg to Shiv Murti in Gurgaon

Length Cost
8 km ₹7,000 cr

To connect: South Delhi to Gurgaon; will help decongest Rao Tula Ram Marg, a key route to Indira Gandhi International Airport

Expected date of start: Still in approval stage

Six-lane Delhi-Dehradun Expressway Link

Length Cost
17 km ₹3,500 cr

To connect: Dehradun Expressway near Tronica City with Urban Extension Road-2, will give access to Dehradun Expressway from Dwarka, Rohini, Punjabi Bagh and Gurgaon; will decongest Barapullah corridor, Mukarba Chowk, Singhu Border and the Ashram-Badarpur stretch

Expected date of start: December



UER-II connects NH 44, NH 9 and the Dwarka Expressway. X/NHAI

Six-lane Noida-Faridabad Corridor via Delhi-Dehradun Expressway

Length Cost
65 km ₹7,000 cr

To connect: Delhi-Dehradun Expressway, Delhi-Meerut Expressway, DND, Faridabad and the Yamuna Expressway; boost connectivity for Loni, Baghpat, Ghaziabad, Noida and Faridabad; will decongest Kalindi Kunj, Sarai Kale Khan and Outer Ring Road

Expected date of start: December

Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway

Length Cost
17 km ₹1,500 cr

To connect: Delhi, Gurgaon and IGI Airport through UER-II and Dwarka Expressway, will improve freight movement

Expected date of start: March 2027

Service roads along UER-II

Length Cost
26 km ₹6,500 cr

To connect: Mundka Industrial Area and logistics hubs, expected to cut snarls on main carriageway

Expected date of start: In approval stage

Six-lane AIIMS-Mahipalpur-Gurgaon Elevated Corridor Project

Length Cost
20 km ₹5,000 cr

To connect: AIIMS, INA, Hauz Khas, Vasant Kunj, Mahipalpur and Gurgaon; will decongest Dhaula Kuan, MG Road, Rao Tula Ram Marg

Expected date of start: April 2027

Kalindi Kunj Interchange near Okhla Barrage

Length Cost
500 m ₹300 cr

To connect: Noida, Jasola, Sarita Vihar, Faridabad

Expected date of start: October

• BRIEFLY



At the Delhi Assembly on Thursday. EXPRESS

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla releases 89 volumes of Central Legislative Assembly proceedings

LOK SABHA Speaker Om Birla on Thursday released 89 volumes based on the proceedings of the Central Legislative Assembly (1924-1930), at the Delhi Assembly, saying the rare document will serve as a guide for the younger generation. Accompanied by Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs Kiren Rijiju, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta and Delhi Parliamentary Affairs Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, Birla also unveiled the inaugural issue of the Assembly's magazine, *Vidhan Chetna*. Birla emphasised that the publication of these 89 volumes will enhance public awareness of the legislative functioning during British rule. PTI

• SENTENCED TO LIFE IMPRISONMENT FOR STABBING A NEIGHBOUR TO DEATH IN 1990

Murder convict who changed name, built family, opened shop caught after 24 yrs

Alok Singh
New Delhi, May 28

A MURDER convict vanished after jumping parole in 2002. For the next 24 years, he built a new life under a fake name — running an auto spare parts shop, raising two sons with his wife, and living just 15 km from his ancestral home in Uttar Pradesh's Prayagraj district.

He was convicted the police would never find him — until they did.

Rakesh Patel alias Pappi, now 54, was arrested by the Delhi Police Crime Branch's Northern Range team from the outskirts of Prayagraj on May 20.

Police said the breakthrough came from an ancestral land sale in Patel's village, Dubra Jagdishpur in Prayagraj. A police team camped for several days in his village, keeping relatives and other residents under surveillance.

"During our first visit, we didn't find much. On our second visit, a villager told us that Patel's brothers had sold an ancestral plot two years ago, dividing it into three parts. We discovered that the money had gone to one Nand Lal Verma. We suspected he might actually be Patel, but we couldn't find his house," an officer said.

The team was then sent for

a third time. "Our team camped in the village for around 15 days to trace Nand Lal's address. Last week, they finally got a lead on the whereabouts of his house," the officer added.

When the police team confronted him, Patel allegedly denied being the fugitive convict and insisted that he was Nand Lal. His family members even produced documents carrying the fake identity, briefly complicating the verification process.

However, police said he eventually admitted he was Patel.

During questioning, police said Patel shifted between multiple locations in Mumbai,



Rakesh Patel in police custody. EXPRESS

Bihar and later Delhi while he was on the run. While hiding in Mumbai and Bihar, he allegedly changed his name from Patel to Nand Lal Verma.

After the death of his father in 2011, Patel decided to settle in his village, said police. He had told fellow residents that he had served time and was released.

According to the police, Patel's father, employed in a government job, had moved to Delhi in the late 1980s.

The family initially lived in a government flat in Sarojini Nagar. However, his father had to and the family faced financial difficulties. They later

moved to a rented accommodation in Jahangirpuri.

In 1995, police said Patel was convicted in 1995 in a murder case registered at Jahangirpuri police station. Patel and his associates — Chander Prakash and Anil Kumar — were sentenced to life imprisonment by a Delhi court for stabbing a neighbour to death in 1990 following a dispute that began over a slap.

Patel was first granted parole in 1999 for his marriage and surrendered before jail authorities on time. However, after being granted parole again in June 2002 on the orders of the Delhi High Court following the birth of his sec-

ond child, he disappeared.

"He never returned to jail after the parole period ended on June 24, 2002. Since then, he had been constantly changing locations and concealing his identity," the officer said.

The case was eventually pulled out of cold storage.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime) Pankaj Kumar said that four months ago, the police team was formed to gather intelligence about the fugitive.

Police said one of Patel's brothers works in a government job and lives in Delhi, while the other is a businessman living in Prayagraj.

Only essential lighting, ACs to operate at 24-26°C Celsius: Govt tells depts

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 28

AIR-CONDITIONERS set between 24 and 26 degrees Celsius, lights switched off during daytime, and mandatory shutdown of electrical equipment after office hours — the Delhi government has directed all its departments and autonomous bodies to adopt power-saving measures for prevention of misuse and rationalisation of electricity consumption in offices.

The General Administration department, in a recent circular marked to secretaries of all departments, including the CMO and the LG Office, said, "In pursuance of the appeal made by the Prime Minister of India regarding saving fuel and energy, it has been decided to undertake measures for prevention of misuse and rationalisation of electricity consumption in Government offices under GNCTD."

Accordingly, all heads of departments, offices, autonomous bodies, local bodies and public sector undertakings have been urged to ensure "judicious and need-based use of electricity" in their offices and establishments.

The departments were also directed to avoid unnecessary use of lighting fixtures during daytime and use natural lighting wherever feasible.

"Over-lighting of rooms, corridors, common areas and office premises shall be avoided, and only essential lighting as per functional requirement shall be used. Departments/offices shall also consider installation of master switches to ensure automatic switching off of lights and electrical equipment in rooms/areas not in use so as to prevent avoidable electricity consumption," the order read.

Further, it asked the departments to operate ACs in an energy-efficient manner — preferably between 24 and 26 degrees Celsius — and avoid unnecessary cooling of office spaces.





MESSAGE

ANTONIO BARTOLI

Ambassador of Italy to India



On June 2nd 1946, through an institutional referendum, Italians chose Republic over monarchy. The 80th anniversary of the Italian Republic is a landmark moment for all Italians in the world. Celebrating it with our Indian friends this year carries a truly special meaning. Only a few days ago in Rome, Prime Ministers Giorgia Meloni and Narendra Modi elevated our bilateral ties to a Special Strategic Partnership. Our Nations have never been so close.

The decision of our Leaders is a turning point along a path that, over the years, we have built steadily and with determination, advancing at remarkable speed. In 2023, the establishment of a Strategic Partnership. In 2024, the adoption of a Joint Action Plan for 2025–2029, which remains our operational road-map. And now, a renewed and forward-looking framework of collaboration for ever more ambitious goals and initiatives. Structural interests and objective complementarities. But also deep-seated commonalities and the same founding values of peace, freedom and democracy. Italy and India share a common vision on many of the major challenges of our time and the future ahead.

In an era of uncertainty, they can provide together a meaningful contribution to the achievement of shared priorities as the defense of the rules-based international order, economic growth and security, inclusive and sustainable development. The important agreements that our Governments signed in Rome aim at further strengthening our cooperation across a broad range of areas. In economy, our two Prime Ministers set the target of €20 billion in trade exchange by 2029. We intend to increase both commerce and investments, leveraging the opportunities arising from the EU–India Free Trade Agreement.

From auto-components to machinery and advanced manufacturing. From critical materials and infrastructures, to precision agriculture and waste-to energy. We more and more see each other not merely as export markets: but as true industrial partners.

Design, develop and produce together: the approach Italy and India look at is that of creating strong and resilient value chains. Matching India’s scale, speed, and talent, with Italy’s industrial design, technological quality and creative know-how.

In this perspective, innovation will play a central role in our future. As our Leaders agreed, we will set up INNOVIT, an innovation center in India aimed at fostering a structured dialogue between our ecosystems. A home for Unicorns and start-ups, innovation-driven companies, universities and research clusters.

But also a platform for the exchange of ideas, expertise and talents in cutting-edge fields such as AI, supercomputing, deep-tech, cybersecurity, and much more.

As we look to the future, we will continue to draw inspiration from the depth of our heritage.

Italy and India, heirs to ancient civilizations, will celebrate 2027 as the Year of Culture and Tourism. A rich calendar of initiatives, events, and exhibitions—from archaeology and restoration to cinema and creative industries—lies ahead.

As an anticipation, and following India’s recent return to the Venice Biennale, we brought to India, for the first time ever, a painting by Botticelli. His Madonna and Child conveys the universal values of beauty, spirituality and motherhood, the very symbol of Italian Renaissance.

Italy and India also stand shoulder to shoulder in the fields of security and defense. We cooperate in combating terrorism and money laundering. We will strengthen coordination and operational synergies on maritime security.

We will deepen cooperation between our Armed Forces and defense industries, building on the recently adopted roadmap for co-production programs in domains of critical importance.

As two peninsulas projecting into their respective seas, Italy and India will continue the long history of mutual connections across the Indo-Mediterranean.

Reviving the ancient “Golden Road,” we are determined to implement the IMEC vision, unleashing its extraordinary potential through joint initiatives in ports and infrastructure, digital networks and custom corridors.

On its 80th anniversary, Italy opens a new chapter in its collaboration with India. A truly special partner. We intend to further strengthen our ties, guided by a spirit of confidence, mutual trust, and shared purpose. Side by side, working for a more secure, stable, and prosperous future. As Prime Minister Meloni said: *Parishram safalta ki kunji hai*.

Across Heritage & Civilizations:
A Cultural Journey Through the
Indo-Mediterranean

Italy and India already knew each other two thousand years ago. Under Emperor Augustus, Rome traded coins, spices, and textiles with southern India. Since then, our relationship has been marked by sustained contact and mutual influence. As heirs to ancient civilizations, our ties are deeper than often assumed. Venetian merchants searching for the Indies, missionaries, and explorers all contributed to these common roots.

In 2027, the Year of Culture and Tourism between Italy and India will further bring our peoples, cultures, and traditions closer together. We plan to organize major joint exhibitions and events across cinema, museums, restoration projects, and artist residencies. India has an extraordinary rich cultural heritage. And Italy offers world-class expertise in creative

industries, museology, and the preservation of artistic heritage. Together, we want to combine these strengths to amplify our soft power.

We are already working on a cultural business forum for later this year, involving museums,



universities, and companies from both countries. India and Italy together host more than 100 UNESCO World Heritage sites. Last year, we jointly celebrated the inscription of Italian cuisine and the Marathi forts on the World Heritage list.

In recent months, we delivered several landmark cultural initiatives together, including the first exhibition in India of a Caravaggio’s painting, *The Ecstasy of Magdalene*, an exhibition on Roman mosaics, a focus on Italian cinema at the International Film Festival, and a display on the ancient Golden Routes as testimony to our shared histories.

Just a few weeks ago, we celebrated the return of a magnificent Indian pavilion to the Venice Biennale. Today, we inaugurate another major exhibition where the luminous beauty of Sandro Botticelli’s painting—by the most celebrated master of the Renaissance—meets the ancient cults of Etruscan Mater Matuta and the Buddhist veneration of Haritis.

We will continue to highlight the many affinities that bring Italy and India closer: art, design and fashion, food, and shared values of fraternity and family.

The objective is clear: more Italy in India and more India in Italy.

Make Together For the World:
From Trade to Co-Production
& Supply Chains

Around one thousand Italian companies currently operate in India. Our goal is to bring many more and enhance ever more solid and resilient value chains between our two economies.

India is Italy’s second-largest trading partner in Asia, and our bilateral trade has nearly doubled over the past seven years. We are now aiming to reach €20 billion by 2029. Beyond expanding trade, we also seek to strengthen investment flows—including greater investments from India into Italy.

The Italian Government sees India as a priority trade and industrial partner, and we have established significant instruments to support our business. For example, we opened an office of SIMEST (our agency for business internationalization) at the Embassy in New Delhi and created a dedicated “India financial line” worth over €500 million to support market-access activities and joint ventures.

We have strengthened our export credit agency (SACE) operations, which currently exceed €2 billion, and participated in numerous trade fairs through national pavilions, including, for the first time in history, as a partner country at the AADHAR fair.

The economies of Italy and India are connected by strong



complementarities and shared strengths. India is investing heavily in its industrial base, while Italy is Europe’s second-largest manufacturing powerhouse. Together, we can create significant synergies across a wide range of sectors: machinery, industrial automation and advanced manufacturing; defense and space; chemicals and pharmaceuticals; renewable energy; fashion and textiles; agritech; and agri-food. We will also collaborate in the field of critical materials and technologies, where a dedicated MoU has already been finalized.

The Free Trade Agreement between the European Union and India is a historic turning point. The progressive reduction of tariffs and barriers will create new opportunities for both our countries, strengthening economic cooperation, investment, and long-term growth.

Our goal is not only to trade together, but also to develop and produce together—combining the strengths of “Make in India” and “Made in Italy”.

We will also promote a more intense dialogue among banks, stock exchanges, venture capital firms, and investment funds. Finance can play a decisive role in supporting investments and trade between the economies of Italy and India.

Powering Innovation, Technology & Talent

Innovation lies at the heart of the Special Strategic Partnership between Italy and India. The future Italian innovation centre in India ‘INNOVIT’ will foster collaborations and joint initiatives between our respective start-ups, companies, universities and research institutes.

We intend to combine Italy’s ingenuity and expertise in design, manufacturing and supercomputers - among the most powerful in the world with India’s engineering talent and scale, as the home of more than 100 unicorns and 200,000 start-ups.

As our Prime Ministers recently reiterated, Italy and India intend to work together on the new frontiers of technological development.

Artificial intelligence, quantum computing, biotechnology, and digital infrastructure are increasingly vital to national sovereignty, economic competitiveness, and citizens’ lives. For Italy and India,



cooperation in these areas is key to future growth and innovation.

We are committed to promoting a human-centered approach to artificial intelligence, engaging with platform operators and content creators to counter deepfakes and other technological abuses.

We intend to further expand our already strong science and research partnership. In 2025, we signed two MoUs for joint research projects and launched a dedicated Science and Innovation Dialogue between our universities, IITs, and research institutes.

A few days ago, our Governments agreed on a Roadmap on Higher Education to explore the full potential of our research exchange, through ever greater mobility of students and talents.

India today represents one of the world’s largest pools of young talent, producing around 10 million new graduates entering the workforce each year.

Italy, on the other hand, is emerging as an increasingly attractive academic destination for Indian students. This is due to the quality of the Italian university system, the expanding range of English-taught programmes, and the strong integration between education, research, and industry. Students from India now form the fourth-largest



international student community in Italy, with around 12,000 enrolled in Italian universities.

Italy and India have chosen to invest in the future by empowering their young generations and nurturing talent. The Joint Declaration

of Intent on nurses adopted in Rome is the latest example of our commitment to strengthening the mobility of our professionals and skilled workers between our two countries.

Together, we aim to build a better tomorrow, fostering growth, creating opportunities, and strengthening our capacity to meet the challenges of an ever-changing world.



Mission Beat the Heat

THE INTENSIFYING heat-wave in several parts of the country was a point of discussion in the Cabinet meeting on Wednesday. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who has been appealing to people through social media to stay hydrated and take precautions, has given special directions to his Cabinet colleagues as well. The PM has advised the ministers to always keep bottles of water with them to help those struggling in the heat. The ministers have also been asked to spread the message in their respective constituencies about the need to have more fluids. The PM has also urged the citizens to see that birds and animals around them have enough water sources in the severe heat conditions.

Train Ride with 'No-fuss' Leader

MANY PASSENGERS on a train from Delhi to Lucknow on Monday night were surprised to see BJP leader and former UP Cabinet minister Chaudhary Bhupendra Singh travelling with them. Some passengers complimented the BJP leader for his simple lifestyle as Singh was travelling with just one staff member in the train. A bunch of passengers were later heard talking about how Singh created no fuss despite the train being two hours late in reaching Lucknow on Tuesday morning.

All Set for New Role?

OUTGOING DELHI BJP chief Virendra Sachdeva, under whose leadership the party formed the government in the Capital after 27 years, is likely to be elevated to the BJP's national ranks and play what insiders term "a significant role" in the party's next electoral target — Punjab. Sachdeva, a former journalist with roots in pre-Partition Punjab, could likely serve as "a crucial organisational link" between the BJP's national leadership and the state in the 2027 Assembly polls. On Thursday, after he handed over the charge of Delhi BJP to Harsh Malhotra, Sachdeva distributed packets of Melody toffee, which witnessed a surge in popularity recently after Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifted a packet to his Italian counterpart Georgia Meloni, to each of his colleagues and office staff at the BJP headquarters in the Capital.

Kerala BJP surprise pick: Gopakumar is new legislature party leader

Shaju Philip & Liz Mathew
Thiruvananthapuram, New Delhi, May 28

AMONG THE BJP's three elected MLAs in the Kerala Assembly, Chathannoor legislator B B Gopakumar has been appointed the leader of the BJP's legislature party. Gopakumar emerged as the party's choice ahead of heavyweights Rajeev Chandrasekhar and V Muraliedharan, both former Union ministers, who were elected from Nemom and Kazhakkootam respectively.

Although more than two weeks had elapsed since the election results were declared, with the Assembly electing its Speaker in the interim, the BJP only announced its legislature party leader on Wednesday, just ahead of the new Assembly's first session that is set to begin on

OUTGOING CM'S AGE, BJP'S EXPANDING FOOTPRINT, 2023 'PACT' SAID TO BE AMONG FACTORS

Why Siddaramaiah had to go and Shivakumar's moment arrived

Manoj C G
New Delhi, May 28

IN THE last six months, Siddaramaiah, who resigned as Karnataka Chief Minister on Thursday, had said more than once that he would step down from the post if Rahul Gandhi asked him to. After all, Gandhi was one of his biggest backers in the Congress. The Leader of Opposition is known to respect his political astuteness, administrative experience, and social engineering acumen.

And the CM kept his word after Gandhi asked him to make way for DK Shivakumar, a dyed-in-the-wool Congressman known for his skills at realpolitik and someone who is considered both resourceful and an adept crisis manager. Siddaramaiah perhaps did not expect Gandhi to make that move. Sources close to him say he was initially in a "state of shock".

Siddaramaiah's age — he will be 80 by the time Karnataka goes to the Assembly polls in 2028 — and the BJP's increasing footprint across the country were among the two major factors that influenced the party's decision. In South, Karnataka is the only state where the BJP has won power on its own strength and keeping it out of its reach is important for the Congress.

The transition also had to do with honouring an unwritten pact the high command had negotiated with the two in 2023. When the Congress won Karnataka under the stewardship of

Shivakumar, the central leadership had a tough choice at hand in picking the CM. Gandhi was keen on Siddaramaiah, while Sonia Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra are known to have a soft spot for the Deputy CM. In 2019, Sonia had visited Shivakumar in Tihar jail, where the latter was in judicial custody after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested him in connection with a money laundering case.

The party had to take a call now. In 2023, the high command had thrashed out a formula that both were not fully in agreement with. While Siddaramaiah became CM and Shivakumar Deputy CM, what was left unsaid was that the CM-ship would be rotational. Siddaramaiah is said to have insisted that if the post was rotational, then Shivakumar should not be in his Cabinet. Shivakumar insisted he should be the CM as he had brought the

party to power. In the end, the two reluctantly agreed.

Shivakumar began mounting pressure on the high command as the two-and-a-half-year mark neared last November. The leadership, after the Bihar defeat, was not keen. It dithered and sent a signal that the issue would be taken up after elections in five states this year. That allowed Siddaramaiah the opportunity to overtake D Devaraj Urs as the longest-serving Karnataka CM.

But the party had to honour the pact and also look at the next elections. The party had to factor in certain issues. Can the party go for elections under an octo-



Karnataka Deputy CM DK Shivakumar greets outgoing CM Siddaramaiah in Bengaluru on Thursday. PTI

genarian, who has already declared that he has no desire to contest again and can he be expected to lead a spirited fight against the BJP when he has nothing to gain?

The party's inability to en-

force a similar formula of rotational chief ministership between Bhupesh Baghel and T S Singh Deo in Chhattisgarh had given the impression that the high command could be pressured. In Rajasthan, the high

command had promised to make Sachin Pilot the CM in the last year of the government's term, but that could not be enforced as Ashok Gehlot stayed put. In Punjab, the Congress had replaced Captain Amarinder Singh as CM four to five months before the elections with Charanjit Singh Channi. This led to disarray in the party and in the elections, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) swept it away.

With that baggage, the leadership moved in to resolve the Karnataka tussle. It was not an easy decision. Siddaramaiah is the party's tallest backward class leader in the state with the Ahinda base (a social coalition of the minorities, backwards, and Dalits). Gandhi has been steering the party in the direction of social justice politics. But an influential section of the leadership, including Priyanka, was in favour of a transition. The argument was that Shivakumar had done a lot for the party and had to be rewarded at some point in time. Moreover, he is resourceful and will leave no stone unturned to bring the party to power to keep the top post.

But the leadership wanted the transition to be dignified and not be disrespectful to Siddaramaiah. He was offered a Rajya Sabha seat and a role in national politics, including the post of Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha at a later date. His interests — in terms of securing the position of his loyalists and son — would also be protected, the leadership told him. Siddaramaiah, however, politely turned down the offer.

Chhattisgarh BJP MLA booked for assaulting official

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, May 28

AN FIR has been registered against Chhattisgarh BJP MLA Ramkumar Toppo and more than a dozen of his aides for allegedly assaulting a revenue official. Another FIR was filed against the revenue official based on a complaint by a woman, who accused the official of inappropriate conduct.

The incident took place on Wednesday in Surguja district, when the woman, who said she was a relative of MLA Toppo, approached Naib Tehsildar Tushar Manik's office, seeking his signature on a document required by jail authorities to release a person on parole.

In her complaint, the woman claimed that the naib tehsildar was angered by her request. "He abused me and made obscene gestures. He then pushed me out. He said he would always behave like this with the Urao people (a local tribal community)". He told his staff that I should not be allowed to come into his office."

Manik denied the allegations and said it was MLA Toppo who later intimidated him to get him to sign a paper, and when he refused, the legislator and his supporters assaulted him.

BJP appoints four new state unit chiefs, signals wider changes may be coming

Liz Mathew & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, May 28

BJP NATIONAL president Nitin Nabin on Thursday announced new state unit presidents in Punjab, Haryana, and Tripura, along with a new leader of its Delhi unit. Nabin, who took charge of the party in January, is expected to revamp the national team soon. It is expected to be a mix of experienced and fresh faces, sources said.

These changes could lead to the restructuring of the party's Parliamentary Board and may serve as a precursor to changes in the government, said party insiders.

While 62-year-old Lok Sabha MP and Union Minister Harsh Malhotra has been appointed the president of the Delhi BJP, Kewal Singh Dhillion, 76, will head the BJP in poll-bound Punjab. In Haryana, the central leadership has picked Archana Gupta, 58, to lead the state unit and in Tripura, 44-year-old Abhishek Debroy has been chosen to lead the party.

"In the BJP, while elections in at least 50% of the states and UTs are a pre-requisite for the election of a new national president, the remaining states have elections immediately after



BJP national president Nitin Nabin being felicitated by Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami in Dehradun on Thursday. ANI

the new chief takes over," said a senior party leader, adding, "He (Nabin) has begun the process of announcing new organisational decisions. The required changes will be announced soon."

While 46-year-old Nabin's elevation triggered speculation that the BJP would induct several fresh, young faces in the party and the government, Thursday's announcements signal there could be a mixed team.

"Among these appointments, both Malhotra and Gupta have strong organisational and ideological backgrounds. Malhotra has been an organisationally disciplined party leader and Gupta

has a strong RSS background," said a BJP insider.

Dhillion has been appointed as the president at a time when the state unit is gearing up for a crucial Assembly election early next year in which the BJP is desperate to make significant gains after failing to win a single seat in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.

These appointments, say party insiders, reveal that more changes are in the offing, including in the government. "The government is going to enter its third year amidst an economic crisis and unpredictable global situation. To infuse freshness in the administration, and address



B B Gopakumar is a legislator from Chathannoor

the seats where RSS workers had been deployed at the grassroots level, leading to Gopakumar's unexpected victory. Gopakumar also drew support as a prominent face of the Hindu Ezhava community, which forms around 45% of the constituency's electorate. The Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana (SNDP) Yogam of the Ezhava community and Nair Service So-

ciet (NSS) have strong footprints in the seat.

A former Congress worker, when Gopakumar fought the 2016 Assembly election from Chathannoor, the BJP only managed a vote share of 24.92%. In 2021, contesting Chathannoor again, he raised the BJP's vote share to 30.61%. In 2026, Gopakumar defeated the CPI's R Rajendran while garnering 38.54% of the vote. Gopakumar, who had earlier served as BJP Kollam district president, had remained active in the constituency over the last decade.

Gopakumar said the Chathannoor model could be replicated in all seats in Kerala, where the stakes for the BJP have been high in both Assembly and Lok Sabha elections.

BJP sources said Gopakumar's elevation as the leader of the legislature party should be

seen as the "growing sway" of the RSS in party matters. In 2016, Gopakumar was fielded in the Assembly polls with the RSS's backing. In the recent Assembly elections, too, the RSS played a crucial role in his electioneering. The organisation wanted to recognise a leader who rose through the ranks, sources said.

Between the party's three Kerala MLAs, Gopakumar is a "safer choice" as legislature party leader for the BJP as the move will help consolidate the party in the state and shift its focus to the Kollam district, where Chathannoor is located. With the party coming to power in the Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation last December and winning two other Assembly seats — Nemom and Kazhakkootam — in the Thiruvananthapuram district, the BJP now wants to target the neighbouring Kollam dis-

trict to expand its sphere of influence. "These victories are significant because they were all Left-held seats. Kollam is another Left citadel," said a Kerala BJP leader, signalling that the party's focus will be to gain ground where the Left has traditionally been dominant.

With the BJP keen on reaching out to minorities, Muraliedharan's public statements targeting Muslims after the elections did not go down well with the state leaders. Muraliedharan has repeatedly raised concerns over the influence of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) in the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government.

"Gopakumar is a classic example that the party can show off to other karyakartas — he is someone who came up through the ranks in politics," said a source.



Siddaramaiah supporters outside his residence in Bengaluru. PTI

Behind popularity: Mass appeal, social justice, oratory skills

Akram M
Bengaluru, May 28

POLITICIANS CUTTING across party lines agree that outgoing CM Siddaramaiah, Janata Dal (Secular) leader HD Deve Gowda and BJP's BS Yediyurappa count among the tallest mass leaders Karnataka has seen. Deve Gowda and Yediyurappa have bowed out of active politics, and Siddaramaiah resigned today. Speculation is rife about his next move.

The writing, it appears, was on the wall. Siddaramaiah is known for his passionate speeches laced with rustic humour, but his last public address to mark the completion of three years of Congress rule in Karnataka was tepid by his standards. Some blamed age, others saw signs of a shift within the government.

Siddaramaiah's career is a saga of defiance and resilience. Adept at turning challenges into opportunities, he had used his expulsion from the JDS to emerge as a popular leader of Karnataka's backward communities. And when the mining scam rocked Karnataka, he paved the way for the Congress's return to power.

That he is the longest-serving CM of Karnataka and the only one in nearly five decades to complete a full term reflects his popularity.

Siddaramaiah was born on August 3, 1947, at Siddaramahundi near Mysuru. He is from the Kuruba community, a pastoralist group traditionally marginalised in Karnataka's caste hierarchy. His father was a farmer, and Siddaramaiah has said his early life was full of hardships. After completing his BSc and LLB, he briefly worked as a lecturer. Inspired by farmer

leader MD Nanjundaswamy, Siddaramaiah quit teaching to enter politics.

In 1983, he contested the Chamundeshwari Assembly seat on a Lok Dal ticket and won. He quickly rose through the Janata Party ranks, serving as Finance Minister in the Janata Dal government. By the early 2000s, Siddaramaiah had become a formidable force in Karnataka politics. His Ahinda vision aimed to consolidate marginalised communities. Then with JDS, he organised an Ahinda convention, challenging the dominance of the so-called upper castes within JDS.

Deve Gowda was projecting his son HD Kumaraswamy as a political heir, and this seems to have miffed Siddaramaiah. In 2005, he was expelled from the JDS after being accused of factionalism and indiscipline. He joined the Congress, bringing with him a strong grassroots base and the Ahinda plank that would redefine Karnataka's social justice narrative.

In 2010, Janardhan Reddy, then a powerful BJP leader and mining baron, dared Siddaramaiah to come to Ballari, the epicentre of Karnataka's mining wealth and corruption scandals. Siddaramaiah responded by leading a padayatra to Ballari. It became a turning point, boosting Congress's morale and laying the groundwork for its resurgence. The party returned to power in 2013 and Siddaramaiah became the CM for the first time.

Critics accuse him of populism, arguing his welfare schemes strain the state's finances. But Siddaramaiah has defended them by pointing out that putting money in the hands of the poor is the best method to boost the economy.

Manipur: EC considers special registration officers for internally displaced electors

Damini Nath
New Delhi, May 28

THE ELECTION Commission is considering deploying special Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs) for the internally displaced persons (IDPs) in Manipur, where thousands have been displaced since the ethnic clashes broke out in May 2023, for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The SIR exercise, which involves Booth-Level Officers (BLOs) going house-to-house to have all registered electors fill enumeration forms in order to stay on the rolls, is set to start in Manipur on Saturday, as per the EC's schedule announced earlier this month.

After that, the Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) and AEROs are supposed to issue notices to those electors who have not been able to establish their eligibility by giving the details of themselves or their parents.

Sources said the office of Manipur Chief Electoral Officer has submitted a proposal to the EC for appointing special AEROs for the IDPs, similar to the deployment of designated Assistant Returning Officers for the conduct of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections in the state.

A total of 18,620 IDPs were eligible to vote in the 2024 elections. The EC had set up 94 special polling stations for IDPs in relief camps. As of now, the total number of IDPs has gone down from 62,000 in 2023

E. EXPLAINED

Why special AEROs for Manipur?

Under The Representation of the People Act, 1950, Electoral Registration Officers and AEROs are appointed for maintaining the electoral rolls of Assembly constituencies. In the case of Manipur, where thousands of electors have been displaced from their home constituencies, the EC is considering appointing special AEROs to decide on eligibility of the electors staying in camps.

to around 57,000, according to government records. Sources said arrangements are likely to be made for around 14,000-15,000 IDPs who are eligible for participation in the SIR exercise. The EC recently announced the schedule of the third phase of SIR, which started in June last year. The third phase will cover 16 states and three Union Territories over the next few months. The exercise is set to start with house-to-house visits by BLOs in Odisha, Mizoram, Sikkim and Manipur from Saturday.

According to the EC, there are 20.91 lakh electors spread across 2,996 booths in Manipur. As per the schedule, electors will have till June 28 to fill the enumeration forms.

Some NEET candidates had to part with original documents, pay later: CBI probe

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, May 28

THE CBI investigation into the alleged leak of NEET-UG questions has found that the accused made some candidates part with their original school documents which would be returned once they appeared for the examination and paid the amount agreed upon.

It is learnt that the CBI, during searches and seizures, recovered original identity and academic documents of several students from the possession of the arrested persons.

A source said investigation teams have uncovered two modus operandi: in one, the accused would take payments upfront for questions; the other method was to take possession of a candidate's original documents that would be returned once payment was made after successful completion of the examination.

"Initially, the CBI had arrested Yash Yadav from Gurgaon and Mangilal Biwal and his associates from Rajasthan. Mangilal received the leaked paper from Yadav for Rs 10 lakh on the condition that around 150 questions would match the original. He allegedly received the papers on Telegram on April 29 and distributed printed copies to his sons, cousin and others including a teacher," a CBI official said.

During the searches, the CBI recovered several documents from Yadav and after scrutiny, it was found that some were original documents of students.

"Similarly, several original documents were recovered from the arrested persons in Pune. The CBI is learnt to have recovered original documents of at least 12 students. They are being approached to record their statements," a source said.

On Wednesday, the CBI arrested Dr Manoj Shirure, a Latur-based physician, and Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, a Physics faculty member at a Pune coaching institute, in connection with the alleged leak of questions, taking the total number of arrests in the case to 13. The CBI also recovered Rs 5 lakh from the house of Dr Shirure's sister on May 21. "It has been found during investigation that Dr Shirure took Chemistry questions from retired teacher P V Kulkarni in the third week of April and collected Rs 5 lakh from the wife of co-accused Shivraj Motegaonkar, founder of RCC Classes in Latur," a CBI official said.

The probe has also found that Shirure helped two other doctors whose children had obtained Chemistry questions from Kulkarni and had paid Rs 3 lakh per student. Of this, he had received 50% of the amount collected from the two students.

Motegaonkar is a friend of Kulkarni who was involved in the examination process on behalf of the NTA. Searches at his institute and residence, the CBI said, resulted in the recovery of a Chemistry question bank which contained exactly the same questions which appeared in the NEET examination.



Following the paper leak controversy, protests had broken out in different parts of the country. PTI

Govt looks at IAF for safe transport of papers

Abhinaya Harigovind & Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 28

THE GOVERNMENT is discussing the possibility of seeking logistics support from the Indian Air Force (IAF) for the NEET-UG, including for safe transportation of examination materials, it is learnt.

This and other possibilities were discussed in a meeting at Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's residence on Thursday, which was attended by Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, National Testing Agency (NTA) DG Abhishek Singh, defence officials and officials from the Department of Posts.

It was not immediately known whether the IAF will provide logistics support for any other all-India level examination as well.

Sources aware of the developments said that the NTA is working on a "compressed timeline" to conduct the NEET-UG retest this time, necessitating a "whole of government approach".

While preparation for NEET-UG usually covers around six months, the NTA is now preparing for the retest and making arrangements "from scratch", over a span of 38 days, sources said, adding that this leaves it "severely pressed for time".

The exam, which was held on May 3 for over 22 lakh candidates, was cancelled on May 12 after a paper leak. On May 15, the NTA announced that the re-test would be conducted on June 21. The CBI is now probing the leak.

ROW OVER CBSE CLASS 12 RESULTS; MINISTER, RAHUL ENGAGE IN VERBAL WAR

Some discrepancies noticed, take responsibility: Pradhan

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 28

UNION EDUCATION Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Thursday acknowledged that "some discrepancies had been noticed" in the CBSE Class 12 exam results, saying he takes "responsibility for it" as this was the first time the Board had implemented the on-screen marking (OSM) system on such a large scale.

"Certain discrepancies have come to our notice, and I take responsibility for them. These issues will be rectified, and appropriate solutions will be worked out. We are all working on this. We will not leave any student's question unresolved," Pradhan said after a review meeting at the CBSE headquarters in Delhi.

The minister's statement came a day after Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi alleged there was "massive tampering" in the Class 12 results, and that the company that CBSE chose for OSM — Coemtp Edu Teck — "had already pulled off the same deed in Telangana in 2019" under a different name.

Responding to Gandhi's claims, Pradhan said: "It has been done (the choice of company) as per the government's procurement policy. I assure...if something has gone wrong, we will not spare anybody. Rahul Gandhi is frustrated after repeatedly losing elections. He op-



Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan during a meeting with CBSE officials, in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

posed SIR, he opposed EVMs, he opposed digital India. He is not with the scientific advancement of the country... I request him... this is not the time for politics. Students' mental stress shouldn't increase with anybody's behaviour or words..."

Replying to the minister, Gandhisaid, "You can attack me all you want but it won't absolve you of your crimes. Nor will it stop me from demanding answers for 18.5 lakh children."

The Congress MP asked why no background checks were done before the contract was handed to the company. "What is the connection between Coemtp's management and the Modi government? Either you ran a background check and went ahead anyway — or you didn't run one at all. Either way,

you are complicit. As for responsibility — if the PM cared, he should have sacked you long ago for ruining the futures of lakhs of students."

Pradhan maintained that the OSM is a "progressive instrument" that is "student-centric", and "other institutions and universities in the country and the world are progressing towards it".

"It is student-centric...they can get information about their marks in a transparent manner. They can transparently get their answer sheets in scanned form. Their questions...whether they have got less or more, or something has been missed...to give information on all this, this facility of OSM is there," Pradhan said.

CBSE introduced OSM for the Class 12 board exams this year — around 98 lakh answer books were marked digitally by evaluators. The Class 12 pass percentage fell from 88.39% last year to 85.29% this year. With concerns raised over the scores this year, the Board slashed the cost to obtain scanned copies of answer books; it received over 4.04 lakh applications to obtain scanned copies of answer books, well over the 1.31 lakh applications received last year.

Based on their answer book copies, students can apply for verification of marks and re-evaluation — a process that has not begun yet. The Board faced

technical glitches with its post-result services portal where students were applying for copies of their answer books. These issues are being fixed in collaboration with experts from IIT-Madras and IIT-Kanpur before the portal is made available for re-evaluation and verification applications.

"Along with transparency, it is a question of ensuring quality. There is scope for improvement in this. The discrepancies that were found...on such a large scale it was organised...over 40 crore sheets were scanned. Of the 17 lakh students (who gave the exam), 4 lakh students have come back to ask for their answer sheets. Around 11 lakh copies have gone to them...for the problems that arose, we take responsibility. We express regret," Pradhan said. He said "if somebody is intentionally responsible, we will not spare them, whether it is within the CBSE or outside, or within the government". He said, "We are all accountable. We are not running from anything."

The Board has maintained that the OSM portal, which was used for evaluation of answer books, was not "compromised". While a social media post had flagged vulnerabilities in the OSM portal, the Board has refuted this on the grounds that the user who raised the issue had accessed a "testing site" with sample data.

J&K High Court questions 2019 terror case as FIR predates 'arms recovery'

Arun Sharma
Jammu, May 28

AN FIR registered 75 minutes before the actual offence — that was what caught the attention of the Jammu, Kashmir and Ladakh High Court while hearing the bail application of a truck driver who was arrested on cross-border terrorism and arms smuggling charges in 2019 and has been in jail since.

Last week, the court was hearing the bail application of Sabeel Ahmad Baba, a truck driver who was arrested for the alleged possession of four AK56 and two AK47 rifles from his vehicle at Lakhnanpur. Baba was among six named in a case linked to offences under the Ranbir Penal Code (RPC), the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967, and the Indian Arms Act, 1959. Pakistan-based Jaish-e-Mohammad commander Ashiq Ahmad Nengroo alias Ashiq Molvi is one of the six accused in the case.

While hearing the bail application, Justice Rahul Bharti cited police records to observe that while the FIR pertaining to arrest and the seizure of arms were registered at 8.30 am on September 12, 2019, the seizures took place a full 75 minutes later following the search of the truck at 9.45 am.

"...one very striking aspect of the case, from which this Court is not able to distance itself from taking serious cognizance, is the fact that the registration of FIR No. 006/L... dated 12.09.2019 by the Police Station, Lakhnanpur at 8:30 am had taken place first and the alleged commission of offences took place at 9:45 am..."

The court called the investigating officer in the case to appear before it on the next date of hearing.



Bakrid prayers in Bengal

People offer Bakrid prayers at Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata on Thursday. The iconic ground, which has been hosting mega political rallies, was used to offer namaz for the first time after the new BJP government in the state banned namaz on roads. PARTHA PAUL

TMC MP Kakoli writes to LS Speaker against party colleague Kalyan Banerjee

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, May 28

TRINAMOL CONGRESS MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar Thursday wrote to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking permission to lodge a formal complaint against party colleague and lawmaker Kalyan Banerjee, alleging that he had repeatedly verbally abused her inside Parliament.

In her letter to the Speaker, Ghosh Dastidar alleged that Banerjee's behaviour reflected "misogyny" and claimed that similar conduct had been directed at other women MPs as well.

"I seek your permission to lodge a formal complaint to you for redressal against Lok Sabha member of AITC Kalyan Banerjee, who has repeatedly verbally abused me inside the Lok Sabha. This misogyny has been against many lady members and needs to be punished," Ghosh Dastidar wrote in the

Mamata targets turncoats with 'Girgit' poem

Amid turmoil in the TMC, party chief Mamata Banerjee has penned a satirical poem, titled 'Girgit' (chameleon), targeting turncoats in her party.

"*Koto nebe choritro bodlate/ chorontole koto utkoch dhon/ ar koto chao? Nijeder bhol bodlate?*..." (How much will you take to change your character? How much bribe money is at your feet? How much more do you want to change your faces?), she writes, comparing disloyal politicians to colour-changing chameleons. -**ATRI MITRA**

handwritten letter to the Lok Sabha Speaker.

Her letter comes a day after

Ghosh Dastidar resigned from all organisational posts in the TMC. Earlier this week, the four-term MP had also stepped down as president of the party's Barasat organisational district unit.

In her resignation letter to the party, Ghosh Dastidar — once among the party's most recognisable faces and national president of its women's wing — stated that there was little meaning in continuing in a position where "obscene behaviour" by an "uneducated and uncivilised" party MP towards a woman lawmaker could not be stopped, and where no support or sympathy was extended by the higher leadership.

After the TMC lost the Bengal Assembly elections, Ghosh Dastidar has been criticising the poll strategist organisation I-PAC. While the senior MP resigned from all party posts, she said that she will not quit the TMC.

Eid homecoming: Crowdfunding brings back Kerala man from Saudi death row

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, May 28

FOR THE Machilakathu family in Feroke, near Kerala's Kozhikode, Eid 2026 became a day of relief and reunion as their son returned home after languishing in a Saudi prison for two decades, narrowly escaping the gallows.

Abdul Rahim, in jail since December 2006 in connection with the death of a teenager under his care, arrived home on Thursday morning on an exit visa from Saudi Arabia. As he stepped out of Kozhikode airport, hundreds waited near his ancestral house to welcome him.

For many elders, Rahim was a faded memory; for the youngsters, he was an icon whose story had moved Keralites across the world, sparking an extraordinary crowdfunding campaign that secured his release.

At home, Rahim thanked all those who gave him a second lease of life. "I thank all Keralites across the world who made my release a reality," he said.



Abdul Rahim, who returned after spending two decades in a Saudi Arabian jail, is welcomed in Kozhikode on Thursday. PTI

Before leaving for Saudi Arabia, Rahim drove an auto-rickshaw and a school bus in Kerala. The youngest of six siblings, he travelled to Riyadh on November 28, 2006, after securing a job as a driver.

According to accounts presented during the case, Rahim had also been assigned to assist his employer's 17-year-old son, who was paralysed and dependent on a breathing apparatus. On December 24, 2006, while Rahim was driving with

the teenager seated in the back, the breathing support device reportedly became detached, leading to the boy's death.

Rahim, then 26, was arrested — just 28 days after arriving in Saudi Arabia, and eventually sentenced to death by a Saudi court in 2011. The sentence was upheld by higher courts, leaving his family in Kerala to live for years under the shadow of a possible execution. In April 2024, the victim's family agreed to pardon him in

exchange for blood money amounting to Rs 34 crore.

The amount — impossible for Rahim's family to raise on its own — was collected through a massive crowdfunding effort backed by Malayalis across the world. Contributions poured in from ordinary workers, expatriates, social organisations and public figures, transforming the campaign into one of Kerala's largest community-led fundraising efforts.

With the victim's family accepting the compensation, the death sentence was set aside. Saudi authorities, however, ordered that Rahim complete a 20-year jail term, which, according to the Arabic calendar followed in the case, concluded on May 20 this year.

Back in Kozhikode, it has been an ordeal for Rahim's family. While father Muhammedkutty died six months after he was jailed, mother Fatima only met him once — in November 2024, after the pardon came through. Occasional video calls were the only relief. Until Thursday, when the Machilakathu family's long wait finally ended.



**OFFICE OF THE
PRINCIPAL COMMISSIONER OF INCOME TAX (JUDICIAL)
ROOM NO. 162-A, C.R. BUILDING, NEW DELHI
PHONE & FAX-011-23379308**

F.No. PCIT (JudL)/NCLT Matters/Publication/2026-27/248 Dated: 26.05.2026

**FORM NO. NCLT 3A
ADVERTISEMENT DETAILING PETITION**
[See Rule 35 of the National Company Law Tribunal Rules, 2016]
Company Appeal No: 24 of 2026
(Under Section 252 of the Companies Act, 2013)
IN THE MATTER OF:
Income Tax Officer, Ward 11(3), Delhi ...Appellant
Versus
Registrar of Companies, Delhi & Ors. ...Respondents
(Highest Consultant Private Limited)

NOTICE OF PETITION

This notice is being published to serve the Respondents No. 2 (M/s Highest Consultant Private Limited), 3 (Mr. Prasanth Shah, Director having DIN: 06984271), 4 (Ms. Varsha Jain, Director having DIN: 06984275) in the captioned appeal which is pending before Hon'ble NCLT, Delhi under Section 252 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking restoration of the name of M/s Highest Consultant Private Limited in the register maintained by ROC. The said appeal is next listed for hearing before the National Company Law Tribunal, Delhi Bench-III on 01.06.2026. In this connection, M/s Highest Consultant Private Limited and their Director is hereby informed and requested to attend the captioned case before Hon'ble NCLT, CGO Complex, Lodhi Road, New Delhi on the date fixed i.e. 01.06.2026. It is to be noted that in case they fail to appear on the aforementioned date, the case will be heard and decided in your absence.

Income Tax Officer, Ward 11 (3), New Delhi
C. R. Building, I.P. Estate, New Delhi - 110002

Sd/-
(Heera Lal)
Income Tax Officer
(Judicial)-3, New Delhi

Place: New Delhi
CBC- 15403/11/001/2627



MUMBAI PORT AUTHORITY

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Mumbai Port Authority invites online **Tender No. E-25/2026: e-Tender-cum-e-Auction for purchase, demolition of dilapidated Residential Buildings under the Jurisdiction of GWND. The Due Date of the tender is 09.06.2026.** Details of the tender are available on MBPA's website: <http://www.mumbaiport.gov.in> and <http://www.eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>

Chief Engineer
Mumbai Port Authority



MAHARASHTRA NATIONAL LAW UNIVERSITY, NAGPUR
(Established by the Maharashtra Act No. VI of 2014)
Near Village Waranga, P.O. Dongargaon (Butibori), Nagpur - 441108
Website: www.nlnunagpur.ac.in

The Maharashtra National Law University, Nagpur, invites applications from eligible candidates for the post of Vice-Chancellor.

Qualifications:

- He shall be an academican and having 10 Years of experience as a Professor of Law, in a University, or in a college on a post approved by a University.
- He must be possessing the highest level of competence, integrity, morals and institutional commitment.
- He should, in the estimation of the Chancellor, be capable of providing effective leadership to the University.

Duly filled-in applications must reach at or before 5 p.m. of 30th June, 2026, only by Registered post/ Speed Post (Not by private courier agencies), to the following address:

'The Registrar, Maharashtra National Law University, Nagpur, Waranga, PO: Dongargaon (Butibori), Nagpur-441108 Maharashtra.'

Detailed Notification regarding the qualification, age, salary and service conditions, term, powers and functions, procedure for appointment, the General Conditions and instructions along with the form of application, and all the other details are on the University's web-site. For same, please visit University's official web-site <www.nlnunagpur.ac.in>.

Sd/-
(Deepak L. Bhagwat)
Registrar, MNLU, Nagpur

Custodial torture: Woman cop suspended

Sujit Bisoyi

Bhubaneswar, May 28

A WOMAN police inspector was suspended and a departmental probe ordered after she and other staff at a police station in Odisha's Kendrapada were accused of custodial torture.

An official orders said inspector in charge Sandhyarani Jena was suspended for gross misconduct and dereliction of duty after a 55-year-old woman and

her 31-year-old son lodged a custodial torture complaint.

According to the duo, this followed a complaint by their estranged father over a "domestic dispute". "Our father was a follower of a guru and has lived apart for a year. He's a vegetarian and disliked our food choices. He also accuses us of harassment and lodged a complaint to compel us to vacate our home," the woman's eldest son told *The Indian Express*. The duo was al-

legedly called to the police station on May 25. "After an hour of discussion, the police asked us to sign an agreement stating that my brother and I would vacate the house. When we objected, my younger brother and mother were assaulted. My mother was dragged by her hair, disrobed, and her *sindoor* wiped off," the elder son said. The woman's second son was allegedly locked inside a toilet, assaulted and forced to sign a blank paper.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Shri Ranbir Bhardwaj S/o Shri Rattan Lal, R/o 487/77-B, Mangal Bazar Road, Peera Garhi, Delhi-110087, intends to purchase property bearing Plot No. 1, Block C-2, admeasuring 127.83 Sq. Yards, situated at Mianwali Nagar, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087. Any person having any claim, objection or encumbrance regarding the said property may intimate the undersigned within 15 days from publication of this notice, failing which the transaction shall be completed.

Contact :
Ranbir Bhardwaj
Mobile:
9891639315

EC must answer but SC gives it free pass & more

THE SUPREME Court ruling on petitions challenging the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls spends far too many words in underlining that which is uncontested — the Election Commission has a constitutional mandate to ensure free and fair polls. And that which is unquestionable — the electoral rolls on which the polls rest must be accurate and reliable. No one, no political party, has questioned either of the above principles or pieties. There is no doubt that the EC plays a leading role in the India story, and its monitoring of the sprawling electoral exercise in a country of diversities bur-nishes that story immeasurably. Undoubtedly, too, the periodic clean-up of electoral rolls is necessary, in light of large-scale migration, rapid urbanisation, illegal cross-border movement, non-reporting of deaths, duplication of entries. Having said that, however, the problem begins.

The EC's conduct of the SIR in Bihar, and then the manner of its roll-out in West Bengal especially, have raised important questions about the delicate balance between the need for electoral integrity and the imperative of voter inclusion. There are widespread concerns that the EC's actions have tilted the balance against the citizen — by shifting the burden of proof onto vulnerable voters; by laying down an onerous documentation regime; by setting compressed timelines for the voter and none for the appellate process. This is what led to nearly 27 lakh being disenfranchised in the West Bengal election. Now, the Court does not just exonerate the EC, it hands it a free pass by giving it the benefit of the doubt on every count and unfettered procedural latitude. Most disturbingly, even on the citizenship issue, the Court, in effect, gives the EC free play, without any guardrails. The Commission, says the Court, is empowered to undertake a "limited enquiry" for the purpose of determining the eligibility for inclusion in the electoral rolls, and such an enquiry does not amount to a determination of citizenship, which will be decided by the "Competent Authority under the Citizenship Act". So far so good. But then, even as the Court speaks of the right to judicial review for those whose names may have been erroneously deleted, it legitimises a short-circuiting of due process by directing that if the EC "is not satisfied that a person meets the statutory conditions for inclusion in the electoral roll", it must refer this individual to the government's Competent Authority within four weeks. The SIR isn't a test for citizenship but the EC, which can only make a "limited enquiry into citizenship", is empowered to set the stage for a citizenship test.

This is disquieting in the political climate the current citizenship debate is set in. The new government in West Bengal has announced that those deleted from the electoral rolls would lose government benefits. In a time when the "ghuspaithiya" or illegal immigrant is the subject of spectre-mongering, and a communal dog-whistle politics, the Court undermines its role as the custodian of the individual's rights. Going forward, therefore, the EC will need stronger scrutiny.

A new Karnataka CM, a tired Congress script

THE 2023 assembly election result in Karnataka marked a rare triumph for Congress since the waning of its electoral fortunes after 2014. The AHINDA social coalition resurrected by Siddaramaiah, a campaign focused on corruption and governance issues and a party organisation that came together, credit for which was given to D K Shivakumar — a host of factors came together to give Congress 135 seats in the 224-seat House. Unfortunately, almost from the very beginning of outgoing Chief Minister Siddaramaiah's term, the Karnataka story has been dominated by the factional fight within the ruling party. With his resignation and the likely elevation of his colleague and rival Shivakumar in his place, Congress's challenges in Karnataka are set to grow.

Siddaramaiah is a mass leader with wide appeal among OBCs, minorities and Dalits. He has taken political ownership of Congress's "five guarantees" — cash transfer and welfare schemes aimed at women and youth, which have, on the one hand, become a safety net but on the other, shrunk the room for capital expenditure by the government. The Social and Educational Survey threatens to become a fault line, by shining the light on the population numbers and economic indices of dominant groups like Vokkaligas and Lingayats vis-à-vis others. Rather than looking for ways to navigate this changing landscape, Congress has been busy managing rival factions. On the governance front, Bengaluru, the hub of innovation and start-ups, continues to face crumbling infrastructure, even as other urban centres cry out for attention and investment.

Sub-groups inside large parties can enrich governance through multiple perspectives. The Karnataka story, though, speaks of a broader political culture that remains myopic, even as Congress shrinks in the face of the BJP's challenge. The new CM can use the next two years to change this script. Or, it can be another chapter in a story of an unchecked decline.

Consensus builder, and a bridge

RAJA RANDHIR Singh, who died on Wednesday aged 79, belonged to an era when Indian shooting existed far from the spotlight. It was the time before Olympic medals, corporate backing and shooting academies. Competing in five Olympics between 1968 and 1984, he was among India's earliest international regulars in trap shooting and won the country's first Asian Games gold in the discipline in 1978. But his success can't be measured merely in medals. Singh came to embody a continuity between amateur-era Indian sport and a more globalised Olympic future. He did so first as an athlete who understood the sport intimately, and later as a figure who could represent India within international federations.

Singh was not regarded as a visionary reformer in the modern sense, nor did he cultivate the image of a strongman administrator. Instead, his value lay in relationships, continuity and access. Athletes across generations, from the pre-liberalisation era to India's Olympic medallists, viewed him as someone who could quietly get things done.

Born into Patiala royalty, son of former International Olympic Committee (IOC) member Raja Bhalindra Singh, Singh moved through international sporting circles with ease. The Olympic movement historically drew heavily from aristocracy, old institutions and diplomatic networks. Officials across Asia frequently described him as a "consensus-builder" and a stabilising figure. India's sporting rise owed much to athletes on podiums, but it also depended on figures like Randhir Singh.

BEFORE ANY representative government can count votes, it must first know whose votes may be counted." That arresting opening line from CJI Surya Kant's 124-page judgment in Association for Democratic Reforms vs Election Commission of India, delivered on May 27, sets an appropriately philosophical tone for one of the most consequential electoral rulings in recent memory. It is a judgment that gets the constitutional law largely right — and the ground reality almost entirely wrong. It also mistakes a demolition for a renovation.

Let me begin with the credit due.

The Court has affirmed what election administrators have long known: Clean electoral rolls are not an administrative nicety but the foundation of democratic legitimacy. More than two decades had passed since Bihar's last Special Intensive Revision (SIR). Rapid urbanisation and large-scale migration had produced rolls riddled with duplication, dead voters, and multiple recording of migrant voters. Annual Summary Revisions were addressing these issues, but problems persisted. The EC's decision to undertake the SIR was legally and constitutionally valid, as the SC has upheld — even if the manner of its execution was anything but.

The Court correctly holds that the SIR is traceable to Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act, read with Article 324, and does not conflict with the constitutional imperative of free and fair elections. More importantly, it draws an intelligent and necessary line on citizenship: The EC can examine it, but for the limited purpose of determining inclusion or exclusion from the electoral roll. Deletion from the voters' list does not amount to a declaration of non-citizenship.

Final adjudication remains with the competent authority under the Citizenship Act. Without this guardrail, the SIR could have silently become a backdoor NRC. The Court refused that.

One more direction deserves appreciation. The EC has been told to refer, within four weeks, all persons whose names were deleted from the 2003 Bihar roll on citizenship grounds to the competent authority — and if that authority finds them to be citizens, their names shall be restored. On paper, this is a meaningful protection.

Now for the cons — and they are serious.

The judgment does not address what is perhaps the most fundamental objection: What the current EC conducted was not a revision at all. It was a de novo collection of data — starting from scratch, discarding rolls on which successive ECs had laboured for nearly three decades. Through painstaking summary revisions, the Commission had achieved about 99 per cent accuracy in the electoral rolls. Elections as consequential as the 2024 general election were conducted on these very rolls without challenge. To throw that work into the dustbin, and to harass 1 billion voters just to fix a residual inaccuracy, is not an SIR within the meaning of Section 21(3). It is something altogether different. The Court simply did not engage with this distinction. That silence is a serious lacuna.

The Court upheld the use of the 2003 roll as the reference baseline, meaning every voter enrolled after 2003 must re-verify. Think carefully about who that is: The young first-time voter, the migrant labourer, the woman newly enrolled under SVEEP.



S Y QURAISHI

Persons deleted erroneously may, the Court says, 'assail the decision of the Commission by way of judicial review'. Picture the voter this is addressed to: The daily wage labourer removed from the rolls

India's West Asia challenge: Stay agile, stay connected



SYED AKBARUDDIN

RARELY IN recent years has West Asia occupied so much space in India's foreign-policy conversation. Attention, however, has not always produced understanding. By breakfast, newspaper columns have sorted the heroes and villains. By prime time, TV hosts have turned the crisis into loyalty tests.

For India, West Asia is not a straight line. It is a Rubik's Cube. Every move shifts another face. There is no single West Asia for New Delhi to align with. Israel, the Gulf and Iran are three principal faces of the same puzzle. A posture that protects defence ties with Israel may complicate Gulf sensitivities. A channel that preserves access to Iran may unsettle partners elsewhere.

The first is a security and technology-oriented West Asia. Here, Israel matters. The relationship is embedded in defence procurement, intelligence-sharing and counter-terrorism capabilities. In a crisis, these are operational assets. Any serious Indian policy must account for this layer, however uncomfortable that may be for those who prefer a purely moral frame.

The second is an economic and human West Asia, the Gulf. For India, it means remittances, oil, gas, investment flows, food security and the safety of its workers abroad. Saudi Arabia and the UAE are both indispensable, but they are not interchangeable. Riyadh carries the weight of oil markets, Islamic legitimacy and bargaining in any future regional settlement. Abu Dhabi's break with OPEC discipline underlines how differently it moves. It is faster, more commercially wired, less bound by old Gulf caution, more open with Israel and more wary of Tehran. For India, there is no single Gulf consensus waiting to be read from one capital. The Gulf has become a cube within the cube.

The third sits on the map itself. For India, Iran is not just a difficult sanctions problem. It is Chabahar, access to Afghanistan and Central Asia, and a reminder that geography keeps its own counsel. A closed channel with Tehran would make India less agile.

These three West Asias do not fit to-

gether easily. Each twists differently, creating pressure elsewhere. Today's crisis has fused Gaza, the US confrontation with Iran, militia activity in Lebanon and pressure on maritime routes into a layered conflict. Even within individual theatres, alignments are not straightforward. In Lebanon, the state's interest in preventing escalation can overlap more with Israel's preference for stability than with Hezbollah's confrontation-driven posture, without making them allies.

This is where the punditry fractures. One camp reads every Indian statement or silence as proof of a tilt towards Israel and the US. Another wants New Delhi to speak in a louder moral register. A third mistakes low visibility for irrelevance. The shallow-west view treats foreign policy as optics.

The claim that India has "chosen" one side ignores India's different interests. The argument that India should have spoken more forcefully assumes that voice alone alters outcomes in a conflict where some actors can change facts on the ground. Moral clarity matters. States, however, inherit consequences that commentators do not. The charge of absence is misleading too. Visibility and access are not the same. India has tried to preserve access rather than spend it on a louder line.

None of this means India has mastered the moment. The risks are now closer to home. West Asia enters India through oil and fertiliser prices, pressure on foreign exchange reserves, a weaker rupee and anxious families. Recent appeals for restraint in fuel use, gold purchases and foreign travel attest to that.

India has recognised that West Asia is not a single contest but a tangle of rivalries, bargains and anxieties. That means policy, even when purposeful, will sometimes appear uneven. Debate and commentary will continue, as they should. India's success in West Asia, however, will be judged by whether it can protect its interests, keep channels open and keep turning the cube without losing sight of the whole.

The writer is former permanent representative of India to the United Nations, and dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy, Hyderabad

These are the citizens that the EC's own outreach programmes spent years bringing into the democratic process. The SIR, as validated, risks systematically disenfranchising the people democratic deepening was meant to reach.

Then there is the documentation problem. The Court upheld the EC's document framework as a "considered exercise of administrative discretion". But a large portion of India's poor do not possess neat documentary proof of identity and residence. The one reliable proof that existed, namely the Elected's Photo Identity Card, has been trashed in one stroke.

Most troubling of all is the remedy the judgment prescribes for wrongful deletions. Persons deleted erroneously may, the Court says, "assail the decision of the Commission by way of judicial review". Picture the voter this is addressed to: The daily wage labourer in Sitarahri or Murshidabad who has been removed from the rolls, possibly without knowing it, possibly having never seen the draft roll, certainly without a lawyer, and almost certainly without the time, money, or legal literacy to file a petition before a competent court. Judicial review is a remedy designed for citizens with resources and time. For the poor voter, it is no remedy at all — it is the law's way of closing a door while appearing to open it.

The citizenship referral direction carries a similar infirmity. The competent authority under the Citizenship Act has no established infrastructure to handle millions of individual cases. The judgment directs completion before "the next Parliamentary, Assembly, or Local Body election, whichever is earlier"

● WORDLY WISE

The good of the people is the greatest law.
— Cicero

— an impossibly compressed timeline. Crucially, the Court has specified no penalty for non-compliance. What if the authority is unable to decide by the earliest upcoming election? Will the voters be advised again to wait till the "next election"? A direction without teeth is a direction in name only.

In West Bengal alone, over 90 lakh names were deleted from the draft rolls. In Tamil Nadu, nearly 74 lakh. The scale of potentially wrongful exclusion is not theoretical. It has already happened. The court's safeguards arrive after the damage.

Just 12 days ago, CJI Surya Kant — the author of the judgment — expressed anguish from the bench about lawyers with fake degrees and no briefs, "like cockroaches". Today, with this judgment, the learned Chief Justice has unwittingly heaped a bounty on them. With crores of wrongfully deleted voters potentially seeking judicial review, the same briefless lawyers across India will find themselves overwhelmed with work. They will laugh all the way to the bank. Whether the poor voter, whose only power was the vote, will find anything to laugh about is quite another matter.

The voter roll is not a bureaucratic document. It is, in practice, every citizen's certificate of democratic belonging. Every name wrongly struck off is democracy denied — not by an enemy of the state, but by the state itself. The SC has told us the SIR is constitutional. What it has not told us — and what no judgment can — is whether a democracy that disenfranchises its poorest voters in the name of clean rolls deserves to call itself one.

Quraishi is former Chief Election Commissioner of India and author of An Undocumented Wonder — The Making of the Great Indian Election

Three-hour rule will turn digital arena into echo chamber



DIVVYA MAHEPAL MADERNNA

INDIA'S DIGITAL landscape has long been a site of productive friction — a place where a billion voices coalesce to signal democratic collaboration. However, the recent notification of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Amendment Rules, 2026, marks a fundamental shift in the state's relationship with the internet. By tightening the leash on "intermediaries" and extending the "broadcasting" tag to individual creators, the government is restricting free speech.

At the heart of the controversy is the new "three-hour rule". Social-media platforms — the intermediaries we rely on for news and connection — must remove "unlawful" content within 180 minutes of receiving a government notice. The shrinking of the compliance window from 36 hours to 180 minutes could end human evaluation. For platforms like Meta or X that manage millions of uploads per minute, a "three-hour deadline" makes human review impossible. No human team can accurately judge a post's legality in such a short window. To safeguard their "safe harbour" immunity (the legal shield that protects platforms from being sued for what their users post), firms will have to rely on AI-driven filters, which are poor at detecting nuance, satire, or regional irony. A political caricature or a stinging critique of a local official, which might be perfectly legal under the reasonable restrictions of Article 19(2), could be flagged by a bot as "incitement".

Another, perhaps more insidious, part of the 2026 framework is the government's attempt to blur the line between citizen and corporation. The rules aim to treat high-reach influencers and independent creators as "digital news broadcasters". A professional newsroom has legal departments to navigate complex government codes. An independent creator or a civic-minded citizen does not. When citizens realise that every viral opinion risks being subjected to the same legal scrutiny as a big media house, the instinct to self-censor becomes overwhelming. This chilling effect doesn't just stop fake news; it chokes independent thought.

The introduction of the Sahyog Portal — an automated government platform that aims to rapidly remove "unlawful" content from the internet — adds to the concerns. Historically, such take-down orders were subject to a centralised process and the scrutiny of high-level committees. Now, a local police officer's interpretation of "public mischief" or "offensive content" can trigger a national blackout of a post. "Truth" could be determined by local sensitivities, not constitutional standards.

The government's primary justification for this amendment is valid. Deepfakes are a threat to our social fabric and misinformation can have deadly consequences. But the solution cannot be built on fear. True safety online comes from transparency, digital literacy, and judicial oversight. If the "three-hour rule" becomes the norm, we are signalling that the state neither trusts its citizens to deliberate nor its judiciary to adjudicate. The internet's greatest value to India was its ability to give the marginalised a voice. If that voice can be silenced by a bot, our digital arena will become nothing more than a government-approved echo chamber.

The writer is national secretary, AICC, co-in-charge of J&K

40 YEARS AGO

May 29, 1986



Burglars loot 10 lakh from bank

BURGLARS MURDERED two chowkidars at the State Bank of Mysore in Regal Building at Connaught Place and looted the bank of about Rs 10 lakh. The chowkidars, Vikram Singh Bhandari (31) of Garhwal and Daya Chand of Rohtak (36) were beaten up and then strangled with electricity wires, the police said. The murders and loot were discovered soon after the bank, facing the outer circle between Regal Cinema and Khadi Gramodyog Bhavan, was to be opened.

Blame for IGI Airport delay

STARTLING FACTS have come to light for the delay in commissioning the Indira Gandhi In-

ternational Airport (IGIA) from November 19, 1985 to May 1, 1986. The study undertaken and data collected reveal that the Civil Aviation Ministry was responsible for the delay. But instead, some senior engineers of the International Airports Authority of India (IAAI) were made scapegoats by asking one to quit while another was reverted without providing them an opportunity to explain.

India, Tamils spurn proposal

BOTH THE Indian Government and the Sri Lankan Tamil groups rejected Sri Lankan National Security Minister Lalith Athulathmudali's proposal for Geneva-type talks between the island government and the militants under the auspices of the Common-

wealth to resolve the crisis. The Union Minister of State for Personnel, P Chidambaram, said that India would not accept any mediation under the Commonwealth's auspices.

NRI consultancy for PSUs

THE STAGE has been set for non-resident Indians (NRIs) to provide management and technical consultancy to Indian public sector companies in a big way with the formation of an NRI firm in New York that will hold a 51 per cent share in a parallel joint venture firm in India. All the public sector undertakings have been asked to subscribe to the share capital of the Indian company, which will also provide the NRI expertise in various fields other than management.



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DIS/AGREE

THE BEST OF BOTH SIDES

A weekly column, which offers not this-versus-that, but the best of both sides, to inform the debate

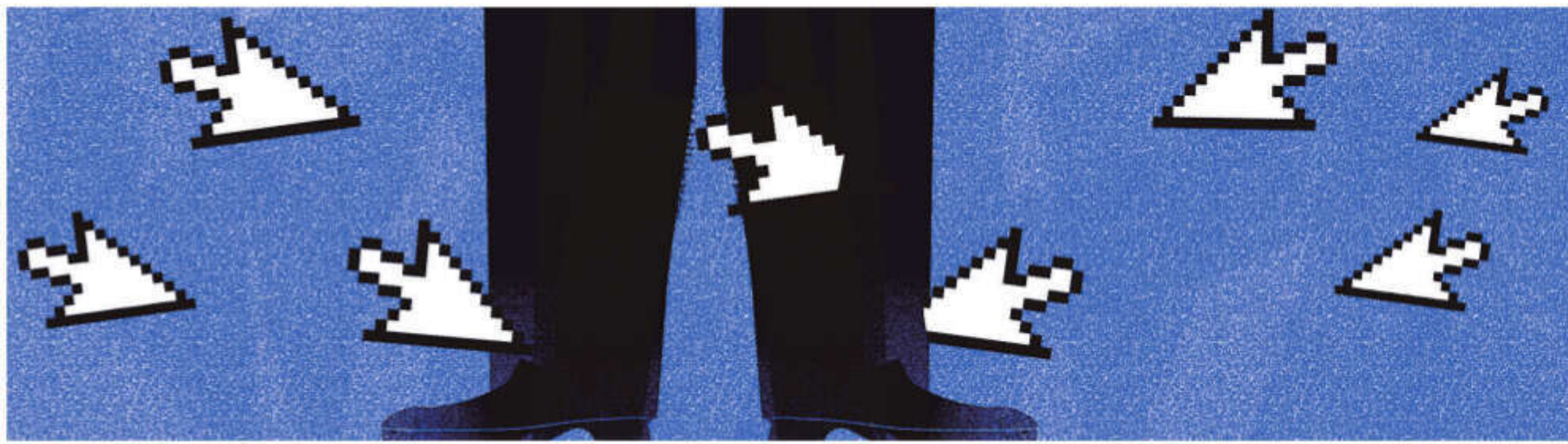


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

What does the virality of the Cockroach Janta Party mean in politics?

CJP frames raw energy, undercurrent



YOGENDRA YADAV

THE CALCULUS of conventional political analysis doesn't get it. For it asks clever, pointless questions: Whodunnit? What's the motive? What's the next move? Its attempt at weighing a shadow reveals nothing but its own fantasies. Or nightmares. This is where political minds could learn something from a poet or a psychologist.

Most reactions to the Cockroach Janta Party miss a simple truth in plain sight. The CJP is not a party. It is no more and no less than the public. It is not a community. Not even a crowd. It is a stack of emotions. It is nowhere close to a movement. It is just a moment.

And that is why it matters. That is why it must not be dismissed. It is a moment that offers us a glimpse. A rare glimpse of an energy that can reclaim the republic from authoritarian assault. Provided we recognise that this is not a wave, but an undercurrent. Provided we can resist the foolish temptation to capture it. Or the stubborn reflex to stand in its way.

At first sight, it fits in with a pattern of midlife crisis of governments with massive mandates, when protest movements came up from nowhere to expose the underbelly of power. The Gujarat and Bihar movements in 1973-74, Assam movement in 1983, Anna movement in 2012 and Kisan Morcha in 2021 — all successfully challenged seemingly invincible governments, bypassing a lacklustre Opposition.

The Narendra Modi government is poised at a similar stage. While the BJP scraped back into power in 2024, it did not retain the kind of dominance or legitimacy that it enjoyed for a decade. Over the past two years, culminating in the successful conquest of Bengal, the BJP government has regained dominance, even if its legitimacy remains fractured. It is no coincidence that the CJP erupted just when the ruling party's stranglehold over electoral contestations appeared near total. The NEET cancellation and the CJI's remarks were the occasion, not the cause.

Yet this moment is much more and much less than the other historical parallels. For starters, it is not a real expression of political energy on the ground. It is one thing to generate synchronised outrage on social media, quite another to convert that into a movement that has feet on the ground, or take it towards a viable political alternative.

The incipient CJP is nowhere there. It has a founder, not necessarily a leader. A vast number of its followers could just be

spectators or curious neophytes with little stomach for real-life political action. A large majority could be expressing diverse, unrelated or even contradictory grievances against an unspecified adversary. As per Ernesto Laclau, this is a defining feature of every such popular protest. This is the raw energy powerful movements are built from.

What makes the CJP more special is the context of growing authoritarianism and its choice of "dilemma action" to take it on. Turning the cockroach into a meme to take on the system is a textbook example of what the Serbian thinker-activist Srđa Popović has been arguing, that humour and unpredictable play is the key to non-violent resistance to authoritarian regimes. *Pranksters vs. Autocrats* (Cornell University Press, 2020) by Popović and Sophia A McClennen spells out why such pranks succeed where regular opposition does not. Such protests put authoritarian rulers in a dilemma: If they permit it, they appear weak; if they suppress it, they appear cruel and absurd. Perhaps unwittingly, the CJP offers a model of dilemma action that democratic resistance could learn from.

More than a method of protest, this moment teaches us to take a clear-eyed view of the political reality of contemporary India. First, no amount of drum-beating around electoral success can hide the growing popular disquiet and distress, especially among the youth. Second, if an all-powerful regime has to invoke national security to ban a meme and deploy its troll army to discredit a social-media trend, it must be very weak within. The greater its conquests, the more vulnerable it is. Third, the parliamentary opposition is not quite up to the task. The 23 million or so followers of CJP have a message for all opposition parties: You need to get your act together.

Therefore we must find a new way to react to the Cockroach Janta Party, away from the usual political cynicism, strategic distancing or tactical embrace. Vinod Kumar Shukla's best-known poem invites us to evolve a new grammar of political solidarity to counter a wide-spread despair: "*Mujhe vah nahin jaanta tha/mere haath badhaane ko jaanta tha ... dono ek doosare ko nahin jaante the/saath chalne ko jaante the* (He did not know me/ But knew my extended hand ... We did not know each other/But knew the walking together)". This is not the camaraderie of revolutionaries, but a companionship of strangers. Not a bond born out of shared identity but one based on shared vulnerability.

These young persons may not know us. Yet they might recognise our extended hand. We may not know each other. But we might learn to walk together in these dark times.

The writer is member, Swaraj India, and national convenor, Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. Views are personal

Watching, liking, sharing is not enough



SHASHWAT

IN TODAY'S India, an Instagram account can become politically influential faster than a political movement can cross a district on foot or bicycle. A meme can travel farther than a manifesto. A reel can reach more people in an hour than months of ground mobilisation. That contrast says something important about the political culture we are entering.

Last February, in the eastern Uttar Pradesh district of Deoria, a Gen Z youth named Jai Maurya was cycling across villages for MGNREGA workers. Now, social media is flooded with discussions around the Cockroach Janta Party, an online phenomenon that rapidly gained visibility among young Indians. Its follower count grew at an astonishing speed. Citing national-security concerns, the Intelligence Bureau has got its account on X withheld in India. The two developments belong to different worlds. One emerged from the internet, the other from the road. Yet placing them side by side reveals an important shift in how politics is increasingly experienced by young Indians.

When I later watched Jai's video, something stayed with me. The veins in his neck were stretched with exhaustion. His breathing was uneven. There was no dramatic soundtrack, no carefully edited frame, no influencer-like performance. He was not acting for a screen. He was carrying politics on his body.

That difference feels significant today.

The concern is not that young people are angry. India faces unemployment, expensive education, rising living costs and growing uncertainty about the future. Political frustration among the youth is neither surprising nor illegitimate. The more important question is what forms this anger now takes, what ideological direction it acquires, and whether digital politics is encouraging participation or merely visibility.

Jai belongs to the first educated generation in his family. His father is a welder. His mother ran a small general store to pay his fees. Jai would return from school and help at the family shop. This is also the story of caste, class and inherited privilege. Some inherit confidence, language and networks. Others inherit labour and responsibility.

Jai was not alone. Fifteen young people, all university graduates and all part of Gen Z, led this month-long cycle *yatra*. You may not know that economist Jean Drèze cycled with them for part of the route. You may not know that these young people travelled nearly 1,200 kilometres across eastern UP between January and February 2026, moving through Chauri Chaura, Gorakhpur, Deoria, Ballia, Mau, Ghazipur and finally Varanasi. Every day, they cycled between 25

and 35 kilometres and spoke to workers in several villages. Local political workers often arranged food. They sat in chaupals, discussed migration, delayed wages and rural employment. Their *yatra* also had an Instagram account. In one month, it gained barely 500 followers. But the participants did not seem especially disturbed by that.

And perhaps that is the larger political question of our time: Has the algorithm become the final judge of political relevance? Does a struggle stop mattering because it does not trend? Is a movement unsuccessful because it cannot become a reel?

The German philosopher Theodor Adorno once warned that modern media could gradually transform politics into entertainment. That observation feels unexpectedly contemporary.

Every political emotion now has to adapt to the logic of the screen. A slogan must become visual. A protest must become instantly shareable. Social-media platforms reward outrage and speed. The problem is not technology itself. The problem is when politics becomes entirely shaped by the logic of visibility.

Following an account begins to feel like political participation. But democracy requires more than watching, liking and sharing. It requires involvement. It requires discomfort. Sometimes it even requires sacrifice. A few days after this *yatra* ended, 14 Gen Z students from JNU were sent to Tihar Jail after taking out a march demanding a safer campus. They were later released after court intervention.

What connects these young people is not just anger. It is ideology. This is where inequality becomes important. Can the son of an agricultural labourer spend hours online building a digital movement? He may not have stable internet, free time or confidence in English-speaking online spaces. He may be working in the fields while someone else makes reels. Only those who can remain visible online are seen. But huge parts of India remain invisible, in fields, factories, railway stations, brick kilns, coaching centres and rented rooms.

Much of today's anti-establishment politics depends on giant corporate platforms like Instagram, Meta and X. Political emotion is shaped through systems driven by engagement and profit.

This is why difficult political questions often disappear beneath digital excitement. What does a movement think about caste? About labour rights? About economic inequality? About minorities?

India is too unequal and too socially complex for democracy to survive only online. The internet can spread information and connect people, but it cannot replace roads, village meetings, workers' gatherings and public conversations.

Because democracy is still built through physical effort. It is still built through walking, listening, arguing and organising. The road still matters in politics.

The writer is producer, Indian Express Hindi. shashwat.upadhyay@indianexpress.com

A promise to Delhi's women & girls: No more silence on menstruation



REKHA GUPTA

FOR GENERATIONS, the word "menstruation" has been carefully avoided in classroom conversations, in homes, and certainly in Indian public life. That silence ended on the 74th Independence Day, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed the nation without reservation and spoke about menstrual hygiene. He highlighted the government's efforts to make sanitary pads accessible to all women and brought an important yet often-ignored issue into the national conversation. The Prime Minister using a major occasion to mainstream the discussion on menstrual hygiene was refreshing.

Under the PM Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana, Suvidha sanitary pads are available at just Rs 1 per pad through Jan Aushadhi Kendras. So far, over 100 crore pads have been sold through these Kendras across the nation. For many women and adolescent girls, they symbolise freedom from hesitation, financial burden, and unsafe alternatives.

For generations, menstruation has been treated as something to be endured silently. This silence has cost our girls their confidence, our women their dignity, and our society its progress. For too long, that

quiet anxiety has been treated as her private burden to carry. Taking inspiration from PM Modi's initiatives for women's empowerment, the Delhi government is launching the campaign "Menstrual Health Matters: Periods Parr Sahi Jaankari, Harr Beti ki Pehli Taiyaari". The right information about periods is every daughter's first and most basic preparation for life. The Delhi government will create a modern, future-ready, and *viksit* Delhi where every girl can attend school during her period without anxiety, every woman can go to work without fear or embarrassment, and every family can discuss menstrual health with scientific understanding.

The heart of this campaign is promoting menstrual health education in Delhi schools. The Upanishads teach us, "*Tamasso maa jyotirgamaya* (Lead me from darkness to light)." The stigma around menstruation is a kind of darkness: Not of the body but of ignorance, of inherited shame, of things left unsaid. We will launch a campaign in schools on menstruation and menstrual hygiene covering emotional well-being, active stigma reduction, and, crucially, health-seeking behaviour. It will ensure that a girl learns not only what is happening to her body but that asking for help is normal, safe, and her right. Additionally, this will be directly linked to awareness of HPV and cervical cancer. Cervical cancer remains one of the most common cancers among Indian women, and it is also one of the most preventable. By connecting menstrual health to HPV awareness, we treat a girl's reproductive health holistically.

Education related to menstrual hygiene cannot be aimed solely at girls. We will also reach out to boys to help them understand menstruation and reduce teasing. Moreover, when brothers understand it, the home becomes kinder. When future husbands and fathers-in-law understand it, families will become happier, healthier, and more supportive. ASHA and Anganwadi workers, considered the backbone of community health in Delhi's districts, will help spread awareness.

Regarding access, the government will issue a clear directive on sanitary pad vending machines. Our commitment is not merely to installing new machines but also to keeping them working, properly maintained, and regularly refilled. All sanitary pads will be biodegradable and compostable.

According to many estimates, a woman in India spends close to Rs 1 lakh on menstrual products over her lifetime. This is a tax on her body that she never agreed to. And every year, billions of disposable pads end up in our landfills. The Menstrual Health Matters campaign lifts the financial burden off women's shoulders without adding to the mountain of waste.

I want to tell every woman and girl of Delhi: Your health matters, your comfort matters, your dignity matters. You were never meant to carry this in silence, and from today, you will not have to. The Menstrual Health Matters campaign will benefit you all immensely and improve your quality of life. When menstruation is treated as shameful, girls miss school and slip behind. Women delay seeing a doctor, and conditions like anaemia and infections

go unnoticed until they become difficult to treat. This campaign will confront these challenges by starting an honest, scientifically informed conversation about menstruation, one that can take place within every family without shame or hesitation. I promise every girl and woman in Delhi that this will not be a campaign that spans just one day or uses just one hashtag. We promise

that the men of this city will be part of the change, not excused from it.

Savitribai Phule, the pioneer who first opened the doors of education to the girls of this land, urged them: "Go, get education. Be self-reliant, be industrious." That call still stands as knowledge of one's own body is the most basic education of all, and self-reliance begins with the dignity of understanding what every woman lives with each month. That freedom begins with something as ordinary and as long denied as the ability to understand and manage one's own body without shame. And that change is not built by the government alone; it is built in homes. The government can install vending machines, conduct sessions, and issue orders. But what we also need is a whole-of-society approach to break the stigma around menstruation.

Today, we must make a collective promise: To ensure that no girl in Delhi will be made to feel ashamed of her body. No woman will be denied dignity because of poverty, silence, or neglect. No family will be allowed to remain trapped in myths when science, care, and compassion are available.

The writer is the Chief Minister of Delhi

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Blot on CBSE

ONCE, THE CBSE was considered synonymous with quality and competitiveness in school education, and many in the rural population were envious of children who had ready access to such an education system ('Exam reform needs patience, preparedness', *IE*, May 28). The study materials, curriculum, and quality of the system attracted many to it, and gradually CBSE schools became a common sight almost everywhere in India. The present appalling scenario of the lapses in the method of evaluation of answer sheets is definitely a blot and an indication of a lack of seriousness and impetus in implementing a reform flawlessly.

Jiji Panicker K, Alappuzha

Al conundrum

ANUBHA YADAV raises a valid and timely concern. ('With AI, writers enter age of permanent suspicion', *IE*, May 18). Questions regarding legitimacy and authorship, however, did not begin with artificial intelligence. Literary history has long witnessed debates over plagiarism, ghostwriting, and dis-

puted authorship. Even the authorship of the Bard of Avon continues to be debated in some circles. That said, technology cannot be shunned. Humanity has always learned to live with scientific and technological breakthroughs — with both awe and anxiety.

Naval Thorat, Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar

Colossal loss

THE PASSING of Sonny Rollins feels like a colossal loss — as immense as the immortal title history itself bestowed upon him, the "Saxophone Colossus" ('Saxophone colossus, and a seeker', *IE*, May 28). With his death fades one of the final guardians of an artistic age when music still carried moral gravity, spiritual yearning, and historical memory. Through masterpieces such as 'St. Thomas', 'Oleo', 'Blue 7', and the politically defiant *Freedom Suite*, Rollins transformed the wounds of segregation, racial humiliation, and civilisational unrest into rhythms of astonishing beauty and resilience. His saxophone possessed the temperament of a living force of nature.

Vijay Singh Adhikari, Nainital



SUJATA ASHWARYA

MINILATERAL ARRANGEMENTS have multiplied, but only a few acquire durability. The Quad foreign ministers' meeting is a good occasion to ask why this grouping has lasted when many remain fragile. India, Japan, Australia and the US have all had to respond to China's assertiveness, and the Quad gives them a way to coordinate without a formal alliance. But China alone does not explain its endurance. It has held through political change in Australia and Japan, shifts in US strategic posture, and India's balancing across partnerships. A purely strategic arrangement would have been more exposed to electoral cycles.

The answer lies in the cooperative prac-

The quiet work that sustains Quad

tice built since the Quad was revived in 2017. Leaders' meetings get headlines. Foreign ministers give it political direction. But much of the deeper work has happened in working groups on maritime domain awareness, critical technologies, health, infrastructure and climate. These have produced modest deliverables, but their importance lies more in the habits formed among bureaucracies. Officials from the four states have developed habits of consultation that no longer require constant political prompting. They have learned to anticipate one another's positions, understand constraints, and read signals with the fluency that comes from repeated engagement. This distinguishes durable cooperation from transactional alignment. Several groupings are dependent on immediate interests. When those shift, they fade or become something else. BRICS is telling: Expansion has given it visibility, but

scale does not automatically produce trust.

The Quad's cooperation has developed in domains that are not purely security-coded. Vaccine distribution, undersea cables, critical minerals, cyclone response and maritime awareness have given the four governments occasions to practise cooperation where the stakes are real but the strategic temperature is lower. A grouping that meets only around threats can remain trapped in immediate calculation. One that works across a broader agenda has more room to build habits of trust and restraint. This is why the New Delhi joint statement matters. Its emphasis on maritime surveillance, critical minerals, undersea cables, counterterrorism and humanitarian assistance shows the institutional breadth that now supports the Quad. Its language of concrete initiatives and tangible benefits confirms that durability rests on repeated coop-

eration across practical domains.

Much of contemporary international politics is transactional. States bargain for immediate advantage, treat partners as instruments, and enter or exit cooperation as convenience dictates. Adam Smith understood the danger: Cooperation among parties who do not recognise one another as legitimate evaluators of their conduct can lose moral restraint, even when it speaks the language of mutual benefit. For India, the Quad shows what is possible when partnership is allowed to deepen beyond immediate exchange. Minilateral arrangements that invest in this capacity are more likely to endure. The Quad's durability lies not only in the strategic balance it serves, but in the quiet habits of cooperation that now sustain it.

The writer is professor, Centre for West Asian Studies, Jamia Millia Islamia

Shah: No legal action if infiltrators leave Bengal on their own

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, May 28

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah on Thursday referred to news reports that hundreds of people were leaving West Bengal and heading to Bangladesh after the new BJP government came to power in the state and said that “since the infiltrators are returning on their own”, the government would not take any legal action against them.

“Suwendu Adhikari and the BJP government in Bengal have established detention centres, but we all want the infiltrators who have entered illegally to return on their own. If they do so, the Bengal government will not take any legal action against them,” Shah said during a public meeting in his Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency. He also inaugurated and laid the foundation for projects worth Rs 340 crore.

“I hope that before the identification campaign starts, several people will leave on their own. Our government has resolved to identify every single infiltrator and remove them from the country,” Shah said.

The Adhikari government in Bengal has opened detention camps as part of its “detect, delete and deport” policy.

Shah also referred to the demographic change committee announced by Prime Min-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah in Gujarat's Kalol on Thursday. PTI

ister Narendra Modi this week, saying it would seek reasons for unnatural demographic changes and suggest laws if required. “If required to frame any law for the same, that will be deliberated too. The demographic change committee will submit its report within a year, and this artificial demographic change will be bestopped,” he said.

The BJP had promised to implement these measures in its election manifesto ahead of the recently concluded Assembly elections, accusing the previous TMC government of failing to enforce the directive. Further, referring to the Assembly election manifesto promise of securing the international border, Shah said, “We said during the election that if you hand over the rule to us, we will make the border secure by fencing along the Bangladesh border and com-

mence the work within a few days. I congratulate Suwendu Adhikari that within seven days, 600 hectares of land have been handed over to the BSF. Even along the Chicken Neck (the corridor in Bengal that connects the northeastern states with the rest of India), 121 hectares of land have been handed over to the Government of India.”

At another public event in Ahmedabad, Shah said: “Previously, 5,000-10,000 infiltrations would take place every day, but now 5,000-10,000 infiltrators are returning.”

In a post on social media, Adhikari stated that the West Bengal government has initiated measures to strengthen border security by facilitating the construction of BSF outposts and barbed-wire fencing, further enhancing security in the border areas.

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, May 28

THE CALL came just after midnight. At Shyam Shah Medical College, Archana Kushwaha, 26, from Akla village in Madhya Pradesh's Sihawal, began bleeding heavily after delivery. She had travelled 109 km in a Bolero after the local clinic could not treat her. “At first they said she had time till morning,” her father-in-law, Premlal Kushwaha, said. “Then suddenly they panicked — ‘*jaldi laakhon*’ (procure blood fast).” It was the middle of the night; relatives scrambled to find blood. Before they returned, a nurse stepped out again: “Ask your relative to come back. Your patient has expired.” Archana died on January 7, 2026, of atonic postpartum haemorrhage, leaving behind a three-year-old son.

She was among 53 women who died between April 2025 and March 2026 in the state's Sidhi district before, during or after childbirth; *The Indian Express* spoke to the families of 20.

● In September last year,



Maternity wing at the district hospital in Sidhi. EXPRESS

the family of Geeta Kol, 31, from Baghailla in Majhauli, was told by the district hospital in Sidhi that she needed AB-positive blood. “They did not have it. Private hospitals were asking Rs 12,000–13,000 for one bag,” her brother-in-law, Betu Rawat, claimed. Geeta died on September 22, 2025, in transit, with severe anaemia listed as the cause.

● Beena Baiga, 21, from

Naikni in Rampur Naikin, delivered at a primary health centre in Pondi. “Thirty minutes later, she started bleeding heavily,” her husband Anuj Baiga said. She was referred to Sidhi, then to Rewa. On November 14, 2025, while still on the road, she died near Gurh of postpartum haemorrhage with a retained placenta. “I kept telling her, keep your eyes open... everything will be fine. She

died in my arms,” he said.

● For Sangeeta Singh, 22, from Chhuhi in Majhauli, a chain of transfers preceded her death. She was taken to a local hospital at 8 pm, kept there until 5 am, then sent to Sidhi and quickly referred to Rewa. She died en route on December 28, 2025, of acute hepatic failure. “We could not get an ambulance at the right time,” her husband Ajay Singh said. “I even had to pay Rs 200 and feed the driver.”

● In Khairahi, Seeta Bai Sahu, 25, went into labour late at night. An ambulance took her to Marwas, where she delivered around midnight. An hour later, she was told to leave for Sidhi. “The ambulance tyre was punctured,” her husband Mangleshwar claimed. He borrowed Rs 2,000 and woke up his neighbours so they could take him. At the district hospital, doctors identified blood loss; he donated blood. “They said she was saved,” he said. But by 4 am, she was dead. Seeta Bai died on December 12, 2025, with severe anaemia recorded.

● For Lalita Rajak, 30, from Godahi in Sihawal, the first sign was a headache. By the time her husband Vijay found a vehicle in the rain, her condition had worsened. They first diverted to Deosar, then to Sidhi, and were referred onward to Rewa. “The doctors said she may or may not survive; you have to rush,” he said. By then, she was unconscious. The family, bonded labourers in Singrauli, had already spent up to Rs 30,000. Lalita died on July 22, 2025, of meningitis, leaving a nine-year-old daughter.

● Sunita Kol, 31, from Pondi, had been unwell for weeks. After treatment at a private hospital and a PHC, she was taken to Sidhi and then referred to Rewa when labour began. “They refused to admit her, saying there was a blood shortage,” her husband Anish Kol claimed. “An hour later, she was referred out.” She died in the ambulance on October 31, 2025, of severe anaemia. “If they had told me 30 minutes earlier, she could have been saved,” he said.

● Maternal deaths in Sidhi

53 WOMEN who died before, during or after childbirth in one year

- Their average age 26
- Youngest was 19

Died in transit, in ambulances or vehicles scrambled by families	13
Died at home	13
Deaths where anaemia was a contributing factor	16

MATERNAL MORTALITY RATE		
Sidhi district	Madhya Pradesh	National average
211	159	87

22 Maternity ward staff; around 40 are required

1 Anaesthesiologist at the district hospital, unavailable for night shifts



tribal communities, have poor diets and are anaemic.”

Smaller healthcare centres show a similar strain

The district hospital that *The Indian Express* visited sits at the top of a referral chain that also comprises community and primary health centres, where antenatal check-ups are conducted, low-risk deliveries are handled, and complications are caught early. Except, the situation is just as stark there.

At the Rampur Naikin primary health centre, about 50 kilometres away, staff nurse Manju Singh describes a cramped labour room with no isolation for infectious cases. There are three health workers against a sanctioned strength of five, and six staff nurses in the labour room instead of eight.

The facility has a blood storage unit but no transfusion capability. “If a pregnant woman needs blood, we refer her to Rewa,” Singh said. “We face a heavy load and cannot treat everyone. Rewa is an hour and a half away. If two emergencies come at once and both need blood, there is no contingency.”

Between April 2025 and March 2026, the PHC recorded 2,387 admissions, of which 21 were stillbirths.

The facility runs three MMU (mobile medical unit) ambulances, including a Janani vehicle for pregnant women, staffed with a driver but no medical personnel.

Praveen Kumar Mishra, a Janani vehicle driver, said, “Many villages don’t have roads. Most cases come during the monsoon, when roads are washed away. Women are carried on cots for two to three kilometres to reach the ambulance.” At least four more vehicles are needed to cover the tehsil, he said.

At the Sihawal primary health centre, more than 60

kilometres from Sidhi, nursing officer Pushpa Dwivedi points to registers listing stockouts. Crucial drugs such as labetalol and methyldopa for hypertension in pregnancy are running low; emergency medicines like injectable hydralazine are out of stock, as are uterotonics such as carboprost, used to control postpartum haemorrhage. The centre also lacks basic supplies such as sanitary pads and has not stocked some antibiotics, including ampicillin tablets, she said. The staff said supplies are irregular, and replenishment requests often take time to be approved and delivered through district procurement channels.

Of its three delivery tables, two are defunct, leaving a single functional table for all births. Five nurses are in place against a requirement of eight to nine. There are no permanent doctors, and no gynaecologist, forcing staff to stretch across roles—even pulling personnel from the operating theatre to cover shifts in the labour room during staff shortages and high patient load.

Between April 1, 2025, and March 21, 2026, the PHC conducted 875 deliveries but referred more than 120 cases, largely because it lacked the staff to manage them.

State Health Minister Rajendra Shukla’s office refused to comment on queries from *The Indian Express*. The health department refused to comment on the allegations specifically pertaining to the deaths in Sidhi. A health department official noted that as per the latest figures of the Government of India’s Sample Registration System, Madhya Pradesh’s maternal mortality ratio has declined from 173 in 2018–20 to 135 in 2022–24. The department has said this was “achieved through the promotion of institutional deliveries, the availability of trained doctors and staff, and the expansion of emergency obstetric services.”

3 dead, 4 missing as farm workers’ country boat capsizes near Patna

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, May 28

THREE PERSONS were killed and four others remained missing after a country boat carrying farm workers capsized in the Ganga near Sultanpur Diara in Bihar’s Samastipur district early Thursday, officials said.

According to the Patna district administration, the incident occurred at around 5.45 am when residents of Bind Toli were returning from agricultural work across the river in Mohiuddinnagar area of Samastipur. The group had reportedly travelled to Sultanpur Diara for harvesting pointed gourd and other farm work, a routine practice for many local residents.

The administration said that 14 people had boarded the boat from Umanath Ghat near Barh to travel to Sultanpur Diara. “While returning, the boat over-

turned near Sultanpur Diara in Samastipur due to strong winds,” an official said, adding rescue teams saved seven persons, while three bodies were recovered by afternoon. Search operations continued for four others who remained untraced.

Meanwhile, Patna Police said preliminary findings indicated that the boat’s motor had developed a technical fault before the vessel lost control in strong winds and capsized. “The boat became uncontrollable due to a motor malfunction and strong winds,” an official said, adding that seven persons had initially gone missing after the accident.

Officials said that personnel from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), and local divers were engaged in an intensive search operation in the river. Sri Ram Krishna, Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDPO)-

1, Barh, said that the exact number of passengers on board was being verified, though initial information suggested between 14 and 18 people were travelling in the small dinghy boat.

“People from Bind Toli regularly cross the river for farming-related work in Mohiuddinnagar, under Samastipur. The boat capsized after its motor reportedly malfunctioned and strong winds destabilised it,” the officer said. Three bodies had been recovered with the assistance of local divers and NDRF-SDRF teams, while efforts to locate the remaining persons continued. Senior district officials from Patna and Samastipur were coordinating rescue efforts. The Patna district administration said Patna DM Dr Thiyyagarajan S M had reached Barh to oversee relief and rescue operations, and instructed officials to expedite all necessary action.

{ BASHIR BADR • 1935-2026 }

Bashir Badr, the poet who modernised Urdu ghazal, dies

Aishwarya Khosla
New Delhi, May 28

BASHIR BADR, the poet who modernised the Urdu ghazal by bringing it closer to colloquial language, a departure from the Persian influence of Ghalib and Mir, died in Bhopal on Thursday. He was 91.

Born in the winter of 1935 in Ayodhya, then part of the United Provinces in British India, he composed his first couplet at the age of seven. Badr recited his first ghazal before an audience in 1946 in Etawah at an All India Mushaira organised on the occasion of Urs. The city’s chief present at the mushaira gave the poet, whose name was Sayed Mohammad Bashir, the title Badr, meaning moon.

A meritorious student throughout, Badr collected many awards as he pursued his education from college to doctorate at Aligarh Muslim University, before returning to his alma mater as a lecturer. He later joined Meerut College as the Head of the Urdu Department, a post he held for 17 years.

It was during his time in Meerut that Badr met historian S Irfan Habib. “His romantic and political ghazals made him a popular figure in mushairas across the Indian subcontinent, and he was often travelling. When he could no longer balance his travels with his teaching commitments, he resigned after 17 years,” Habib said.

The attack on his house in Meerut’s Shastri Nagar during



He composed his first couplet at the age of seven

the riots of 1986 firmed his decision to leave the city. “He was very hurt,” recalled Habib. Badr subsequently moved to Bhopal, where his wife’s family resided. After the Meerut incident he wrote the widely quoted couplet: “*Log toot jaate hain ek ghar banan mein, tum taras nahikhate bastiyan jalane mein* (People spend all they have building one home, you feel no remorse burning down entire settlements).”

Badr has seven poetry collections in Urdu and one in Hindi to his credit, including the ghazal collections *Ikai*, *Kulliyate Bashir Badr*, *Aamad*, *Image*, *Aahat* and *Ujale Apni Yadon Ke* (The Light of My Memories), the last written in the Devanagari script. He also authored two critical works — *Azadi Ke Bad Urdu Ghazal Ka Tanqid-i-Mutala* (A Critical Study of Urdu Ghazal after Independence) and *Biswin Sadi Mein Ghazal* (The Ghazal in the Twentieth Century).

Such was his stature that while he was still a student, his work had become part of curricu-

lum. Speaking to *PTI*, his son Tayeb Badr recalled an anecdote from his father’s student days at AMU. During a viva, Badr was asked to explain the deeper meaning of his own couplet — “*Ab hum milenge toh kayi log bichad jayenge, intezaar aur karo agle janam tak mera* (If we meet, many people will be separated; wait a little longer for my next life)”. The examiner, unaware that Badr had written those lines, fundamentally disagreed with his interpretation of the couplet.

Another popular couplet, “*Dushmani jam kar karo lekin ye gunjaish rahe, jab kabhi hum dost ho jayenge toh sharmindah nahon* (Perform your role as enemies wholeheartedly, but make sure if we ever become friends, neither of us feel ashamed)”, was quoted years later by the then President of Pakistan, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, when he and then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi signed the Shimla Agreement in July 1972. Badr was awarded the Padma Shri in 1999 for his contribution to literature.

Noted lyricist Javed Akhtar posted on X: “Today, our language Urdu has become a little poorer. Bashir Badr, an extremely melodious poet, has departed from our gathering forever. This poet and his poetry will live on in our memories forever.”

Habib said the poet had been bedridden for a decade due to Parkinson’s disease and dementia. “He passed away today, but we lost him a decade ago,” he said.

[FROM PAGE 1]

Ground Zero for maternal deaths

To understand what led to the 53 deaths that are now under the state’s scanner, *The Indian Express* accessed maternal death records, visited the largest district hospital, and spoke to the families of at least 20 women [see accompanying story].

Some things stood out:

● Sixteen of the 53 women died at the Shyam Shah Medical College, a tertiary referral centre about 70 km from Sidhi.

● Thirteen women died in transit — in ambulances, hired vehicles or private cars driven by loved ones who struggled to find transport.

● Thirteen died at home.

● Five died at the district hospital in Sidhi, and four at private facilities.

● One death each was recorded at Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Medical College and SGMH, Rewa.

● The average age of the women was 26; most were first- or second-time mothers. The youngest was 19.

● Where causes were identified — in 40 of the 53 cases — they point to conditions that could have been addressed with timely care. Obstetric haemorrhage, both postpartum and antepartum, accounted for 12 deaths; hypertensive disorders, mainly eclampsia, for seven; and severe anaemia for five.

● Beyond the immediate causes, the review flags anaemia — specifically iron and folic acid deficiency — as a contributing factor in 16 deaths.

● Puerperal sepsis and other infections claimed four lives, and abortion-related complications three. The review also notes two deaths from thrombocytopenia, and single cases of cardiac failure, pulmonary aspiration and amniotic fluid embolism — conditions requiring intensive care beyond the district’s capacity.

● One woman died from a snakebite during pregnancy; another by suicide. These cases also figure in the district’s Maternal Death Review records because the audit reviews all deaths occurring during pregnancy or within the postpartum period, though not all may fall under direct obstetric causes used in official MMR calculations.

● Thirteen cases await post-mortem reports.

At a divisional review in Rewa in December last year, chaired by the Mission Director of the National Health Mission, officials highlighted that Sidhi had recorded the highest ma-

ternal mortality in the division: 38 in nine months between April and December 2025.

The department was critical of Dr S B Khare, the chief civil surgeon and head of the district hospital, during the divisional review, and subsequently in a show-cause notice issued in February this year by the then Civil Surgeon and Chief Hospital Superintendent of Sidhi district hospital, which cited “poor decision-making during delivery,” “lack of preparedness of facilities,” and a “failure to ensure (that) benefits of government maternal schemes reach the public,” which it said had damaged the government’s image.

The notice added that Sidhi had “consistently ranked among the bottom three districts in CMHL (Community Maternal Health League grading, used by the state health department to assess maternal and child health performance),” with maternal and child health outcomes “among the worst in the state.”

Dr Khare, when contacted, said the district hospital was working to strengthen its screening process to identify high-risk pregnancies and severe anaemia, and to bolster its blood bank units. “We are yet to respond to the showcause notice. The data shows a high number of deaths, but this isn’t the correct picture. Many cases were from other districts,” he claimed.

The main hospital: Overwhelmed, understaffed, underequipped

Nowhere is the strain on the system more visible than at the maternity ward of Sidhi District Hospital, which is constantly handling pregnant women arriving with cramps, weakness and painful contractions. District Health Officer Dr Sunita Tiwari, who oversees the ward, told *The Indian Express*, “I am also the hospital’s sonographer, and I work in the OPD and handle administrative duties. I am doing the work of four people.” Between April 2025 and March 2026, the hospital recorded 10,022 admissions in the maternity ward and 5,922 deliveries. Of these, 726 were C-sections — a rate the health department flagged as below average during reviews conducted between late 2025 and early 2026, largely because the hospital has only one anaesthesiologist, a critical gap in managing high-risk pregnancies.

“The anaesthesiologist works only for eight hours and

then refuses to turn up for emergency night shifts. Many other staff keep taking leave, and we face that difficulty,” Dr Khare claimed. The hospital received 1,109 referrals from peripheral centres and, in turn, referred 492 patients to higher facilities — 486 of them to Rewa. An internal review by the district health authorities of 383 referral cases between April and December 2025 found that many were made for “avoidable reasons.”

“One of the main reasons for high referrals is the lack of additional anaesthesiologist,” said Dr Babita Khare, Chief Medical and Health Officer of Sidhi. “I’ve written repeatedly for an additional anaesthesiologist,” said Dr Tiwari. “There is none on the night shift, which is when most cases arrive. We cannot handle caesarean deliveries and have no option but to refer patients.”

District records also show four sanctioned posts for gynaecologists in Sidhi, but staffing remains thin. “One specialist visits Sihawal twice a week for sonography, and there is only one anaesthesiologist at the district hospital,” an official said.

The burden is substantial. Between April 2025 and March 2026, the district hospital and referral network handled 1,706 high-risk pregnancies. The maternity ward managing this load has 22 staff members, including supervisors, while around 40 are required. “We need a dedicated OT, a blood storage unit, a paediatrician, an anaesthesiologist, and even a ventilation unit in the maternity ward,” an official said.

Blood supply is another reason for referral to other districts. Officials at the maternity ward said patients are sometimes referred to other hospitals due to lack of platelets at the blood bank, which isn’t equipped with a blood component separation unit. The hospital’s blood bank had just seven units in stock, according to its in-charge, Dr Sunidhi Singh, when *The Indian Express* visited the facility in April. “We managed to finally get 53 units of blood after organising blood donation camps this month. We hope to have at least five to six units per day with this new supply,” Dr Singh said on Thursday.

Responding to questions on maternal deaths, Dr Babita Khare said an inquiry had been initiated, pointing in part to the district’s terrain. “I have been trying to bring down maternal mortality in Sidhi, but it isn’t declining,” she said. “Many villages are hard to reach, and most women, largely from

Goa nightclub blaze: ED attaches properties worth Rs 11 cr

Express News Service
Panaji, May 28

THE ED Panaji zonal office has attached properties valued at over Rs 11.01 crore under provisions of the PMLA in connection with the investigation pertaining to the alleged illegal operation of the Birch by Romeo Lane nightclub in Goa.

A fire at the nightclub in North Goa’s Arpora on De-

cember 6 last year killed 25 people, including five tourists. Brothers Saurabh and Gaurav Luthra, who ran the club, took a flight from Delhi to Phuket at 5.30 am on December 7, just hours after the incident, which took place just before midnight the previous day. They had booked the tickets at 1.17 am, just 90 minutes after the blaze.

The Goa Police had booked the Luthra brothers and the club’s

partners, manager, event organiser and other managing staff and charged the accused with culpable homicide.

A magisterial inquiry, set up by the government to probe the fire at the club had found that the local panchayat “coluded” with the owners of the property, allowing the club to be run illegally without a valid trade licence. The panchayat “failed in its statutory duty”

and took no action to seal the property or shut its operations, the inquiry said.

The ED had initiated a probe on the basis of FIRs registered by the Goa Police at Anjuna police station and Mapusa police station against Luthra brothers and others under various provisions of the BNS, 2023. In a statement, the ED said the FIRs pertain not just to the fire incident on December 6, 2025, but also to of-

fences for forgery of documents, including fake and fabricated No Objection Certificates (NOCs) and other statutory documents used for the purpose of obtaining regulatory approvals.

The ED said a probe under PMLA has revealed that the establishment was being operated by M/s Being GS Hospitality Goa Arpora LLP without obtaining mandatory statutory approvals, including the fire NOC.



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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

● GLOBAL

Why it is almost impossible to bring down bodies from Everest ‘death zone’

Yashree
New Delhi, May 28

HYDERABAD RESIDENT Arun Kumar Tiwari fulfilled a long-standing dream last week — summiting Mount Everest. He had barely begun his descent, however, when his health failed and he died. His family has decided to leave his body there to honour his love for the mountains. Fellow mountaineer Sandeep Are, 47, also died on the same day (May 21). Are’s body was recovered as he died lower down on the mountain.

In Tiwari’s case, the family made an informed decision — bringing a body back from Mount Everest is notoriously difficult and expensive.

In fact, bodies have lain on the mountain for years, serving both as warnings and landmarks for climbers every year. One of the most well-known bodies is simply called Green Boots. Believed to be that of Ladakhi climber Tsewang Paljor, it has lain on the Everest route for 30 years, the bright green boots clearly visible. Another is



Mt. Everest. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

THE 2PM RULE

- More people die climbing down Everest than going up because they push themselves to reach the summit.
- The 2 pm rule is that one must start climbing down at that time, no matter how close to the summit they are.
- This timing is crucial because weather that high in the mountain is tricky — a storm can gather and darkness can fall very quickly, making the risky descent much more dangerous.

Sleeping Beauty, the remains of American climber Francys Arsentiev who died in 1998.

Over the past few years, the Nepal government has launched massive clean-up operations in the Himalayas as more and more people attempt to climb Everest, crowding and cluttering the mountain. While the government has also brought down some bodies, over 100 are still believed to be up there.

Why is it so hard to bring down a body from Mt Everest?

Arun Kumar Tiwari was part of an expedition managed by Hyderabad-based Boots and Crampons and Nepal’s Pioneer Adventure. Pioneer Adventure’s Executive Director Nivesh Karki told *The Indian Express*: “Tiwari died around 8,790 metres, just below the Everest summit, which stands at 8,848 metres.

Retrieving a body from that elevation is almost totally impossible. There are technical and financial challenges, but the rescuers are also at risk themselves.”

The region above 8,000 metres is known as the “death zone”. Only about one-third of the oxygen we breathe at sea level is available there. People in the death zone can experience light-headedness, brain swelling (high-altitude cerebral oedema) or fluid buildup in the lungs (high-altitude pulmonary oedema). The latter two can be fatal. Rescuers in these areas would, thus, be putting themselves in serious danger. To add to this, the terrain is challenging, with steep, slippery rock faces. Temperatures are freezing and frostbite is common.

While all this is valid for climbers as well, rescuers face additional challenges. At that height, a body freezes quickly. Getting it back down means digging it out of the ice in conditions where tool use is extremely difficult. Then there is the task of carrying down a heavy load in tricky terrain with little oxygen. Bodies are heavier in death and often frozen stiff in unnatural positions.

“You need 8-10 trained sherpas for this. The body has to be pulled down on a sheet with ropes. Conventional stretchers can’t be used in such conditions. Passages are so narrow — only around two feet — that one person can barely stand. The cost of such an operation can go up to Rs 1 crore, but as far as I know, almost no one has been brought down from the height at which Tiwari died,” Karki said.

Everest climbers are supposed to get insurance to pay for their rescue in case they get stuck or lost. “But no insurance provider pays for manual rescue, they only pay for transportation. And helicopters can barely operate in the death zone, the air is too thin,” Karki said.

● CLIMATE

Europe heat will abate soon, but El Niño looms



AMITABH SINHA

LARGE PARTS of western and central Europe are in the grip of an extraordinary heatwave phase, with many places registering temperatures 10 to 15 degrees Celsius higher than normal. Both the UK and France have recorded their highest ever temperature for May. Other countries, including Italy, Germany, Switzerland and Spain, have also been reporting unusually high temperatures.

A warm spell in May is not entirely unusual for western Europe, but the average temperatures during this time usually hover around 20-22 degrees Celsius. This week, however, several places have seen temperatures above 35 degrees Celsius — unprecedented for this month.

The prevailing heatwave has brought back uncomfortable memories of the unprecedented summers of 2022 and 2023 when temperatures in excess of 40 degrees Celsius were recorded at many places in Europe. A large-scale drought in 2022, the worst in living memory, and the record-breaking temperatures in both years resulted in the deaths of tens of thousands of people.

Things are not that bad right now, but this is just the month of May. The core summer months in Europe happen to be June and July, and it was in these months that most of the record-breaking temperatures in 2022 and 2023 were reached.

Incidentally, the extreme European heat of 2022 coincided with a very strong La Niña phase in the equatorial Pacific Ocean, which tends to have a cooling impact on the planet. This year, an opposite phenomenon, a strong El Niño, which has a warming effect, is taking shape.

El Niño and La Niña are two distinct phases of a large ocean-atmosphere interaction over the Pacific region that influence weather patterns worldwide.

The ‘heat dome’ effect

The unusual heat in Europe right now is being attributed to the formation of a “heat dome” that is preventing warm air near the ground from rising and dissipating. This is leading to an increase in surface temperatures. ‘Heat dome’ is just a fancy way to de-



People seek relief from the heat at a beach in England’s Brighton town. AP

scribe how heatwaves normally occur. Heatwaves anywhere, including over India, are caused by the emergence of high-pressure air systems in the mid-troposphere, about 7-10 km above Earth’s surface, that trap the heated surface air near the ground. They push down the air and compress it, increasing the temperature in the process.

This same system also prevents cloud formation and precipitation. Local influences can then amplify or weaken this phenomenon. For example, the heat dome effect over India often gets aggravated by the presence of dry soil, the “urban heat island effect” and the movement of hot air blowing from the deserts in the west. The urban heat island effect is a phenomenon where urban areas record higher temperatures than surrounding rural areas because their concrete traps heat during the day and radiates it at night.

The formation of a heat dome is not an unusual phenomenon in European summers. This year, however, it has happened a little early, resulting in an extremely warm May — possibly the warmest May in several years.

Interestingly, around the start of this month, Europe was experiencing below-normal temperatures. This rapid, extreme fluctuation in weather — hot and cold, wet and dry — is sometimes described as “climate whiplash”, something that is becom-

What Europe is experiencing ‘Heat dome’: High-pressure air systems trap warm air near the ground and increase surface temperatures.

● ‘Climate whiplash’: A rapid, extreme fluctuation in weather.

ing increasingly common because of climate change.

The extreme heat over Europe is expected to abate soon. Most forecasts suggest that the heat dome would dissipate by the weekend, and that temperatures would return close to their normal range within a few days.

Strong El Niño

But another threat is looming, not just for Europe but many other parts of the world including India.

An El Niño phase is emerging in the equatorial Pacific Ocean which is expected to persist through the rest of the year, possibly crossing over to the next year as well.

El Niño refers to an unusual warming of the surface waters of the equatorial Pacific Ocean, off the coast of north-western coast of South America. It is known to have a warming effect over the planet. Multiple forecasts have suggested that this El Niño could develop into one of the strongest ever.

The Climate Prediction Centre of the US’s National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, one of the world’s most authoritative agencies tracking the Pacific Ocean, however, says it is too early to make any reliable prediction about its strength.

“While confidence in the occurrence of El Niño has increased since last month (April), there is still substantial uncertainty

● Highest temperatures recorded in Europe this week

FIGURES IN DEGREES CELSIUS

UK	35.1
France	36.4
Spain	38.7
Portugal	32.9
Germany	34
Switzerland	32

COMPILED FROM RESPECTIVE NATIONAL WEATHER AGENCIES

about its peak strength,” it said in a bulletin earlier this month.

“The strongest El Niño events in the historical record are characterized by significant ocean-atmosphere coupling through the summer, and it remains to be seen whether this occurs in 2026,” it said, adding that there was only a one-third chance that the emerging El Niño would be a very strong one. In any case, a stronger El Niño does not necessarily mean stronger all-round impacts, it said. “Stronger El Niño events do not ensure strong impacts; they can only make certain impacts more likely,” it said, emphasising that the relationship between the occurrence of the ocean warming phenomenon and its impact was probabilistic and not deterministic.

Less rain, more heat

Still, the emergence of El Niño is a worrisome development for India. It is expected to affect the monsoon and push the mercury higher. It is because of the emerging El Niño that the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast below-normal rainfall for the upcoming June-September monsoon season.

There is no one-to-one correlation between the occurrence of an El Niño and suppressed monsoon rainfall over India. Past records, however, show that monsoon rainfall has remained below normal during an El Niño year in 70% of the instances. This year, the phenomenon is expected to fully mature by July. So, the IMD is expecting that August and September rainfall will be badly affected.

Similarly, there is a strong link between the occurrence of El Niño and the frequency and severity of heatwaves in India. In general, there is a greater chance of prolonged and severe heatwaves occurring in India during an El Niño phase.

● SPORT

The anatomy of a perfect race: Gurindervir’s historic 100m run

Pratyush Raj

New Delhi, May 28

GURINDERVIR SINGH’S 10.09-second scintillating sprint in Ranchi for creating the new national record in 100 metres looked lightning fast. The Punjab sprinter has been training with his coach, James Hillier, who said, “Just for that 10.09s race, we have trained two weeks continuously and months before that.”

In a chat with *The Indian Express*, Hillier broke down Gurindervir’s “perfect race”. “A perfect race can be executed by training for every phase. We have divided four phases: the 0m to 30m (start and gain speed), 30m to 60m (hit another gear of speed), 60m to 80m (maintain speed), 80m to 100m (minimise deceleration) and since the start of the year, Guri followed this model of training,” said Hillier.

A perfect start

In his run, Gurindervir had a perfect start off the blocks. “We had been working on his start for a very long time. In the final race, he had a perfect start. The first two

steps, where you generate most of the speed, are crucial. In that race, it looked like others had a bad start but their start was fine. It was just Guri getting off the blocks exceptionally well,” said Hillier.

The reason for focusing on this stage, Hillier said, was that “Earlier, Guri used to start well but also lose a lot of energy, which resulted in him finishing badly. Now, his start has become more efficient. He uses less energy but gets the same explosive start by turning his legs more quickly in the first few strides.”

He added that the loss of energy early on would make the race “a 60m dash” for Gurindervir. The sprinter won a gold medal at the National Indoor Championships in the 60m dash with a national record timing of 6.60s. “At the start of the season, we just trained for the first 60m. I wanted him to perfect the first two phases,” Hillier said.

Hitting top gear

The second stretch of 30 to 60m is extremely important for someone like Gurindervir, as this is where his strength lies. “We don’t have the splits for the race but I know

Science of the sprint

- The sprinter’s coach, James Hillier, said the timing was executed by breaking down the race into phases.
- On the track, they spent hours perfecting every second and millisecond to improve overall time.

Guri hit his top speed in the second phase. He would start and accelerate in the first 30 and then just go flying in the second stretch,” said Hillier.

After the Indoor nationals, when Gurindervir participated in the Indian Athletics Series in Delhi, he started the race well and was in the lead till 60m but faded at the end. “A lot of people saw that as a negative result but we were happy. We had trained for just 60m by then... I was happy,” said Hillier.

Maintaining speed

After the first two phases, the body needs to ensure that it sustains the speed. When Gurindervir clocked 10.17s in the semi-final, he held back on the finish line and later said, “I just ran the 80m race.” Hillier clarified, “Him pulling himself back meant that he was executing the 80m plan that day.”

While training for this leg, the idea for Gurindervir was to cover 10m in 0.9s. “Sometimes, he would get [it] and sometimes he wouldn’t. His fastest was 10m in 0.87s,” Hillier said.

Minimising deceleration

“I always say the first 30 and the last 20 are the most crucial parts of the race. The middle takes care of itself. Now, Guri has always been good at setting up the race but he would always fade out at the end. That is what we worked on in the last few weeks. The final stretch,” said Hillier. “No sprinter gets faster in the last 20m, it is about minimising the deceleration.”

In past races, Gurindervir would lose to Animesh Kujur (current national record holder in 200m) as the latter would usually catch up with him. “It is all about frequency. Guri gets tired in the last 20, he lengthens his strides and his cadence slows down resulting in deceleration,” the coach said.

To minimise deceleration, Hillier worked on Gurindervir’s posture. “My goal was to get him more upright and shorten his stride. When that happened, his frequency of moving both legs increased, resulting in a perfect finish,” said Hillier.

On the clock, it was just a 10.09s race, but in hindsight, it was meticulously crafted with hours spent on the track perfecting every second and millisecond.

● ENTERTAINMENT

Ranveer Singh-Farhan Akhtar row: How Bollywood treats contracts, exits

Rishika Singh
New Delhi, May 28

THE FEDERATION of Western India Cine Employees (FWICE) has called upon its members to not work with actor Ranveer Singh amid his dispute with Farhan Akhtar, the producer and director of *Don 3*.

Many have criticised the directive as beyond FWICE’s remit. B N Tiwari, the president of FWICE, told *The Indian Express*: “The federation never wants to go against a particular individual, this is more a message than an outright ban.”

Don 3 was announced in 2023 with a teaser featuring Singh. Its fate is now uncertain, with Singh leaving the project a few months ago reportedly due to delays and the lack of a final script. Akhtar and Ritesh Sidhwani, co-founders of the production house Excel Entertainment, are said to have sought around Rs 45 crore from the actor for losses, which he reportedly refused to pay.

Singh’s representatives have stated that he did not wish to publicly speak on the

matter and declined to comment when approached by *The Indian Express*. Akhtar, too, did not respond to a request for comment.

What is FWICE?

FWICE is a 70-year-old trade union comprising 38 craft associations with more than 5 lakh members. To become a FWICE member, a film industry worker first joins any of the 38 associations based on their respective profession, such as the Cine and TV Artists Association and the Indian Film & Television Directors’ Association (IFTDA). These bodies hold elections for posts such as president, who can join the FWICE General Council.

Tiwari, who has worked as a sound engineer for over 50 years, outlined its functions: “We manage the disputes or problems that come our way, but generally, we work to push for cinema workers’ rights, to see if these rights are being curtailed.”

In case of a dispute, members first approach their respective associations. If there’s no resolution, they can turn to



Ranveer Singh has dropped out of ‘Don 3’.

FWICE. “Akhtar went to IFTDA, but the issue wasn’t solved there, so he came to the federation, which is the mother body. Its decision must be abided by,” Tiwari claimed.

However, FWICE is not authorised to ban any individual. Tiwari said the move was intended to compel the parties involved to act, rather than permanently bar anyone. Singh reportedly did not respond

to calls from FWICE, allegedly saying the matter did not fall under its jurisdiction. “He is a superstar, I want to support him, but for both parties to reach an agreement, we have to do something,” Tiwari said.

When has FWICE acted in the past?

Most recently, FWICE objected to actor Diljit Dosanjh’s inclusion in *Border 2* (2026) for having starred in a film featuring Pakistani actor Hania Aamir after Operation Sindoor. The film’s shooting had begun before the Pahalgam attack. “T-Series (the producers of *Border 2*) apologised to us, they said the film is about to be completed, if you don’t support us, we will face significant losses. So, we do consider the producer’s argument as well,” Tiwari said.

How are such disputes resolved?

Namrata Pahwa, a Delhi-based advocate who has worked with film and media clients for over a decade, told *The Indian Express* that a lot depends on the contract in question. “Before a contract is signed, it

goes through many iterations over months. All negotiations should hopefully finish before executing the agreement, on remuneration, responsibilities, etc,” she said.

In the absence of specific obligations upon termination, “There are default charges actors would have to pay, which are about five times the amount one would have made from the agreement,” Pahwa said. Or, they must refund payment with interest.

For a long time, contracts were not essential to an industry where personal relationships and informal ties influence work. But in the last five to six years, after the Covid-19 pandemic and with the rise of OTT platforms, they are becoming the norm.

Payments to actors are made in various stages, given that film production is a long, capital-intensive process with many moving parts. It includes pre-production (planning, budgeting, casting), the actual filming, and post-production (dubbing, marketing, promotions), each step involving numerous tasks. Fees are paid in “tranches”, linked to different stages of

completion (say 10% or 50% of the project).

An actor who has worked on several feature films and OTT productions told *The Indian Express* on the condition of anonymity that actors who aren’t A-listers often have little power. “Once a contract is finalised, it all works based on goodwill, and you have to engage in soft negotiations if something comes up... For an average actor, leaving a project due to a disagreement might be turned against you... The OTTs make contracts that are very hard lettered,” he said.

Pahwa said: “With a big production, it’s not just your time or energy involved. Incredible costs are borne since every stage involves a lot of money. So, if an actor suddenly wants to leave, it shouldn’t be allowed, save for a legitimate breach of contract from the production side.”

Alternatives such as mediation and arbitration (a more formal process) are explored before moving on to litigation, and even then, issues are generally settled out of court. Unions and associations can only advise and mediate, she said.

U.S. PRESIDENT THREATENS TO BOMB OMAN IF IT GETS INVOLVED IN IMPOSING HORMUZ TOLL

Iran and US trade fire, plan for 60-day ceasefire extension awaits Trump nod

Tehran says it targeted US air base in Kuwait after strikes

Reuters
Dubai, Washington, May 28

THE UNITED States and Iran reached an agreement on Thursday to extend their ceasefire pending the approval of President Donald Trump, after Iran had targeted a US air base in Kuwait following US strikes on what Washington called an Iranian drone operation.

According to four sources familiar with the matter, the two sides agreed a memorandum-of-understanding to extend the truce for 60 days but the plan still needed Trump's sign-off.

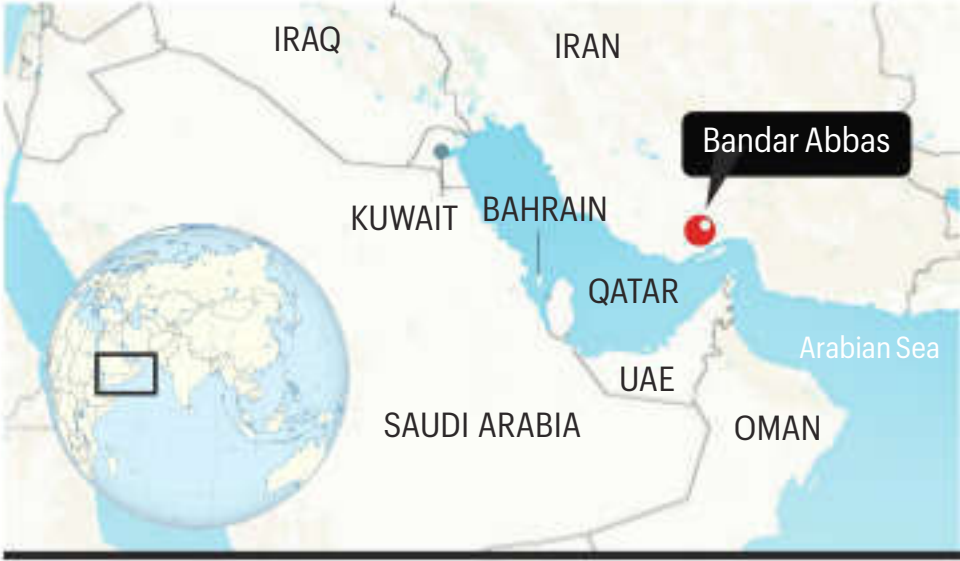
The agreement will state how to address Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium, which will be among the first issues discussed during the 60-day window, according to an earlier report by *Axios*, which broke the news. The White House declined to comment. The reports prompted oil prices to reverse course and trade lower on hopes of a potential reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump has said the end of the war is close but told media at a cabinet meeting on Wednesday



Smoke billows following an Israeli strike in Beirut on Thursday. REUTERS

Strikes Target Military Bases



day he was not yet satisfied by the negotiations and the US was not discussing easing sanctions, one of Tehran's demands.

US Central Command said US forces had shot down five Iranian attack drones and struck a ground control station in the

port city of Bandar Abbas that was about to launch a sixth. Kuwaiti forces had then intercepted a ballistic missile fired towards the country, which hosts a large U.S. base. "These actions were measured, purely defensive and intended to maintain the

ceasefire," a US official, who requested anonymity to speak candidly about military operations, told Reuters earlier.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said it had targeted the US base responsible for an early-morning attack near Bandar Abbas airport and that any repeat would lead to a "more decisive response", *Tasnim* news agency reported.

Kuwait condemned the attack and demanded that Iran immediately halt what it called a serious escalation.

Mediator Pakistan said its foreign minister, Ishaq Dar, would meet US Secretary of State Marco Rubio in Washington on Friday, although the significance of his visit was unclear.

The US warned Oman on Thursday not to get involved in any effort to impose a toll in the Strait of Hormuz, saying it will penalize any partners involved in such a system.

Trump said that no single country would have control over the waterway, and appeared to threaten Oman, with which the US has decades-long military and economic ties. "It's international waters, and Oman will behave just like everybody else or we'll have to blow them up. They understand that, they'll be fine," he said on Wednesday. Oman has not mentioned the idea of joint control of the strait with Iran, with which it says it has discussed freedom of navigation.

Israel strikes Beirut's southern suburb ahead of key Washington talks

Associated Press
Beirut, May 28

ISRAEL'S AIR force carried out an airstrike on a southern suburb of the capital, Beirut, Thursday afternoon, the Israeli military said, further straining a fragile ceasefire a day ahead of crucial negotiations in Washington.

The strike hit an apartment building but it was not immediately clear who might have been targeted. Videos from the suburb of Choueifat, close to Beirut's international airport, showed white smoke billowing from a residential neighborhood.

Tensions have been increasing in southern Lebanon, where Israeli troops in recent days have crossed the strategic Litani River, which the Israeli military has used as a de facto boundary. Large areas to the south are under Israeli military control despite the Washington-brokered ceasefire that's been in place since April 17.

This was the first attack close to the Lebanese capital since May 6, where an Israeli strike killed a military official with Hezbollah's elite Radwan Forces in another southern Beirut suburb.

Overnight, Israeli forces pounded the coastal city of Tyre, Lebanon's fourth-largest city, killing at least 14 people across the south of the country in its ongoing military escalation against the Hezbollah group ahead of the Washington talks.

Among those killed in the flurry of strikes were five women and children and a Lebanese soldier. Dozens of others were wounded, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry and the state-run National News Agency.

The Israeli military said meanwhile that one of its soldiers was killed in a Hezbollah drone attack in northern Israel. On Thursday afternoon, the Israeli military issued another evacuation warning for Tyre and its suburbs.

The city was officially declared a UNESCO World heritage site in 1984.

Foreign Minister Youssef Raggi said in a statement Thursday that he has been following "with deep pain and profound concern" the ongoing Israeli attacks on Tyre.

Trump's call to expand Abraham Accords leaves West Asia baffled

Vivian Nereim, Isabel Kershner & Elian Peltier
Riyadh, May 28

THE SOCIAL media post by President Donald Trump made it sound straightforward. The United States would orchestrate a deal to end the war with Iran and, in exchange, a slew of countries across West Asia and South Asia would join an agreement, called the Abraham Accords, establishing relations with Israel.

In fact, he said, that "should be mandatory." But half of the

countries he named — such as Egypt, Jordan and Turkey — already have relations with Israel. And the other half — including Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Pakistan — have no interest in establishing them anytime soon.

As a result, the meandering ultimatum that Trump shared Monday was met with a mix of silence and bemusement across the Middle East. Regional analysts said they were not even sure that they understood the rationale behind his proposal. Why would ending the war,

which the United States and Israel initiated by bombing Iran on Feb. 28, provide an incentive to recognize Israel for countries like Qatar, which had lobbied desperately to prevent the war in the first place?

"It's just bizarre," said Yoel Guzansky, a senior fellow at the Institute for National Security Studies at Tel Aviv University in Israel. "What's the connection between a deal with Iran and that? I'm honestly puzzled."

Two Western diplomats in

the region said that no one was really taking the idea seriously. They spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss diplomacy. Asked to explain the connection between peace negotiations with Iran and expanding the Abraham Accords, a White House spokesperson did not answer directly.

Instead, she referred to remarks made by Trump on Wednesday, when he suggested that U.S. agreement on a deal with Iran could be made contingent

upon countries such as Saudi Arabia and Qatar agreeing to recognize Israel. "I think those countries owe it to us," he said. "I'm not sure we should make the deal, if they don't sign."

The Saudi and Qatari governments did not respond to requests for comment.

Under the Abraham Accords — a deal brokered by the first Trump administration in 2020 — the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain and Morocco agreed to establish diplomatic relations with Israel.

A wide range of American politicians have portrayed the pact as a major diplomatic achievement, and have frequently referred to the accords as a "peace deal."

Scholars from the region say that is merely a turn of phrase, belying the fact that there has never been a war between Israel and Bahrain or the UAE. In effect, the deals bypassed the central conflict — between Israel and the Palestinians — declaring harmony between parties that were not fighting. NYT

WHO chief: Ebola testing being scaled up in Congo

Reuters
Berlin, May 28

THE WORLD Health Organization said on Thursday on X that, in partnership with the national medical research organization of the Democratic Republic of Congo, it is scaling up Ebola diagnostic capacities in the country to help swiftly contain an outbreak.

WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said the effort aims to strengthen the laboratory network to deliver real-time data, rapidly identify confirmed cases and save lives.

Meanwhile, aid supplies were rushed in to the center of Congo's outbreak of a rare type of Ebola virus as beleaguered medical workers have struggled with a lack of equipment, a distrustful population and armed groups in a volatile region.

A white cargo plane on Thursday morning delivered



WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus. FILE

masks, gloves, boots, and medications — all of which are in short supply — donated by the European Union to Bunia, a northeastern town at the heart of the outbreak. UN-branded forklifts lifted several cases into trucks.

The aid delivery from the EU is expected to come in batches over the next eight days, Jérôme Kouachi, head of emergency operations at UNICEF in Congo, said. The WHO has declared the outbreak a public health emergency of international concern, in the hope of ramping up aid.

Three injured in suspected 'terror' stabbing at Swiss train station

Geneva: A man stabbed and wounded three people in what authorities described as an "act of terror" at the train station in the Swiss city of Winterthur on Thursday before being arrested.

The attack took place shortly before 8:30 a.m. The suspect, who was arrested five minutes after emergency services were alerted, is a 31-year-old Swiss-Turkish dual national who lives in Winterthur, regional police chief Marius Weyermann said.

He had come to authorities' attention in 2015 for distributing propaganda of the Islamic State group, Weyermann added. In recent days, he was taken to a psychiatric facility after calling the police emergency number and making "confused comments," but he left on Wednesday after a doctor determined that he wasn't dangerous. AP

Ukraine, Sweden ink defence deal as Kyiv moves to buy fighter jets

Reuters
Uppsala, May 28

UKRAINE WILL buy 20 new Gripen fighter jets and Sweden will donate 16 of an older model next year, Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and Sweden's Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson said at a joint press conference on Thursday.

The two leaders had signed a letter of intent last year paving the way for Sweden to sell up to 150 Saab Gripen model E fighter jets to Ukraine, though deliveries of the newer model are several years away.

The planes are a priority for Ukraine's fighter fleet and the country's defence minister said in May that a deal for Gripen E could be signed "within months" after the European Union approved a 90 billion euro loan for Ukraine.

"Gripen is the best and optimal choice for Ukraine. So



Sweden's Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson with Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Uppsala, Sweden, on Thursday. REUTERS

today, we take the next major step on this joint journey," Kristersson said at a press conference alongside Zelenskyy at Uppsala air base, where two Gripen jets were on display.

"We need these jets and for us this is really a new page for Ukraine," Zelenskyy said, adding it planned to buy all the 150 jets stipulated in the original letter of intent. "God bless, we will have enough financing for this," he said.

The transfer of older model C/D jets enables a stopgap solution for Ukraine's air defence in the meantime.

Zelenskyy said Ukraine had earmarked 2.5 billion euros out of a 90 billion euro EU loan package for the planes.

BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Criminal probe against writer who accused Trump of assault



Jean E. Carroll outside the Manhattan Court in New York on May 9 2023. FILE

THE JUSTICE Department has opened an investigation into whether E. Jean Carroll, the longtime advice columnist who has said Donald Trump sexually assaulted her in a Manhattan department store 30 years ago, lied during the course of civil litigation against the Republican president, according to a person familiar with the matter. The person who confirmed the existence of the investigation was not authorized to publicly discuss an ongoing inquiry and spoke on the condition of anonymity. AP

CHINA

EU fines Temu €200mn over illegal products

TEMU WAS hit with a 200 million euro (USD 232 million) fine after an investigation by EU regulators found the Chinese online retailer didn't do enough to protect consumers from illegal products. The EU's fine follows preliminary findings that Temu was exposing consumers to a high risk of products that didn't comply with EU consumer safety rules. AP

COLOMBIA

52 killed in clashes between armed groups

AT LEAST 52 guerrilla fighters were killed in clashes between rival armed groups battling for control of a key cocaine production and trafficking region in southeastern Colombia, a faction of the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC) said on Thursday. The violence highlights ongoing turf wars among dissident armed groups in the region. REUTERS

NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

IMF approves \$695 mn aid amid war fallout

THE INTERNATIONAL Monetary Fund has approved USD 695 million in funding for Sri Lanka as the island nation grapples with the impact of Cyclone Ditwah and the war in West Asia. It has approved the amount following a review of Sri Lanka's economic reform programme. PTI

NEPAL

Lawmaker scales Everest with Parliament logo

A NEPALI lawmaker belonging to the ruling RSP has scaled Mount Everest, carrying the logo of the Federal Parliament. Mingma David Sherpa, a mountaineer and a member of the House of Representatives, reached the highest peak in the world at 5:40 AM on Wednesday, as per his social media post. PTI

16 killed, 79 injured after fire breaks out in Kenya girls' school

Reuters
Gilgil (Kenya) May 28

A FIRE tore through a dormitory at a girls' secondary school in a town in Kenya's Rift Valley overnight, killing at least 16 students, the government said Thursday.

The fire broke out just after midnight at the Utumishi Girls' Academy Senior School in Gilgil in west-central Kenya and burned for more than two hours, Education Minister Julius Migos told reporters.

He said 79 other students were injured, although 71 of them had already been discharged from hospital. Students at the school are aged between 15 and 18 years.

"Investigations are ongoing, but the... cause of the fire is not yet identified," Migos said.

Speaking to reporters at the school, Interior Minister Kipchumba Murkomen urged people not to speculate on the cause of the fire.

However multiple survivors told first responders that a stu-

dent had lit a mattress with a match, said one first responder, who asked not to be named because they were not authorized to speak to the media. They did not know what the student's motive might have been.

Fires are common at Kenyan schools, with more than 100 recorded in 2024, according to the government. Many fires are set by students protesting harsh discipline and poor conditions, researchers have found.

Doors on the second floor where the fire started were initially locked and some students died while jumping out of the windows, the first responder said.

The fire broke window panes and left the walls of the school stained with smoke.

Outside the school on Thursday, hundreds of family members gathered to seek news of their loved ones.

Injured students could be seen, some limping with bandaged limbs, others carried by police officers.

THE STUDY BY RESEARCHERS AT UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA FOUND THAT BLOOD BIOMARKERS MEASURING TAU AND AMYLOID PRODUCTION WERE ASSOCIATED WITH A GREATER LIKELIHOOD OF COGNITIVE DECLINE

New blood test may detect Alzheimer's years before symptoms appear

Anuradha Mascarenhas
New Delhi, May 28

FOR THE first time, researchers have identified blood biomarkers for Alzheimer's Disease that correlate with subtle cognitive differences in middle-aged adults who do not yet show memory problems. This means that Alzheimer's-related brain changes may be detectable years before symptoms emerge.

A new study led by researchers at the University of California, San Francisco (UCSF) found that blood biomarkers measuring tau and amyloid proteins — hallmarks of Alzheimer's Disease — were associated with a greater likelihood

of future cognitive decline.

The study was published in *The Lancet* and primarily funded by the National Institutes of Health (NIH).

Researchers found that six percent of the 1,350 participants, aged 53 to 69, had elevated levels of amyloid and tau in their blood. These participants also scored lower in two important cognitive domains.

"Alzheimer's disease pathology begins years before symptoms emerge," said Kristine Yaffe, senior author of the study and chair of the UCSF Department of Psychiatry and Behavioral Sciences. "Detecting the disease early means patients can target modifiable risk

factors and potentially seek interventions sooner."

Yaffe has led research on modifiable dementia risk factors such as physical inactivity, cognitive inactivity, depression, smoking and cardiovascular health. According to her research, addressing these factors could delay or prevent up to 40 percent of dementia cases.

Alzheimer's Disease, which is a form of dementia, is characterized by an abnormal and progressive buildup of amyloid and tau proteins.

This accumulation forms destructive plaques and tangles that damage neurons, block cell-to-cell signals, and ultimately kill brain cells.



A scientist looks at scans of brains at the Department of Readaptation and Geriatrics of the University Hospital in Geneva, Switzerland. FILE

The new study measured blood levels of Aβ42, Aβ40 and p-tau217 in 1,350 dementia-free

adults in the US States, with an average age of 61 years. Researchers identified

Alzheimer's-associated biomarker levels in 86 participants — around 6 per cent of the study group.

At baseline, participants with elevated biomarkers demonstrated slower processing speed — the ability to quickly respond to changing information, such as traffic signals or conversations — as well as poorer executive functioning, which includes planning, organizing and managing tasks like finances or schedules.

Five years later, this group showed a 2.5- to 4-fold higher risk of rapid decline in verbal memory and a 3- to 4-fold higher risk of decline in processing speed, suggesting a signifi-

cantly increased likelihood of developing Alzheimer's disease.

According to a 2025 report in the *Indian Journal of Public Health*, an estimated 5.3 million Indians are currently living with dementia, a number projected to nearly triple by 2050.

Alzheimer's disease accounts for 60 to 70 per cent of these cases. Dr Anil Venkitachalam, a Mumbai-based consultant neurologist not associated with the study, said that blood biomarkers currently have greater clinical relevance in patients who already show cognitive symptoms.

"They may help differentiate Alzheimer's Disease from other forms of dementia and as-

sist in assessing prognosis and the expected rate of cognitive decline. They are also useful in identifying suitable candidates for clinical trials," he said.

However, he cautioned against routine population-wide screening. "One important concern is the high potential for false positives," Dr Venkitachalam said. "Many older individuals who are cognitively healthy may still show amyloid accumulation in the brain and yet never develop dementia."

In such cases, widespread screening could lead to unnecessary anxiety and psychological distress, especially since effective treatments for dementia remain limited.

AS WEST ASIA WAR CONTINUES

Anti-dumping duties on chemicals a key ‘concern’

The impact of such duties leads to an increase in input prices in the sector

Ravi Dutta Mishra

New Delhi, May 28

INDIA'S CHEMICAL Industry associations and several government ministries have begun pushing for a suspension or pause in anti-dumping investigations into several chemical intermediaries due to a surge in prices and shortages caused by the ongoing war in West Asia.

In April, the government exempted import duty on 40 petrochemical products till June 30, but it has begun fresh stocking efforts to ensure domestic availability of key chemicals.

Many such requests are made to the Commerce and Industry Ministry by the downstream industry, such as the textiles and footwear sectors.

An official said the Textile Ministry has also asked for a pause on several anti-dumping investigations on chemical intermediaries and deferment in anti-dumping duty investigation on input items such as elastomeric fibre yarn and viscose rayon filament yarn due to the war.

India's chemical manufacturers are the most protected sector in the country.

An independent analysis of India's trade policy during the last five years by the WTO Secretariat shows that 51% of all anti-dumping measures in force are related to chemical or



DPIIT has asked petrochemical industry to “urgently respond” on the scope to indigenise the production of over 200 highly import-dependent petrochemical items. REUTERS

allied industries, and Chinese products have been the top target of such investigations.

“Between 1 January 2021 and 30 June 2025, India notified a total of 226 antidumping investigations to the WTO. Of these, 130 were notified as having resulted in affirmative determinations and in the application of antidumping measures. As of 30 June 2025, India maintained a total of 170 antidumping measures in force. China was the main subject of India's investigations and antidumping measures in force, accounting for 36.5% and 43.8%, respectively.

“A total of 51% of anti-dumping measures in force pertain to products of chemical or allied industries,” the Trade Policy Review (TPR) report said. *The Indian Express* had reported last week that the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), in a meeting with the petrochemical industry, had asked them to “urgently respond” on the scope to indigenise the production of over 200 highly import-dependent petrochemical items.

These items cumulatively account for annual imports worth over \$50 billion, and the missive from the DPIIT, issued Wednesday, comes amid the West Asia crisis that has caused price and supply-related challenges for the industry.

Most petrochemicals listed by the DPIIT were intermediate products that are used in packaging, construction, automotive, agricultural, textile and paints.

Big vs Small

Anti-dumping investigations have been a subject of deep divide between large manufacturers and the downstream sector, as anti-dumping duties typically protect large manufacturers abroad but lead to a surge in input item prices for MSMEs across the sector.

The impact of such duties on the chemical sector particularly translates to high input prices, as chemicals are used in

the production of nearly 80,000 downstream products in India, as per Niti Aayog. However, industry sources also say that China's industrial policies are often designed to scuttle manufacturing abroad.

China, for decades, has been the world's largest producer and exporter of multiple chemical value chains, from petrochemicals and polymers to fibres and intermediates, posing a challenge for countries globally.

Anti-dumping duties, quality control orders (QCOs) and other such measures are artificial interventions, and MSMEs have to bear the cost as these things make us uncompetitive, Anil Bhardwaj, Secretary General, Federation of Indian Micro and Small & Medium Enterprises (FISME) said, adding that these interventions are driven by political motivations and not economic logic. “Anti-dumping duties and QCOs should be the last resort and should be used for a short period of time. But in India, it is used unabated on petrochemicals, plastics and even raw materials such as copper and aluminium.

“Due to these interventions, we have even become a net importer of auto components because raw materials have become expensive,” Bhardwaj said. As per Niti Aayog figures, the chemical base in India has seen erosion due to a surge in cheap imports from China.

According to a report released last year, Niti said that India imported chemicals worth \$75 billion compared to exports worth \$44 billion, accounting for a trade deficit of around \$31 billion.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Why SC online gaming tax verdict could be a final death blow to sector

Soumyarendra Barik

New Delhi, May 28

THE SUPREME Court on Wednesday upheld the constitutional validity of the government's retrospective 28% Goods and Services Tax (GST) levy on online gaming companies, delivering a massive setback to the country's real-money gaming sector.

The verdict effectively revives tax demands running into nearly Rs 2.5 lakh crore against gaming firms, fantasy sports platforms and casinos, and could well spell the end of the road for the online gaming sector, already reeling under a ban imposed by the government in 2025.

A bench comprising Justices JB Pardiwala and R Mahadevan dismissed petitions filed by several gaming companies and industry bodies challenging the GST regime and retrospective tax notices issued by authorities. Companies like Dream11 and GamesKraft would be impacted by the judgement.

The dispute centred around the gaming sector's contention that the 28% GST on online gaming should apply only prospectively, from 1 October 2023, after the amendments approved by the GST Council came into effect.

Another contention put forth by the industry was whether GST should be imposed only on the platform fee or commission earned by gaming companies — known as gross gaming revenue (GGR) — or on the full face value of bets and contest entry amounts deposited by users.

Gaming firms had argued that taxing the entire pooled amount was commercially unsustainable and contrary to the treatment of skill-based games. The court, however, has treated real money gaming involving



The verdict revives tax demands of around Rs 2.5 lakh crore against gaming firms, fantasy sports platforms and casinos. REUTERS

uncertain outcomes as betting and gambling for GST purposes, irrespective of skill elements.

The ruling overturns relief earlier granted by the Karnataka High Court to gaming platform Gameskraft, which had challenged a Rs 21,000 crore GST notice. While gaming company Dream11 had got a show cause notice for evasion of Rs 40,000 crore, casino gaming company Delta Corp received multiple notices from GST authorities totalling Rs 23,204 crore for short-payment of taxes.

What the verdict means for the online gaming sector

The judgment could prove existential for a sector already battered by tightening regulation and bans on several real-money gaming formats under the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming (PROG) Act, 2025. The underlying consensus is that the sector may find it hard to re-establish itself through other business streams after the verdict.

“Upholding the 28% GST on full face value—especially with

retrospective impact—creates an immediate, steep financial burden that cannot be passed on to consumers. This settles the long-standing ‘skill versus chance’ tax debate, aligning directly with the government's intent to strengthen consumer and youth safeguards.

As the industry faces a sharp phase of consolidation and liquidity pressures, companies must immediately recalibrate their financial structures. Survival will hinge on rapid business model adaptation, aggressive cost-rationalisation, and absolute regulatory alignment,” said Saurabh Agarwal, Tax Partner, EY India.

However, some experts said that though the verdict may increase the tax base on paper, the fact that the sector has come to a grinding halt owing to the new gaming law, could mean that recovering the dues could prove to be a challenge.

Sudipta Bhattacharjee, Partner, Khaitan & Co, who represented several online gaming and casino companies before the Supreme Court, said, “...this victory may not practically yield to anything significant for GST authorities — with the

complete ban on online money gaming now, most companies have either shut down or pivoted to some other area of business.

Thus, any attempt at recovering such massive GST attempts may not practically yield any results since the GST amounts demanded are several times higher than cumulative revenues ever earned by these companies”.

How India dismantled the high-flying online gaming industry

Last year, the government moved to place a strict ban on online gaming companies operating in India, citing national security concerns, including the use of digital wallets and cryptocurrencies for money laundering and illicit fund transfers, these platforms serving as potential messaging and communication grounds for terror organisations, and offshore entities circumventing Indian tax and legal obligations, among others.

The law was a major blow to the sector, which was projected to be a \$9 billion market by 2029. Under the PROG Act, the government will prohibit any person from offering online games in India, failing which they could be imprisoned for up to three years, and penalised Rs 1 crore.

Those promoting such platforms, such as social media influencers, will also face jail time of two years, and a penalty of Rs 50 lakh. The government will also prohibit banks and financial institutions from facilitating financial transactions on such platforms.

It applies to all online money gaming platforms irrespective of whether they are games of skill or chance, a distinction the industry had lobbied hard for in the past.

Outlook for oil remains extremely vulnerable to geopolitical risks: RIL

ENS Economic Bureau

New Delhi, May 28

RELIANCE INDUSTRIES Ltd, a leading player in the oil and gas sector, on Thursday said the outlook for oil remains extremely vulnerable to geopolitical, macro-economic and policy risks in FY2026-27.

Global oil demand growth is expected to be sluggish due to higher oil prices and economic slowdown in FY 2026-27 amid West Asia conflict, RIL said in its annual report. Crude oil has been highly volatile since March this year when the US-Israel conflict started.

“Refinery and oil infrastructure damages which caused product supply losses are likely to take a longer period to recover, resulting in continual volatility in the market,” RIL said. In FY 2026-27, volatile product and feedstock prices, supply disruptions from the West Asia, Government of India directives on SAED, petrochemical feedstock usage and duty exemption on key petrochemical products may weigh on domestic demand and margins, it said.

Fuel prices have gone up by Rs 8 in Mumbai in the month of May alone. RIL said natural gas is expected to play an increasingly critical role in India's energy transition, with its share in the energy mix targeted to rise from around 6% to 15% by 2030. “RIL's gas portfolio remains well-positioned to support this structural shift, contributing nearly 30% of the country's domestic gas production,” RIL said.

Continued development of deepwater and CBM assets, supported by existing infrastructure and operational efficiencies, is expected to further augment supplies and cater to India's growing gas demand in FY 2026-27 and beyond, it said.

RIL to operationalise 40 GWh BESS capacity

RIL said its battery energy storage system (BESS) giga-factory is nearing commissioning, with the company set to oper-



RIL Chairman Mukesh Ambani has declined to draw a salary from the company for the sixth straight year. REUTERS

ationalise 40 GWh of annual capacity—scalable to 100 GWh—as production ramps up in the second half of 2026.

BESS is a technology that stores electrical energy in batteries so it can be used later when needed. Adani Green Energy Ltd (AGEL) has already commissioned a cumulative 3.37 Gigawatt-hour (GWh) BESS this week.

According to RIL's latest annual report, the company is progressively commissioning its HJT (Heterojunction Technology) cell and module lines.

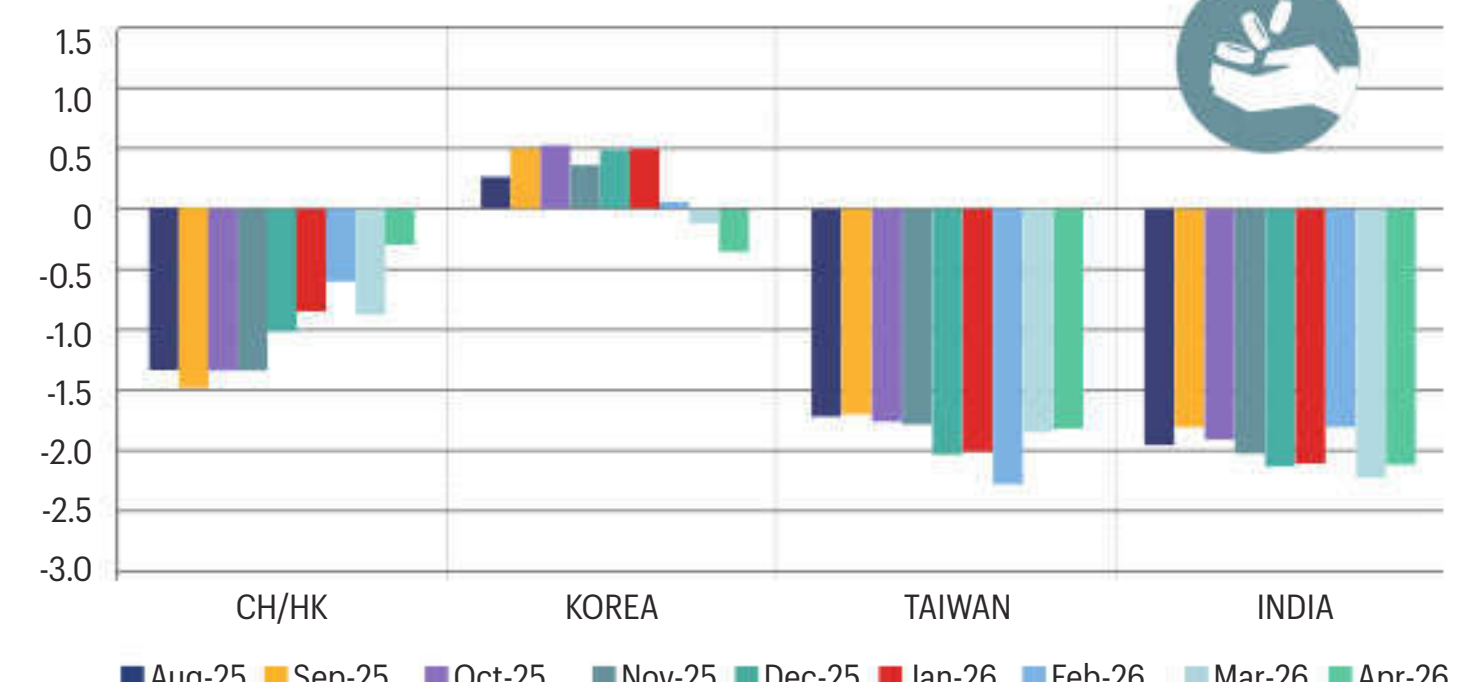
The first 200 MWP of high-efficiency HJT modules have been delivered — demonstrating 10% higher energy yield and 25% lower degradation versus industry standards, with 720 Wp BIS — certified panels. “Reliance remains on track to scale to 10 GWP per annum, with expansion to 20 GWP planned, targeting 26% module efficiency. Polysilicon, glass, ingots, and wafers are being commissioned in phases toward full integration,” it said.

The Dhirubhai Ambani Green Energy Giga Complex at Jamnagar is envisaged as the most integrated clean energy manufacturing ecosystem outside China, the report said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• EM FUNDS REMAINED UNDERWEIGHT ON INDIA IN APRIL

The Indian rupee's travails are keeping policymakers on the edge. And while it has recovered to 95.7-per-dollar after nearly breaching 97-mark earlier this month, focus remains on foreign investors, who have exited the Indian stock market to the tune of \$3.6 billion so far in May. According to Nomura, global emerging market (EM) funds remained ‘underweight’ on India in April with respect to the MSCI EM weights. EM investors' relative allocations increased marginally by 0.1 percentage point on India last month, Nomura said in a note last week.



SOURCE: FUND WEBSITES, MSCI, NOMURA RESEARCH. NOTE: DATA IS ON A LIKE-FOR-LIKE REPORTING BASIS FOR 34 FUNDS WITH CONSISTENT HISTORY FOR EVERY MONTH SINCE AUGUST 2025; NUMBERS DO NOT MATCH WITH DATA ABOVE DUE TO USE OF A SLIGHTLY DIFFERENT SAMPLE SET OF FUNDS

Telecom wars return as Vi targets Airtel's Priority Push

Urvi Malvania

New Delhi, May 28

AFTER YEARS of tariff wars and consolidation battles, the telecom sector may be headed for a fresh confrontation — this time over whether some users should get a better Internet experience than others.

Vodafone Idea (Vi) has fired the opening salvo through a sharp consumer campaign targeting Bharti Airtel's recently launched Priority Postpaid service, signalling the return of public sparring between telecom operators after a prolonged period in which the industry's focus had largely shifted to survival, fundraising and tariff repair.

The timing is significant for Vi. The company, which recently received relief through the reassessment of adjusted gross revenue (AGR) dues and saw Kumar Mangalam Birla return as chairman, appears keen to signal that it is ready to compete more aggressively again after years of financial stress and subscriber losses.

Vi's latest social media campaign — built around slogans such as “Sabko equal network ka vaada” (the promise of equal

network for everyone) and “Everyone is a priority with Vi” — appears directly aimed at Airtel's Priority Postpaid offering, which uses 5G network slicing technology to provide a more stable and consistent network experience for postpaid users. The campaign copy leaves little to interpretation. “Na kisi ko kum, na zyada. Sabko equal network ka vaada.” (No one gets more and no one gets less. The promise of equal network for everyone) one of the creatives reads, followed by the tagline: “Strong network. Sabka haq.” (Strong network, everyone's right.)

“India's digital growth has been built on the foundation of affordable and connectivity for all. At Vi, we strongly believe that every customer deserves a fair and consistent network experience. Offering preferential speeds or services based on user profile, raises questions around equity and principles of an equal digital ecosystem,” said Avneesh Khosla, chief marketing officer, Vodafone Idea.

“For India to continue its digital growth, even as the technology advances, it is important for innovation and monet-

isation models to keep the interests of all customers paramount, be transparent and most of all remain inclusive,” he added.

Airtel has defended the offering, arguing that it remains compliant with net neutrality norms because it does not involve preferential treatment of websites or applications and is based on network management capabilities enabled by standalone 5G architecture.

The company has also argued before authorities that its network has sufficient spare capacity to ensure that prepaid users are not impacted.

The launch has, however, triggered divisions within the telecom industry and revived debates around equal Internet access that had largely subsided after the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India's 2016 rules prohibiting discriminatory tariffs for data services.

The current dispute differs from earlier battles around Free Basics and Airtel Zero because the issue now is not differential access to specific content but differentiated quality of Internet experience enabled through network slicing technology. FE

DIRECTORATE OF MINES & GEOLOGY STEEL AND MINES DEPARTMENT, GOVT. OF ODISHA, BHUBANESWAR

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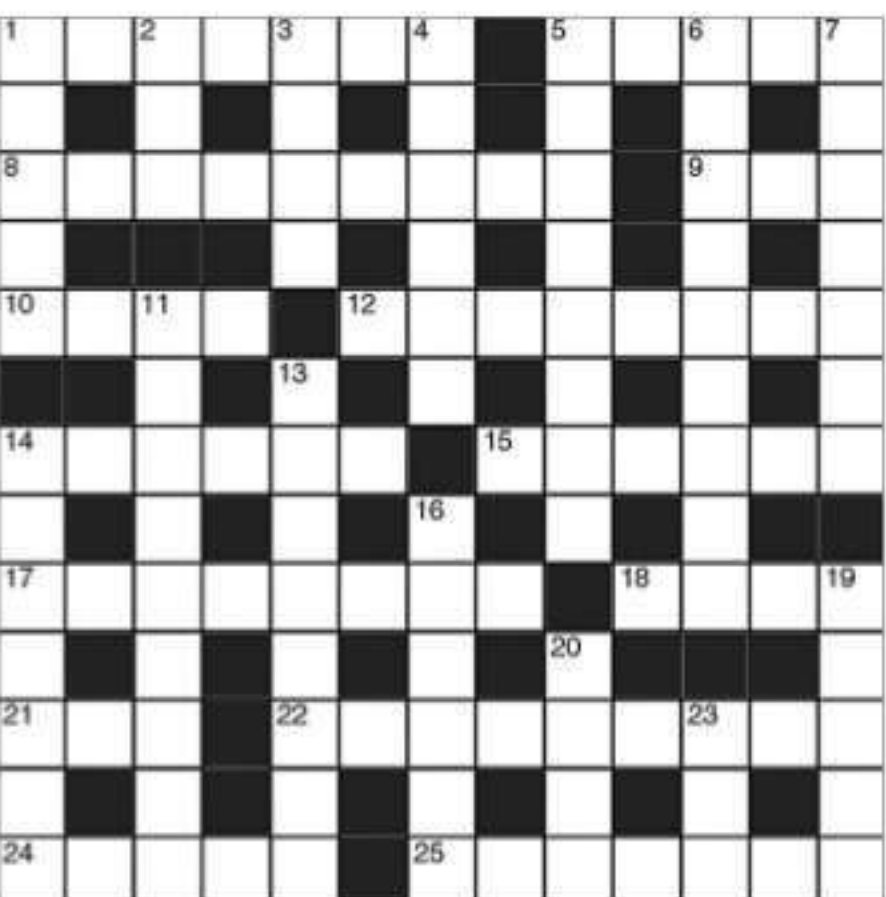
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CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Quiet — Auntie is taking a turn in the garden (7)
- 5 Produce a lower type of offspring (5)
- 8 Guidance provided by the board? (9)
- 9 Go down for a swim (3)
- 10 Wary about being seen as crooked (4)
- 12 Objects when the claret is shaken up (8)
- 14 Is allowed to copy a cocktail delicacy (6)
- 15 Loud Verdi composition full of fire and passion (6)
- 17 They join together in operations (8)
- 18 When one has a vast amount of land (4)
- 21 Thing laid on the table for breakfast maybe (3)
- 22 The powers a university has (9)
- 24 Describing a boom in travel (5)
- 25 Patois said in France to take in a smart guy (7)
- DOWN
- 1 Lodgings at university next to a city in Italy (5)
- 2 It helps to make road repairs a work of art (3)
- 3 A slight touch of the devil (4)
- 4 Workers' home (6)
- 5 Regard as deliberate (8)
- 6 Gentleman's darlings a proper woman adores (9)
- 7 Unmasked once one asked questions (7)
- 11 Continuous operation in making arrests (7,2)
- 13 Precise remedy (8)
- 14 Small firms having outfits for pets (7)
- 16 Foiled — the trespassers? (6)
- 19 Tessa turns up something useful (5)
- 20 Urgent request for parking on farmland (4)
- 23 There'll be talk if it's broken (3)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6000 ACROSS: 1 Arrogant, 5 Case, 9 Extra, 10 Tearing, 11 Persona grata, 13 Put off, 14 Writhe, 17 Preparations, 20 Entreat, 21 Niece, 22 Yo-yo, 23 Idolatry DOWN: 1 Aced, 2 Retreat, 3 Glass of water, 4 Noting, 6 Anita, 7 Engraved, 8 Danger signal, 12 Apoplexy, 15 Tangent, 16 Parted, 18 Entry, 19 Defy

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Parentage is a very important profession, but no ____ for it is ever imposed in the interest of the children. - Walter Besant (4,2,7)

BSEEO

●●●●●

AERTTT

●●●●●

YISSS

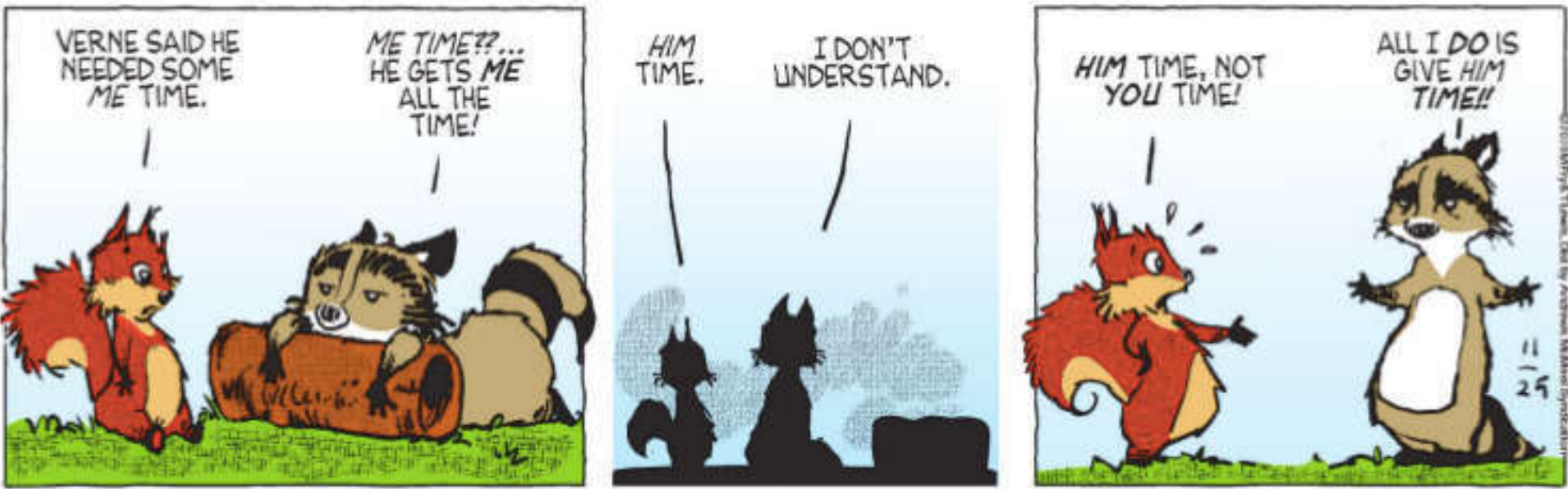
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IPUFFN

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SOLUTIONS: Obese, Sister, Pulling, Parentage is a very important profession, but no test of fitness is ever imposed in the interest of the children. - Walter Besant

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6333

	4	6	8		3	5	2	
8				2				6
			9	6				
	9					5		
5	2						9	1
	3						6	
			6	4				
4				3				5
	6	2	5	1	8	3		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6332

3	8	1	4	6	7	5	9	2
5	7	9	2	3	8	6	4	1
4	6	2	5	1	9	8	3	7
2	9	8	7	5	6	4	1	3
6	3	4	8	2	1	9	7	5
1	5	7	3	9	4	2	6	8
8	1	5	9	4	3	7	2	6
7	4	6	1	8	2	3	5	9
9	2	3	6	7	5	1	8	4

Executive Engineer

PD, P.W.D, Bulandshahr

E- Procurement Tender Notice

Letter No. 2804/1A

Dated: 21.05.2026

Short-E-Procurement Inviting Tenders

On behalf of Governor of Uttar Pradesh, Executive Engineer, Provincial Division, U.P.P.W.D., Bulandshahr invites following percentage rate bids online through <http://etender.up.nic.in> in from the eligible and approved Contractors registered with P.W.D. class as per column no. 10 below Building work Category as applied from Date 01.06.2026 to 08.06.2026 upto 12:00 Noon as per the prescribed T-1 of Govt. of U.P. The technical bid will be opened online on dated 08.06.2026 at 12:30 P.M. If the office happens to be closed on the date of opening of the bid as specified, the bid will be opened online on the next working day, at the same time any validity of bid will be considered from the original date. The date and time of opening of the financial bid shall be notified on the website.

Sl. No	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs.in Lakh)	Bid Security (Rs.in Lakh)	Time of Completion work including rainy season	Tender Cost (In Rs.)	Address of Executive Engineer	Address of Superintending Engineer	Address of Chief Engineer	Category
1	Financial Year 2026-27								
1	Repair and Maintenance of Office Building Provincial Division, PWD, Bulandshahr in District Bulandshahr	4.50	0.45	12 Months	150*500+18% GST 117.00 – Rs.767.00	Executive Engineer P.D,P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Superintending Engineer, BSR Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Chief Engineer, Meerut Zone, P.W.D., Meerut	A, B, C, D (Building work)
2	Repair and Maintenance work of Transit Hostel at District Bulandshahr	4.40	0.44	12 Months	150*500+18% GST 117.00 – Rs.767.00	Executive Engineer P.D,P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Superintending Engineer, BSR Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Chief Engineer, Meerut Zone, P.W.D., Meerut	A, B, C, D (Building work)
3	Repair and Maintenance of Residences in D.M. Colony Bulandshahr	4.50	0.45	12 Months	150*500+18% GST 117.00 – Rs.767.00	Executive Engineer P.D,P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Superintending Engineer, BSR Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Chief Engineer, Meerut Zone, P.W.D., Meerut	A, B, C, D (Building work)
4	Repair work of office of Bulandshahr Circle, PWD, Bulandshahr building.	4.30	0.43	12 Months	150*500+18% GST 117.00 – Rs.767.00	Executive Engineer P.D,P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Superintending Engineer, BSR Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Chief Engineer, Meerut Zone, P.W.D., Meerut	A, B, C, D (Building work)

1. Time allowed for completion of Whole work in column No. 5, including rainy season.

2. The Tender Document Fee must be deposited through Internet Banking only.

3. Contractor should be registered in Building work in PWD.

4. All registered contractors have to upload turnover certified by C.A. of last 5 years and details of maximum cost of work satisfactorily completed in last 5 years on Chanakya Software before submission of tender.

Details of e-tender uploaded on <http://etender.up.nic.in> shall also be uploaded on uppwd Chanakya Software before last date & time of submission of bid.

5. Terms & Conditions related to bids are available on <http://etender.up.nic.in>

6. During execution of work contractor should ensure the all safety Measures for COVID-19 issued by the Uttar Pradesh government.

7. In PWD technical evaluation of tenders is to be done by Prahari Software URL for Prahari is <http://wms.uppwd.gov.in/Prahar/>.

Assistant Engineer

P.D., P.W.D., Bulandshahr

UPID-251864 Dt. 27/05/2026

www.upidadv.gov.in

(Er. Rahul Sharma)

Executive Engineer

P.D., P.W.D., Bulandshahr

कार्यालय कार्यापालन यंत्री, नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन

तृतीय निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ऑन लाईन निविदाओं का आमंत्रण केन्द्रीकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्नानुसार नगरीय प्रशासन एवं विकास विभाग द्वारा जारी एस.ओ.आर. दिनांक 02.08.2021 से लमसम आधार पर किया जाता है।

नि.स.क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की अनु. लागत	प्रतिभूति राशि	ऑन लाईन निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य	समयावधि	निविदा क्रय एवं दर प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि
2026_UAD_487998_3	Execution of Balance work construction laying jointing commissioning of Sewerage Network, Manhole, IC, House Service Connection with Road Restoration of Sewer Zone-3 under AMRUT-1.0	74456237/-	372281/-	20000/-	270 दिवस	08-06-2026
2026_UAD_488004_3	Execution of Balance work of Sewerage Network, Manhole, IC, House Service Connection with Road Restoration of Sewer Zone 5 Part- I under AMRUT-1.0	95065111/-	475325/-	20000/-	270 दिवस	08-06-2026
2026_UAD_488006_3	Execution of Balance work of Sewerage Network, Manhole, IC, House Service Connection with Road Restoration of Sewer Zone 5 Part-II under AMRUT-1.0	84415414/-	422077/-	20000/-	270 दिवस	08-06-2026
2026_UAD_488135_3	Execution of Balance work of Sewerage Network, Manhole, IC, House Service Connection with Road Restoration of Sewer Zone 5 Part- III under AMRUT-1.0	89637044/-	448185/-	20000/-	270 दिवस	08-06-2026
2026_UAD_488166_3	Execution of Balance work of Sewerage Network, Manhole, IC, House Service Connection with Road Restoration of Sewer Zone 5 Part-IV under AMRUT-1.0	86687763/-	433438/-	20000/-	270 दिवस	09-06-2026

निविदा संबंधित अन्य विवरण एवं विस्तृत निविदा सूचना की जानकारी वेब साईट <https://mptenders.gov.in> पर ऑन लाईन दर्शाई गई है।

कार्यपालन यंत्री- अमृत

लो.स्वा.यां. संघा.खण्ड न.पा.नि. उज्जैन

आयुक्त

नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

HEAD CONSTABLE KEDAR NATH JHA
17 BN BSF
02.01.1958 – 29.05.1995

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Kedar Nath Jha on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries while fighting with militants in Wadura area, Sopore, J&K and later succumbed to his injuries at 92 Base hospital, Srinagar.

INSPECTOR BRJI MOHAN PANDEY
46 BN BSF
04.01.1955 – 29.05.1993

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its Subordinate Officer, Inspector Brji Mohan Pandey on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice due to lightening, while deployed at FDL GOC II in Sundar bani area, Jammu.

HEAD CONSTABLE BIRENDER CHOUDHARY
19 BN BSF
27.11.1967 – 29.05.2000

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Birender Choudhary on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice due to lightening, while deployed at FDL Danchi Top in Mandir Mandi area, Jammu.

CONSTABLE SURAT SINGH, PPMG
51 BN BSF
07.07.1945 – 29.05.1978

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Surat Singh, PPMG on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury while fighting with armed miscreants in area of BOP Maharana, Jaisalmer, Rajasthan and later succumbed to it.

LANCE NAIK MOHAN LAL, PMG
53 BN BSF
17.09.1944 – 29.05.1984

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Lance Naik Mohan Lal, PMG and Constable Satwinder Singh, PMG on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting with militants in Tarn Taran area, Punjab, and later succumbed to their injuries at SGTB Hospital, Amritsar.

CONSTABLE SATWINDER SINGH, PMG
53 BN BSF
03.04.1962 – 29.05.1984

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Lance Naik Mohan Lal, PMG and Constable Satwinder Singh, PMG on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting with militants in Tarn Taran area, Punjab, and later succumbed to their injuries at SGTB Hospital, Amritsar.

LATE SEP RISHI KUMAR

In proud memory of Sep Rishi Kumar of 6th Battalion The Dogra Regiment, who made the supreme sacrifice while serving the Nation at Nowshera (J&K) on 28 May 2002. Your act of valour, raw courage & devotion to duty will always remain a source of inspiration and motivation to all of us.

"BRAVES DIE, BUT ONLY ONCE"

Remembered by Commanding Officer and All Ranks 6 DOGRA

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today your emotional experiences will be much more intense than usual. This could be due to the kinds of people or situations that you are drawn to. You also might feel possessive about property. Tonight: Check your finances.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today your attention will turn to your most personal relationships. If you have a conflict with someone close to you, it will be much more emotional. Do not allow someone else to manipulate your feelings. Tonight: Partnerships.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today you might have to put your own practical or emotional needs second to the needs of someone else. Don't be a martyr; it's simply what's happening. Tonight: Work.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Romantic possibilities are exciting today! Grab every opportunity to socialise with others. Enjoy sports events and fun activities with kids. You can't conceal your feelings from as today you will project yourself more emotionally than usual. Tonight: Play.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): It will please you today to get some time to yourself to relax among familiar surroundings, perhaps hiding out at home or enjoying your own secret hideaway place. Interactions with a female family member might be significant. Tonight: Relax.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today you have a strong desire to express your views to others, which means you need to find someone willing to listen to you. Seek out someone who can go beyond the superficial conversation. Tonight: Learn something new.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You might find that you're identifying with your possessions today, which means you won't want to lend something that you own to anyone. Tonight: Check your money.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today the Moon in your sign, can make you more emotional and gives you a slight little edge over the other signs in terms of having good luck. Ask the universe for a favour. Tonight: Be patient.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Solitude and beautiful surroundings will please you today. You'll enjoy being outdoors. Some of you might explore mystical or spiritual disciplines that are intriguing and mysterious. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today is a good day to enjoy the company of friends, groups and organisations. You might feel more protective and supportive about someone than usual. You might even feel jealous if they show someone else more attention. Tonight: Schmooze.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today the Moon is high in your chart, which means you'll attract the attention of others. Possibly, details about your most intimate and personal life are on public display. This might be as simple as a public argument. Tonight: Be modest.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today your sense of adventure is aroused, which is why you want to break free from your daily routine. Travel would be ideal, but you can also be a tourist in your own city. You might meet new friends from different backgrounds. Tonight: Adventure.

The Brihanmumbai Electric Supply & Transport Undertaking
(OF THE BRIHANMUMBAI MAHANAGARPALIKA)

TENDER NOTICE

E-tenders are Re- invited for the supply of following items.

(1) 81558, (2) 81565, (3) 81602.

Note: For more details, log on to website <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

PRO/AAM(M)/28/2026

GENERAL MANAGER

कार्यालय प्रधान महापंचायक, उज्जैन

उपग्रह राज्य औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

ई-1/4, लखनपुर, कानपुर

ई-निविदा सूचना

एनएसएल सूचित किया जाता है, कि विभिन्न औद्योगिक क्षेत्रों के अन्तर्गत विकास/अनुसंधान/उत्पत्ति/कार्य के हेतु सरकारी विभागों/सार्वजनिक उपक्रमों/विभागों/प्राधिकरणों/परिषदों/नगर निकायों में कार्यरत कर्मियों/ठेकेदारों से ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं, जिसको अपलोड करने की समय सीमा निम्नवत् है—

अंकित कार्य की निविदा दिनांक 29.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11.00 बजे से दिनांक 18.06.2026 को अपरान्ह 5.00 बजे तक अपलोड की जा सकती है, जिन्हें दिनांक 18.06.2026 को अपरान्ह 5.30 बजे खोला जायेगा (पूर्णकालिक)

निविदादाताओं द्वारा केंचन खण्ड पत्रों की मूलप्रतियाँ निविदा प्रपत्रों में उल्लिखित दिनांक तक कार्यालय में चाना की जा सकती हैं। ई-निविदा को मध्यम से आभारित की जाने वाली निविदाओं का विवरण निम्नवत् है—

क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	बि.ही.का.रु.ख.दर
1	Maintenance work for One year at Different Industrial Sector at I.A. TDS City Ghaziabad	258.17

नोट:-निविदादाता कम्पनी निविदाओं में समस्त कर सहित दरें अंकित करें। जीएएसटीडीसी अलग से देय होगा। निविदा सम्बन्धी विस्तृत जानकारी प्राधिकरण की website: <https://beta.upsidamarkeplace.com> पर स्थित ई-बिड एवं यूटिलिटी की website: <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर देखी जा सकती है। अन्य जानकारी हेतु कार्यालय के अधिक प्रबन्धक (निविदा) की सजीव कुमार मोबाइल नं. 9910017449 पर सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।

प्रधान महापंचायक, उज्जैन/आभारित, कानपुर

CENTRUM
Home Loans
Auto milkar ghar bhog

Corporate & Registered Office : Unit No. 801, Centrum House, CST Road, Vidyanagar Marg, Kalina Santacruz (East), Mumbai - 400098. CIN No. U65922MH2016PLC273826

DEMAND NOTICE

Under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation And Reconstruction Of Financial Assets And Enforcement Of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with Rule 3 (1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

The undersigned is the Authorised Officer of Centrum Housing Finance Ltd under Securitisation And Reconstruction Of Financial Assets And Enforcement Of Security Interest Act, 2002 (the said Act). In exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, the Authorised Officer has issued Demand Notices under section 13(2) of the said Act, calling upon the following Borrower/s (the said Borrower), to repay the amounts mentioned in the respective Demand Notice/s issued to them that are also given below.

In connection with above, Notice is hereby given, once again, to the said Borrower to pay to Centrum Housing Finance Ltd, within 60 days from the publication of this Notice, the amounts indicated herein below, together with further interest and other charges till date of repayment of the dues in full, as detailed in the said Demand Notices, from the dates mentioned below till the date of payment and/or realization, payable under the loan agreement read with other documents/writings, if any, executed by the said Borrowers. As security for due repayment of the loan, the following assets have been mortgaged to Centrum Housing Finance Ltd by the said Borrowers respectively.

Sr. No.	Loan Account No./ Name of the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)	Total Outstanding Dues (Rs.)	NPA Date Sec.13(2) Notice Date FCL Date	Description of secured asset (immovable property)
1	MTCRM23012774 / Vikram Singh / Sapana Kumari	Rs.5,40,274.00 (Rupees Five Lakh Fourty Thousand and Four Hundred SeventyFour Only)	10-04-2026 15-05-2026 14-05-2026	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Plot No. G-65, Khasra No. 1405/1 (Part), adm. 41.80 sqmts., Vrindavan Highway Greens Colony, Mauza Chaumuhan, Tehsil - Chhata, Distt. Mathura-281406, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Plot No. G-66 West : Plot No. G-64 North : Road 20 feet South : Plot No. G-98
2	MTCBR23014045 / Sonu Giri / Guddu Giri/Priyanka Devi	Rs.9,21,661.00 (Rupees Nine Lakh TwentyOne Thousand Six Hundred SixtyOne Only)	10-04-2026 15-05-2026 14-05-2026	"In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Khasra No. 664 (Part), adm. 292.81 sqmts., Mauza Mursana, Pargana Baran, Tehsil & Distt. Bulandshahr-203150, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Rasta 18 ft West : H/o Guddu Giri North : Prop. of Prakash GiriSouth : H/o Bhooara Giri

If the said Borrowers shall fail to make payment to Centrum Housing Finance Ltd as aforesaid, Centrum Housing Finance Ltd shall proceed against the above secured assets under Section 13(4) of the Act and the applicable Rules, entirely at the risks of the said Borrowers as to the costs and consequences. The said Borrowers are prohibited under the Act from transferring the aforesaid assets, whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of Centrum Housing Finance Ltd. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the said Act or Rules made thereunder, shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act. Place :Uttarpradesh Date :29.05.2026

Sd/-, Authorised Officer For Centrum Housing Finance Ltd

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New Delhi

CHANGE OF GUARD ON THE CARDS

Hardik set to lose Mumbai Indians captaincy

Discussion on the all-rounder's place in the side also likely; Coaches tell senior players to remain 'coachable'

Devendra Pandey & Sandeep Dwivedi
Mumbai/New Delhi, May 28

HARDIK PANDYA'S reign as Mumbai Indians captain is coming to an end. After a season in which they lost 10 of 14 games, finished ninth, and extended their title drought to six years, MI is set to overhaul its squad — starting with the captaincy.

The Indian Express, speaking to at least three persons in the MI fold, has learnt that Hardik is likely to lose the captaincy. A discussion on his place in the side is also on the cards.

"There were enough signs

during the season that the team management wasn't keen to retain him as captain. There is a clear buzz in the camp," said a source.

The immediate backdrop is a team talk by the coaching staff after MI's final game of the season against Rajasthan Royals.

"The coaching staff was very clear in their message to the senior players that wherever they play, they need to be coachable. There were many instances where the coaching staff recommended something which was backed by data but players didn't follow it," said a source.

So what is the path forward?



Hardik Pandya-captained MI finished second-last this season. AP

"There will be serious introspection and discussion in the coming days. Every option would be weighed. Many questions need to be addressed. Going ahead, can Hardik be the

captain? Does he stay in the team just as a player?" according to a MI old-timer.

The problem runs deeper than captaincy.

"We haven't been able to use

the Powerplay like some of the more successful teams this IPL. We haven't moved with the times," said another source.

The teams that made the playoffs this year — RR and Sunrisers Hyderabad — redefined T20 batting with top orders consistently going above 10 runs per over.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans showed the value of experienced bowlers: Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Josh Hazlewood, Kagiso Rabada, Mohammed Siraj. MI, with arguably the most recognisable names in the competition, looked out of sync with the modern T20 game.

None of their players featured in the race for Orange or Purple Caps.

Their best batsman Ryan Rickelton is 17th among the top run-getters. Leg-spinner Allah Ghazanfar is 14th among wicket-takers.

For a squad containing proven match-winners at every position, the numbers are difficult to explain.

Hardik's relationship with the MI terraces has always been complicated. Originally an MI find, he was released by the franchise in 2022, went to Gujarat Titans, won the IPL as captain, and returned to MI in 2024 to replace Rohit Sharma. The decision came days after Rohit had led India to the 50-over World Cup final.

The fans never forgave the optics. They booed him through his first season back, when MI finished at the bottom of the table. A partial recovery in 2025 raised hopes. The 2026 season extinguished them.

The MI players and decision-makers are currently on a break. The hard conversations, sources say, will happen when they regroup in the coming weeks.

Archer's weapons: Bouncers, heavy balls, hard lengths

Sandip G
New Delhi, May 28

THE REDEEMED Jofra Archer exudes a narrow-eyed suspicion in everything that he does this IPL. The celebrations post-wickets are a bit more celebratory. He breaks into a brisk stroll rather than a full-pelt sprint from his follow-through, sometimes contorting his index finger and thumb into the alphabet C, a reminder of his chillingly famous duel with Steve Smith in 2019 Ashes, where he concussed him with a fiendish bouncer.

He smiles apologetically; grins are exercised with restraint. He talks measuredly, churning out double-checked platitudes.

■ "How do you feel tonight?" The presenter asked him after the eliminator against SRH?

He replies: "I thought I bowled pretty alright."

■ "What about striking in the first over?"

"I take it on, and I do my best for the team."

■ "How do you plan against destructive batsmen?"

"Honestly, you've just got to hold your nerve".

It's as though he is scared of jinxing himself, as though he is telling himself to be equanimous, for his dream spell of returns could turn into a nightmare of injuries. He fears the recurrence of six injury-bodged years, wherein he fell from the heights of fame to the depths of agony. From one of the fastest bowlers, scaling the steps of greatness to the pitted one, unforgotten because of his fear-some talent.

But this IPL has been the best he has bowled since the 2019 Ashes. He is shattering toes and stumps; he is hammering arms and helmeted heads; he is bowling with heat and fire; he is not shackled by revolting muscles (even though the fear of injury lurks). He is finally producing what a raft of IPL owners and coaches wished he would be when they coughed up astronomical figures to own his signature.

The 24 wickets he has grabbed this episode is an album of pure fast-bowling delight. The 3/58 in the eliminator against Sunrisers Hyderabad was a miniature model of his repurposed prowess.

Abhishek Sharma snared by a bodyline bouncer, which was so perfectly designed the left-handed opener could not hook or pull, glance or glide, duck or weave away, or even top-edge. All he could was glove to the wicket-keeper.

Abhishek was not in a tangle, but hunched in a reactionless mess. It was the perfect bouncer to a left hander from over the stump, impossible to evade, unless it was Gordon Greenidge or Sunil Gavaskar.

In true Caribbean spirit, he has weaponized the short ball. He has coerced extra bounce from the unsuspecting surfaces, from the might of his shoulders, a minimalist energy-conserving run-up and explosive, natural power. There was another devilish short ball he had bowled this IPL, to Royal Challengers Bengaluru's batsman Phil Salt in their first meeting. The ball just climbed into from a hard length zone and rocketed into Salt, caught



With 24 wickets this season, Jofra Archer is second on the wicket-takers' list. AP

in a reactionless stupor.

Most of his wickets owe to the short or hard length devils at extreme pace. The heavy ball nailed Ishan Kishan; it hurried to him and hit the bat's splice, producing a whirring sound. A similar ball had accounted for him in their previous encounter, only that he had managed a bit more distance.

Full and good lengths too were used to devastating effect, especially with the new ball.

An in-swinging pearler out-did Tim Seifert. The ball swung in the air and seamed off the deck to shatter the stumps. Travis Head, in the league-stage, was nicked off an away-swing across him, where he squared him. He uses both the upright and wobble seam to make the deviations. The dismissal probably played in Head's head that he exposed all his stumps and tried to carve him through the cover region. Archer, probably second-guessing, hurled a full-length ball on stumps at pace. He missed the swipe and saw the stumps tattered.

Central to his most prolific IPL season has been reconciling with the reality that even good balls could go for runs.

"So your good balls are going to go for boundaries, your bad balls are going to go for boundaries as well. So you've just got to hang in there and just always keep thinking about wickets because with that first four, like trying to get through the overs, it's never going to happen," he explained. It's a difficult mindset to replicate on the field. But Archer has mastered the art of not feeling pained when getting hit.

Pace and deception

The pace, the deception, the cunning, those have always dwelled in Archer. Only that injuries (stress fractures in his right elbow and lower back, a freak right hand injury, and minor hamstring and thumb niggles), had racked his body and mind so hard that he was crippled with doubts. "I don't know whether I have another start-stop year in me," he said in 2024. The body has revived and the mind feels refreshed. "I am enjoying my bowling more (this year) than in the last few years," he said earlier this year.

It is unlikely that at 31, he would become the dreaded red-ball bowler he once was. But he could still be a hero in the IPL, make up for the lost time and reconquer the departed glory. He stands as a testament of an unbroken spirit and could be bowling his club to glory.

ANALYSING THE PRODIGY

Lack of a front-foot game is an advantage for Sooryavanshi

Renowned coach Zubin Bharucha explains the "hang back" technique that is rewriting what length means

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, May 28

VAIBHAV SOORYAVANSHI doesn't possess a pronounced front-foot game. Renowned coach Zubin Bharucha dismisses the percentages altogether. "Zero. He actually doesn't have any front foot game," Bharucha says.

It is an apparent weakness. The inability to consistently drive the ball along the ground to deep cover or long-on may be a glaring flaw on any batter's profile. Not for Sooryavanshi. His record-breaking, six-hitting avatar rests on that very contradiction.

On Wednesday in Chandigarh, Sooryavanshi began the Eliminator against Sunrisers Hyderabad needing seven sixes to overtake Chris Gayle's tally of 59 from the 2012 IPL season. He got there in 15 balls. Pat Cummins had conceded four by then. Eshan Malinga and Sakib Hussain were taken apart just as quickly. A 14-year-old record was erased by a 15-year-old in under 20 minutes.

The sixes count raced to 12 within 27 balls — equalling his own Indian record for the highest maximums in an innings, against the same opposition, within a month — before Sooryavanshi fell for 97 off 29 deliveries, agonisingly short of Gayle's record for the fastest IPL century — 30 balls. Sadness, unfamiliar on his face, blanketed him as he trudged back.

He has brutalised the leg side all season, distorted the lengths of the league's best bowlers, and maximised the powerplay like few before him. There is a method to it, one that bowling groups are scrambling to decode and plot against in real time.

The numbers tie his hang-back technique to the sixes

story. Over 76 percent of his 680 runs this season have come off pacers. The powerplay alone has fetched him 490 runs — the highest ever by any batter in a single IPL season.

His 65 sixes make up 58 percent of his total runs. Only two bowlers have delivered more than an over without being hit for a six. Jasprit Bumrah leaked two in five deliveries, including a first-ball six in their maiden duel. Bhuvneshwar Kumar conceded two in nine, as did Kagiso Rabada.

The thread that binds all of them is the same. Shorter lengths, dispatched disdainfully. Fuller balls, buried under serious heat. When hard lengths are compressing swinging arcs across the league, Sooryavanshi strikes at 244 against pace in that band. There is seemingly no release — 12 sixes when full, 16 against length, 12 against back of length, 17 when banded short.

Bharucha's explanation makes the technique visible. "He is actually changing the entire dynamics of what length means because he doesn't come forward. Even when the foot moves forward, his weight is always towards the back. Every ball becomes hittable for him: bowl full, and he'll swing through the line, bowl short, and it becomes a length ball for him."

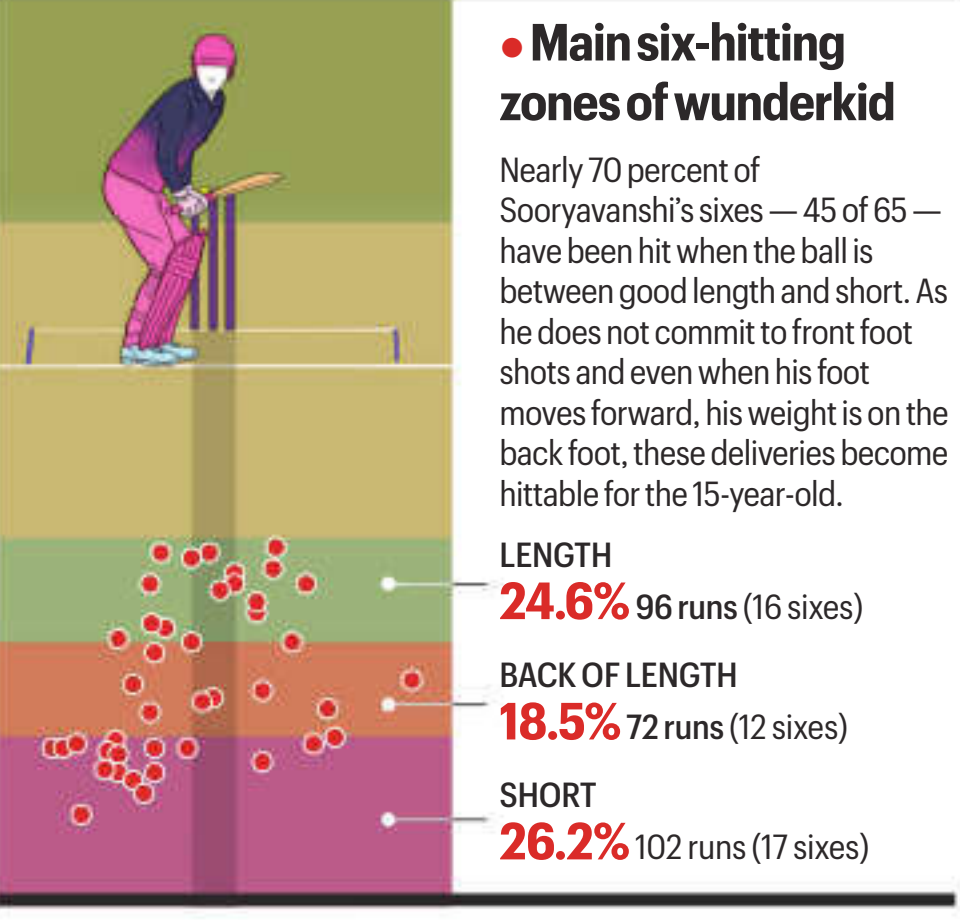
He adds: "With that huge backlift, he has got so much time on his hands that he cannot keep the bat down. So the faster the bowler bowls, the easier it is for him. You have to bowl some really special balls. You have to change the pace. You have to do all that sort of stuff to fox him."

Hook-pull range

Facing a higher percentage of short deliveries has allowed



With 65 sixes, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi went past Chris Gayle's single-season record of 59. PTI



Sooryavanshi to unfurl a tenacious hook-pull range. Over half his 65 sixes have been powered between mid-wicket and fine-leg — 34 sixes in 80 balls. Straight deliveries in the stump channel are stubbed too: 21 sixes between long-on and off at a strike rate of 281. The phenomenon extends to every

● Main six-hitting zones of wunderkid

Nearly 70 percent of Sooryavanshi's sixes — 45 of 65 — have been hit when the ball is between good length and short. As he does not commit to front foot shots and even when his foot moves forward, his weight is on the back foot, these deliveries become hittable for the 15-year-old.

LENGTH
24.6% 96 runs (16 sixes)

BACK OF LENGTH
18.5% 72 runs (12 sixes)

SHORT
26.2% 102 runs (17 sixes)

corner. With at least 15 scoring shots on every sector of the ground, his lowest strike rate is 194 in the cover region — still seven sixes in 53 balls. Even in the point region, his least productive six-hitting area with one six in 23 balls, the strike rate holds at 204.

Bowling groups have tried

everything. The slower ball had partially disrupted him earlier this season.

On Wednesday, he bided the extra second and cleared them over the ropes four times, including the record 60th six over wide long-off off his Bihar statemate Hussain. Irony has since forced the quicks to attempt deliberate full-tosses - a pace bowler's last resort against a 15-year-old.

They had subdued him to six runs in 17 balls with that approach before. In his 15th innings, after SRH served up six of them, he belted the first one over square leg.

Gayle acknowledged the arrival of the "New Six machine" on social media. The Jamaican's all-time record of 1056 T20 sixes across 17 years came at a rate of one every 9.5 balls. The Bihari phenom is already clearing them at nearly twice that rate, just 623 balls into his career. Qualifier 2 on Friday. Unusual fields, broken plans, and a teenager bending the format to his will. Zero percent front-foot game. One hundred percent problem.

● PROVING A POINT

By adding a touch of flair to his batting, Gill pushes case for T20I comeback

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, May 28

IN THE coming days, India's selectors will sit down to chalk a new path for the T20 team. The main discussion point would be Suryakumar Yadav's form, with the likes of Rajat Patidar and Shreyas Iyer breathing down his neck after a good run in the IPL.

The opening duo will be another point of discussion, with multiple options emerging and making it tough to select the best player from the lot. That discussion will also have a key question to answer: Where does Shubman Gill, India's Test and ODI captain and maker of over 600 runs in IPL 2026, stand?

Having become the T20 vice-captain in August 2025, his place in the side seemed settled. Yet, inconsistent form forced the selectors to drop the axe on him for the T20 World Cup, when the squad came out in December 2025.

It was a bold and correct decision at the time. But in IPL 2026, Gill has looked a different batsman. Not many expected Gujarat Titans (GT) to make it to the Playoffs, but by being prolific with the bat, he has led from the front.

Heading into the Qualifier 2 against Rajasthan Royals (RR) on his home ground in New Chandigarh, he has 618 runs next to him in 14 innings, with six fifties. This again isn't new. Last season, he had 650 runs



Shubman Gill has adapted to the needs of the T20 format. CREIMAS

that paved the way for his inclusion in India's Asia Cup squad. In 2023, he had 890 runs when GT made the final. In each of the last seven IPL seasons, the least he has tallied is 426.

This season, Gill has looked different in one aspect. When he was dropped from the T20 World Cup squad, apart from his form, there was another concern. He didn't have quick

hands like some of his peers did; the belief was that he wasn't tailor-made for the format, and he had to bat out of his skin to make an impact in the shortest format.

In IPL 2026, Gill has retained his usual consistency but added flair to his batting and has not shied away from playing high-risk cricket. Despite GT being top-heavy and possessing a brittle middle-order, he has hit 30 sixes, six more than last season.

In a lot of the matches, he has retained his batting elements, but gone are the days when his bat face used to close quickly at the point of contact. And more importantly, his strike-rate has increased to a career-best of 159.28 this IPL. He

has ticked the boxes that the selectors and the team management asked him to, while leading admirably in the middle.

The competitors

But, will that be enough? Others vying for the same spot have bettered him. Sai Sudharshan has 652 runs. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has 680 runs. Beyond him, there is Ishan Kishan with 602 runs. Then there are the incumbents Abhishek Sharma and Sanju Samson, who have been the backbone of India's T20 team.

On Friday, and possibly on Sunday if GT get past RR, Gill has two innings to jump the queue and be in the reckoning. It could be even one, but small margins eventually decide who's in and who's out. Given

how Indian cricket functions, if Gill ends up leading GT to their second IPL title, he may find himself in India's T20 squad. There is reason to be optimistic and accept the reality that India's requirements are totally different, like Shreyas Iyer found out last season.

It is not all doom and gloom for Gill. There are talks in Indian cricket corridors that they prefer to have one captain who leads them across all three formats. Few teams in international cricket have different ODI and T20 captains today. So, with Suryakumar struggling for runs and selectors preferring to look beyond him for the next cycle, Gill could emerge as a candidate to replace him.

That the next T20 World

Cup is scheduled to take place Down Under means there is room to accommodate at least one player who is compact than flashy, and given his strengths as a batsman — the horizontal shots, Gill fits the bill perfectly. The era of anchors may be over, but there is still a place for batsmen with compact technique.

Having been dumped, Gill hasn't sulked or refused to adapt.

Through the course of this IPL, he has shown that his T20 batting has evolved, and on Friday will come up against a phenomenon called Sooryavanshi. Comparisons will be inevitable. But this Qualifier II could well be down to competition for one spot between the two.

WFI move SC against order allowing Vinesh to compete



Vinesh Phogat. FILE

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, May 28

THE WRESTLING Federation of India (WFI) has moved the Supreme Court, challenging the Delhi High Court order that allowed Olympian wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the selection trials for the 2026 Asian Games, scheduled to be held here on Saturday.

In its Special Leave Petition (SLP), the WFI termed the Delhi High Court division bench order dated May 22 as "ex facie illegal" and argued that the federation was not given adequate opportunity to file a detailed reply before directions were issued in favour of Vinesh.

The federation said the High Court had directed inclusion of Vinesh in the trials for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya despite her allegedly being "ineligible" under the published selection criteria.

The WFI further argued that selection of athletes for international multi-sport events falls exclusively within the domain of the recognised National Sports Federation and warned against "judicial overreach" into sporting selection matters.

Giving background to the dispute, the federation stated that Vinesh had voluntarily retired from wrestling in December 2024 through communications sent to the International Testing Agency (ITA). According to the plea, under United World Wrestling (UWW) anti-doping rules read with the WADA Code, an athlete returning from retirement must undergo a mandatory six-month whereabouts and dope-testing period before becoming eligible to compete.

The WFI also referred to a "recorded missed test" allegedly registered against Vinesh on May 4 in connection with an unsuccessful testing attempt on December 18, 2025, following which a show-cause notice was issued to her on May 9.

The federation contended that the disciplinary process against the wrestler was still pending and should be allowed to reach its "logical conclusion".

The plea also said the selection policy, published in February 2026, had no provision for an "iconic player" or maternity-based exemption and maintained that selections had always been merit-and-performance based.

The WFI further submitted that 12 wrestlers in each category had already qualified for the trials on the basis of medals won at the Senior National Championships, Senior Federation Cup and Under-20 National Championships, and claimed those wrestlers were not heard before the High Court passed its order.

The federation additionally argued that the deadline for accreditation for the Asian Games had expired on May 14, prior to the High Court order, making implementation difficult.

UPSET AT ROLAND GARROS

Cerundolo stuns World No. 1 as Sinner feels the heat in Paris

The unseeded Argentine came back from two sets down to beat the Italian 3-6, 2-6, 7-5, 6-1, 6-1 in second round

Reuters
Paris, May 28

JANNIK SINNER'S bid for a maiden French Open title and career Grand Slam went up in smoke as he experienced physical issues in his second-round match against Juan Manuel Cerundolo and fell to a 3-6 2-6 7-5 6-1 6-1 defeat on a scorching Thursday. Sinner arrived in Paris as the favourite for the title having lifted claycourt titles in Monte Carlo, Madrid and Rome, with his main rival and defending champion Carlos Alcaraz ruled out with injury and Novak Djokovic searching for his best form.

But Cerundolo tore up the script in a dramatic clash where he held his nerve even as last year's runner-up Sinner crumbled while on the verge of a big win, sending shockwaves through Roland Garros.

"It's tough for him. He was winning the match. I couldn't win more than three games (in any of the first two sets)," said Cerundolo. "I think I was a little bit lucky, I feel sorry for him ... he was serving to win this match, but then I don't know what happened. I think he was cramping maybe, or maybe it was the pressure of the match, I don't know.

"But of course I feel sorry for him and I hope he recovers. I'm super happy, I'm going to keep trying to play my best... I hope to be ready for the next match."

Broken streak

Sinner's defeat ended his 30-match winning run going back to March and also

snapped the nine-Grand-Slam streak of 'Sincaraz' championship victories, but the early signs on Thursday hardly pointed to anything other than a comfortable outing.

As the temperature climbed over the 30 degrees Celsius mark for the first time in the afternoon, Sinner had already breezed through the first set on the back of a solitary break, and the 24-year-old Italian looked to be in cruise mode.

Cerundolo offered resistance towards the end of the second set, but the 56th-ranked Argentine was left with a mountain to climb after Sinner unleashed a huge forehand winner to double his lead in the match for the loss of only five games. The four-times Grand Slam champion cooled off with an ice towel in the break and turned up the intensity on his unseeded opponent in the third set to go 5-1 ahead, before he began to struggle and halted play when serving at 5-4. "In the third set I felt dizzy and I wanted to vomit but I couldn't," the Italian was heard saying to an official, before he stepped off the court for a medical timeout.

Major Upset

Sinner returned five minutes later and was immediately broken for 5-5, and dropped the next two games to hand the set to his Argentine opponent, who sensed the chance to pull off a major upset in Paris.

Hitting heavier to quicken the points and also serving and volleying frequently, Sinner looked desperate to avoid the exit but his troubles only in-



Juan Manuel Cerundolo defeated Jannik Sinner despite losing the first two sets on Thursday. AP

creased as he began to clutch his right thigh in the fourth set, which he surrendered tamely.

Quickly losing control, Sinner was broken early in the decider, as Cerundolo took full advantage to leave the Paris Grand Slam without its title favourite and Djokovic with a golden opportunity to win a standalone 25th major.

Should Djokovic miss out, Alexander Zverev looms as another top contender to finally break his Grand Slam duck after losing three major title clashes, with several other dark horses also looking to capitalise. Jannik Sinner said his lack of energy in a stunning French Open loss on Thursday was down to a combination of factors including a long clay-court swing, during which he played and won three successive events to arrive as the favourite in Paris.

Sinner, who was targeting a

maiden French Open title and career Grand Slam in the absence of his injured rival Carlos Alcaraz, was hampered by illness for a 3-6 2-6 7-5 6-1 6-1 second-round defeat by Juan Manuel Cerundolo.

After titles in Monte Carlo, Madrid and Rome, and a comfortable victory in his Paris opener, Sinner fell flat on Court Philippe Chatrier.

"In general, many things came together... I played a lot and I didn't have a lot of time to recover," Sinner said in a packed press conference room.

"I came here, first match, really good, really solid... even though I finished late, but not crazy late.

"This morning I didn't sleep well. When I woke up, I was struggling a bit, but this can happen. Usually in Grand Slams you have a couple of days where you don't feel perfect.

"That was today."

While heat and humidity have often tripped up Sinner during big events, the world number one, who hails from northern Italy's South Tyrol, said he was at ease in Paris despite the mercury going past 30 degrees Celsius.

"Shanghai (in October) was very tough. The humidity was high," Sinner said about his retirement in the Chinese city.

"Australia was very warm (this year), I remember. It's different when you play on hardcourts, because the heat also comes from underneath," Sinner explained.

"Here, it was warm, but it was okay. It wasn't like I was dying because of the heat. Today, it was a completely different scenario, but this can happen. It's tough to accept, of course, because of the position I've been in and everything considered, but now I have a lot of time to recover."

Why RG staff are turning to salt to save the clay

Express News Service
Mumbai, May 28

FOR DECADES, clay courts have been associated with long rallies, high bounces and physically-draining tennis. But at this year's French Open, players have often said Roland Garros is playing faster than usual.

The reason is not a change in balls or court construction alone — it is the weather.

Paris is currently experiencing an unusually intense early-summer heatwave, with temperatures crossing 35°C during the opening week of the tournament. Groundskeepers say the conditions are unlike anything they have dealt with in late May.

"What we're experiencing is unprecedented," Philippe Vaillant, head of court maintenance at Roland Garros, told the Associated Press. "Even the weather services say it themselves: it's unprecedented to have temperatures this high for such a long period at this time of year." The heat is fundamentally altering how the clay behaves,

Weather's impact

Clay courts are moisture-dependent surfaces. Unlike hard courts, their playing characteristics are directly tied to how much water is retained beneath the top layer of crushed brick. When temperatures rise sharply, moisture evaporates faster. The surface becomes drier and harder, which changes the speed and bounce of the ball. Players at Roland Garros have already noticed the difference.

World No.1 Aryna Sabalenka said the conditions were "boiling hot" and that "balls are flying, everything is much faster."

Traditionally, clay slows the ball down because moisture creates more friction between the surface and the ball. But dry clay reduces that resistance. The bounce becomes quicker and lower, favouring aggressive baseline hitting over attritional rallying. The shift is significant because Roland Garros has historically had the slowest Grand Slam surface. This year, players are increasingly comparing conditions to hard courts during afternoon sessions.



Jannik Sinner struggling during his match on Thursday. AP

Red clay's science

What appears to spectators as a simple layer of red dirt is actually a complex five-layer structure nearly 80 centimetres deep. At Roland Garros, the courts are built using large foundation stones, gravel, volcanic rock residue, compacted limestone, and finally a thin layer of crushed red brick.

According to Vaillant, the limestone layer is the most critical component because it retains moisture and provides structural stability. The red brick layer is mainly cosmetic

and helps players slide. If the limestone dries out excessively, the court can crack. More importantly, the surface becomes dangerously slippery. Vaillant compared overly dry courts to an ice rink, warning that players could lose their footing while sliding into shots.

"The crushed brick layer is 3 to 5 millimetres thick," Vaillant explained. "The most important part is the limestone layer underneath. That's the actual playing foundation. This limestone layer must remain moist at all times. It's compacted crushed stone maintained through water supply. If we let it dry out too much, the courts could crack."

The red brick layer, meanwhile, serves a different purpose. "The crushed brick is mainly there for colour and as a material that provides some sliding ability and an important visual contrast, since the limestone is almost white," Vaillant said.

Keeping courts alive

To combat the heat, tournament staff have dramatically altered maintenance routines. "We're forced to water the courts a little more, of course,"

Vaillant said.

Normally, clay courts are watered at fixed intervals. This year, groundskeepers are soaking the courts every evening to replenish moisture deep beneath the surface. During matches, courts are also being lightly watered between sets — something rarely required under standard French Open conditions.

Another key tool is calcium chloride, a salt compound spread across the courts in flake form each morning. "This is basically just salt," Vaillant said. "We spread it over the courts in flake form in the morning. It melts on contact with water and helps retain surface moisture."

The compound slows evaporation and helps the courts retain consistency through long matches played in direct sun. Groundskeepers say the substance effectively "reactivates" moisture in the crushed brick layer during the day.

The maintenance operation is massive. Around 200 groundskeepers are working across 18 competition courts and 15 practice courts during the tournament.

Pragg defeats Carlsen on his home turf but says it's not a 'big win'



R Praggnanandhaa was not pleased with the manner of his victory over Magnus Carlsen. MICHAL WALUSZA/NORWAY CHESS

Amit Kamath
Oslo, May 28

ANOTHER EDITION of Norway Chess saw another triumph for a member of India's golden generation over the world's greatest chess player of the current era. Wednesday saw R Praggnanandhaa hand one more defeat to Magnus Carlsen at what is the Norwegian's home tournament. The third round victory came two years after Pragg had beaten the World No 1 at the same tournament in what was his first classical victory over Carlsen. At last year's Norway Chess, world champion Gukesh had earned his first Carlsen scalp in classical chess.

Carlsen does not dabble in too much classical chess these days. Norway Chess, in fact, is the one of those rare times in a year that he makes an exception to his aversion to playing the longest format of the sport. But even then, a victory in classical chess over Carlsen, who has been uninterrupted World No 1 since July 2011, is cause for celebration no matter how it arrives. Pragg disagrees. "Honestly, I don't think it's such a big win," shrugged Praggnanandhaa in a conversation with the Indian media at Oslo moments after he had forced Carlsen to resign after the 46th move. "I got lucky at the end."

There are at least 18 decent moves for white on move 6 in that position," Carlsen said in the confession booth. "And yet I managed to get surprised."

As the battle entered the middle game, things heated up.

"We both wanted to fight today," Pragg said. "That's why we saw this crazy fight... I don't know what was happening. At some point I lost control."

Pragg was not the only one. Wednesday's third round clash saw both players go blunder for blunder after the game entered a wild time scramble at the end. Partly responsible for the game descending into a blunder-fest was the Norway Chess' unique time control: each player had 120 minutes at the start with an increment of 10 seconds coming into play only from move 41.

"In this time control when you are down to seconds it's just a gamble," said Pragg.

By the 37th move (37...g4), Pragg thought he was "busted". But with both players down to the bare minimum on their clocks, blunders arrived from both ends. Eventually, Carlsen threw in the towel to hand Pragg another classical victory.

Over the span of three rounds, Carlsen has dropped 13 rating points in Oslo. The man who was once invincible has looked human so far. A day after Pragg's triumph, Gukesh will try his luck against Carlsen in round 4. Once again, expect a street fight.

The game started with Carlsen and Pragg both opting to spend 25 seconds each before making their first move. The World No 1 theatrically adjusted all his pieces in response

to Pragg playing 1.e4. Then, he opted to pick a fight by choosing the Sicilian Defence with black. Pragg was happy to accept the challenge.

It was a facsimile of the battle the duo had at Norway Chess 2024 when Carlsen had picked a fight with black pieces — that time going for the riskier Paulsen Variation of the Sicilian — and lost. Back on that day two years ago, while Carlsen and Pragg duelled over the board, Hikaru Nakamura had taken one look at their game and walked into the confession booth to lament: "I wish Magnus would take these chances against me or Fabi (Caruana). When Magnus is playing the younger kids specifically he wants to sort of prove a point, he takes far more risks than he does against us old folks!"

On Wednesday, both Carlsen and Pragg wanted to prove a point. Pragg's first throw of the dice came as early as the 6th move, when he played h4, which caught Carlsen off guard.

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THE WRITER IS IN OSLO ON THE INVITATION OF NORWAY CHESS

Neymar set to miss World Cup opener

Reuters
Rio de Janeiro, May 28

NEYMAR HAS been ruled out of Brazil's upcoming friendlies and is set to miss their World Cup opener after scans revealed a grade-two calf injury, the Brazilian Football Confederation (CBF) said on Thursday. CBF doctor Rodrigo Lasmar delivered the blow ahead of a players' press conference, confirming the 34-year-old forward faces two to three more weeks on the sidelines.

"Neymar reported for duty yesterday here at Granja Comary, underwent all the medical tests, which concluded with an MRI scan revealing a grade-two calf injury, not just swelling. He is expected to be cleared in two to three weeks," Lasmar said.

Neymar could be dropped from the squad.

He had joined the team on Tuesday but missed Wednesday's first training session and was sent to a private clinic in Teresopolis for imaging tests after complaints of swelling in his right calf.

According to Lasmar, the MRI showed no swelling, as previously reported, but a Grade 2 calf strain — a moderate injury involving a partial tear of the muscle fibers that requires rest and rehabilitation. The diagnosis differs from that presented by Santos prior to the squad announcement. The club's doctor Rodrigo Zoagaib had stated the problem was merely swelling and that Neymar would arrive fit to begin training on Tuesday.

Brazil are in Group C also alongside Haiti and Scotland.

● SINGAPORE OPEN SUPER 750

Tanisha-Dhruv serve up a treat, stun multiple Oly medallist

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, May 28

JWALA GUTTA had once said she picked Ashwini Ponappa as a partner not because of her smashes, which were excellent, but due to her serves. Now, Tanisha Crasto, hoping to reach Jwala's heights in mixed doubles (the latter reached World No. 6 with V Diju), is proving why a swell serving game can literally win matches. To get to match point at the Singapore Open, Tanisha sent a bamboozler that confounded none less than Yuta Watanabe — a seemingly benign backhand wobble serve that left the Japanese skill-master confused.

Watanabe is a twice Olympic medallist and four-time World Championships podium finisher, including two silver medals in mixed doubles. The Japanese 28-year-old isn't

easily frazzled. The two hooting serves at the end were just the finishing touches.

Tanisha's explosive bursts, as she strikes a whisk-like rotating pattern with Dhruv Kapila and goes about creating chances while never giving up, has been one of Indian badminton's most underrated possessions.

On Thursday, at the Super 750, Tanisha and Dhruv lost the opening game, before bouncing back to beat Watanabe and Maya Taguchi 8-21, 21-17, 21-16 and reach the quarterfinals.

Already an Olympian in women's doubles and of versatile utility in team events, Tanisha not had the easiest times, given her reactive-reflexive high-risk game, which can cop a fair amount of errors. But she thrives in the chaos that mixed doubles tends to be, doesn't get afraid of front-court confrontations, and can surprise oppo-



Dhruv Kapila (L) and Tanisha Crasto in action. BADMINTON PHOTO

nents when she actually gets into textbook patterns.

Dhruv is more methodical, the muscle from the back, who creates openings for Tanisha, but has a good understanding of forecourt exchanges too. His accuracy varies and injury concerns bog him down, but together they have the potential to pierce the top tier of mixed

doubles someday.

After losing the opener 21-8 to Watanabe-Taguchi, the Indians ensured an early lead in the second. Tanisha would send one over the Japanese heads to reach 11-8, but it was in breaking the 14-14 deadlock that Tanisha showed the first signs of her audacity. She went after Watanabe with her angled smashes

smacking one into his ribcage.

She would pop up the shuttle at the net making a Watanabe kill difficult, to go up 18-14. A Taguchi service error gave the Indians game point to level matters. But it was Tanisha who once again made the shuttle pop up like a champagne cork, using her racquet frame, that gave them the game 21-17.

The Indians, not technically the most refined, were merely staying afloat till 9-11 in the decider. In some rallies — like the one to get to 12-11 — Tanisha's only job was to scream panicked prods to Dhruv to take the shuttle, as he did all the work. There is no unspoken understanding or some poetic connection between these two that makes them a good pairing — just clear (and loud) communication where a 'Dhruv' or 'Me!' is yelled out by Tanisha, when then, for the shuttle. But the

ruckus brings decisiveness.

At 16-12, the perfect game came together. Dhruv managed to use his power to push both Watanabe and Taguchi to the back court, and Tanisha smartly turned her racquet head for a cross-drop to the forecourt empty space.

Still the Japanese reached 16-17. It's when Tanisha attacked Taguchi's serve savagely with an upright backhand return to create a melee. To get to 20-16, Tanisha sent a trick serve that saw Watanabe fumble. And on the third shot of the next point, it was once more her awkwardly exchanged return that drew out an error. The piercing war cry followed.

In other Indian results, PV Sindhu defeated Riko Gunji while Kunlavut Vitidsarn gave a walkover to Lakshya Sen. HS Prannoy lost a tight match to local boy Loh Kean Yew.